

Readers make their case for which vehicle is best

Most people chose affordable and popular cars, but some answers may be surprising. **In Money**

Column: Oregon, Texas coaches one in the same

Toppmeyer looks at differences between Ducks' Lanning and Longhorns' Sarkisian. **In Sports**

Director and actress unpack 'Miasma'

Filmmaker Jane Schoenbrun, left, and star Hannah Einbinder get real about queer horror movie, intimacy and identity. **In Life**

USA TODAY

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NATHANIAL GARY/USA TODAY

E2



DOLLY PARTON 1946-2026

LOVE, ALWAYS

Legendary singer, songwriter, actress, businesswoman, philanthropist dies at 80

Dolly Parton, the country music icon with a personality as bold as her signature blond coif and rhinestone-encrusted outfits, died Tuesday, Aug. 25. She was 80 years old. The music legend was known for hits such as “Jolene,” “I Will Always Love You,” “9 to 5” and “Coat of Many Colors.”

For more coverage, including tributes, videos and photos, visit usatoday.com

Dolly Parton poses in New York City backstage at the Marquis Theatre in 2009. News of her death was shared in a video message from her family Aug. 25.

TODD PLITT FOR USA TODAY

Did colonists have formal British accents?

Phaedra Trethan
USA TODAY

Did loyalists to the English crown think that George Washington, John Adams and Ben Franklin were a bunch of *snollygosters* and *belswaggers* *brabbling* as they *droiled* and *desudated* in the July heat?

Did their hearts *ake*, missing the *wimmin* and *dawters* they left at home as they fought for what they *beleev*?

Confused? If a 21st-century American heard the way people spoke during the Revolutionary period, they'd hear a lot of words and phrases that sounded

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Samantha Ricchiuti, left, portrays Betsy Ross for Historic Philadelphia. Ross was raised a Quaker, she explained, and used the sect's "plain speech." PROVIDED BY NICK ANTHONY

Elections swiveling on data centers

Public backlash has leaders changing tune

Phillip M. Bailey
USA TODAY

Populist opposition to data centers fueling the boom in artificial intelligence is scrambling up the 2026 mid-terms, cutting across ideological lines.

Americans from the urban cores to rural outskirts are objecting to the facilities, which house the servers and networking equipment used for AI and other digital services.

A Gallup survey released earlier this year found roughly 71% of adults in the United States oppose building the centers in their area, and barely one-quarter favored the projects. That has spurred a noticeable pivot from elected leaders.

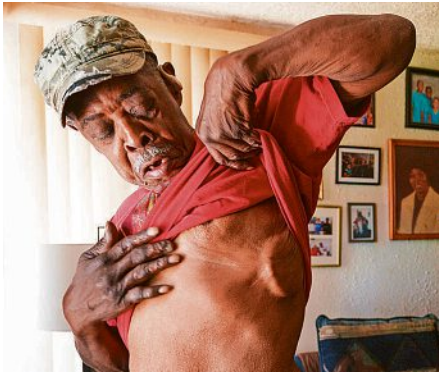
Chief among them is Texas Gov. Greg Abbott, a Republican, who issued new directives ending certain tax incentives, curtailing water and energy consumption, and releasing guidelines tech companies must follow to help lower electricity costs.

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Where top politicians stand: A look at what Trump, DeSantis, Ossoff, others say about data centers. **2A**

IN OPINION

Misplaced concerns: Argument over water and energy use misunderstood, columnist Dace Potas writes. **7A**



Timothy Holmes had to buy a generator to keep his pacemaker online after a storm hit Gary, Indiana. MICHAEL CLUBB/USA TODAY NETWORK

2 weeks with no power feels like 'end times' in Gary, Indiana

Sophie Hartley
Indianapolis Star
USA TODAY NETWORK

GARY, IN – After massive storms ripped through northwest Indiana and knocked out power on Aug. 11, Latasha Montgomery assumed she and more than 370,000 people in the area would soon have electricity restored.

Nearly two weeks later, Montgomery and thousands of other Indiana residents are still living in the dark.

“Now, it’s been 12 days. I don’t even know how to really grasp that,” said Montgomery, who lives with her three children in a home on Gary’s east side. “It really feels like the end times.”

Families lost hundreds of dollars in spoiled food after refrigerator temperatures rose. Some tried to salvage deep freezers full of food to no avail. People started washing their laundry by hand. Schools closed, forcing working

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Data centers becoming an election issue

Politicians tread carefully as voter concerns grow

Zachary Schermele
USA TODAY

Grassroots backlash to data centers has emerged as a defining issue on both the midterm election campaign trail and in American politics more broadly.

The massive hubs, which house the technological infrastructure needed to run artificial intelligence programs, have generated wariness among voters in both parties who are worried about higher energy bills and environmental impacts including constant noise and water usage.

While President Donald Trump has largely supported the data center boom – saying on Aug. 23 that communities rejecting data centers are “making a mistake” – he has slightly tweaked his largely pro-industry stance on the issue, giving Republicans permission to oppose them.

“I want them to do what they want. Some people feel differently,” he told reporters on Aug. 21. “If a Republican’s against a data center, that’s OK with me.”

Here’s where major national figures in both parties stand on the controversial subject:

Donald Trump

Trump is mostly a proponent of data centers. A New York native, he has fiercely criticized the Empire State’s Democratic Gov. Kathy Hochul for implementing a temporary one-year moratorium on their construction in July.

The president said in a radio interview last week with his former personal lawyer Michael Cohen that data centers lead to “tremendous tax revenue coming into the towns and cities that want them.”

“Frankly, communities that don’t take a data center, they’re making a mistake because there’s plenty of communities that want them,” he said.

At the same time, he has acknowledged that “not every location’s perfect for it.”

Ron DeSantis and Byron Donalds

Florida Gov. Ron DeSantis, another 2024 Republican presidential contender, has taken a much more skeptical view.



Trump says data centers and power plants bring jobs, tax revenue and growth, urging communities to welcome new development. But he has moderated his stance, allowing Republicans to oppose them. POOL

“I want them to do what they want. Some people feel differently. If a Republican’s against a data center, that’s OK with me.”

President Donald Trump

He signed a data center regulation bill on May 7 that he said ensures local governments still can reject data center development in their communities while trying to prevent costs from being passed on to consumers, including via utility bills.

The law, SB 484, also aims to protect Florida’s water resources and requires public disclosure of data center deals after a period of time, DeSantis said.

“You should not, as a hardworking Floridian, have to subsidize some of the wealthiest companies in the history of humanity,” he said while enacting the legislation.

Rep. Byron Donalds, the Republican congressman running to replace DeSantis as governor, has led with less skepti-

cism about data centers.

Although he has acknowledged they shouldn’t saddle consumers with higher costs of living.

When discussing AI developments in a February podcast interview, he said AI generally would ultimately make the economy “far more efficient.”

“I know the concerns about displacement, but with every change in our economy, there are always concerns about displacement,” he said.

Jon Ossoff

Sen. Jon Ossoff, the Georgia Democrat running for reelection in one of the country’s most competitive Senate races, has taken a cautious approach to data centers. Similar to Donalds, the rumored 2028 presidential aspirant has stressed that ratepayers shouldn’t suffer financially because of them.

He wrote a letter to the chair of the Federal Energy Reserve Commission in April saying his office was looking into how his state’s billions in investment in AI was affecting energy costs.

Josh Shapiro

While running for reelection, Josh

Shapiro, the Democratic governor of Pennsylvania and an expected 2028 presidential contender, has shifted his tone as public opinion has soured on AI infrastructure. Just more than a year ago, he touted Amazon’s decision to build data centers in his state, saying the choice proved his administration could “work at the speed of business.”

More recently, though, he said he has heard concerns “loud and clear from the good people of Pennsylvania.” He signed an executive order this month to bind developers by specific guidelines related to shouldering energy costs and preserving water, and said they’d no longer be eligible for a fast-track permit.

“We will not be bullied by developers and bulldozed by the lawyers working for these big tech companies,” he said.

Kathy Hochul

Hochul planted an early flag in the AI debate when she banned hyperscale data center construction for a year.

Similar measures have taken off in roughly a dozen other states, according to the National Conference of State Legislatures.

Contributing: Bart Jansen and Philip Bailey

Data centers

Continued from Page 1A

The order will temporarily halt about 1,800 data center projects in Texas.

“I established guidelines [and] guardrails to protect Texas communities,” Abbott said in a post on X in August. “These guidelines are now the universally applied standard in Texas.”

Abbott’s shift came less than a year after the governor, 68, faces reelection this year, praised Google for a \$40 billion data center investment in the state. He said it would make the Lone Star State an “epicenter of AI development.”

The change in tone also coincided with Democratic gubernatorial candidate Gina Hinojosa pounding Abbott for letting tech companies into the state with little oversight.

“I’m calling on Greg Abbott to issue a moratorium on any new data centers with an emergency executive order to do so,” Hinojosa, a state lawmaker, said in a virtual news conference in July.

“He has the sole power to do it,” she added. “That moratorium should stand until the Legislature can convene and make sure any data center being built is done so by American union labor that is licensed. We also want local control of the work.”

Swing state candidates are rethinking their stance

Across the United States, opponents of data centers have expressed fury at local public officials about the strain on water and electricity resources but also the disruption to communities because

of noise and pollution.

Polling by Gallup found the effect on resources was the leading reason for opposition, with 50% of respondents mentioning environmental concerns.

Opposition also cuts across every major demographic, including party affiliation, the survey found, but with Democrats at 56% strongly opposed versus Republicans at 39%. Independent voters’ opposition sat at 48%, Gallup found.

That has spurred a sprint by Democratic and Republican candidates running this year who appear to be recalibrating their positions on data centers as states and local governments rush to come up with new rules and regulations.

‘Putting developers on notice’

Pennsylvania Gov. Josh Shapiro, a rumored 2028 presidential hopeful on the Democratic side, signed an executive order Aug. 18 requiring local approval before any state grants are awarded to data center developers.

In May he had cast the telecommunication facilities as a major economic project that would “lead on innovation.”

“I’m putting these developers on notice and letting them know that we will not let them bully Pennsylvanians, disregard our constitutional right to clean air and pure water, and drive up our utility bills,” Shapiro said in a post on X.

In the Wisconsin race for governor between Democrat David Crowley and Republican Tom Tiffany, both are looking to leverage the controversial construction boom against their opponent.

Tiffany blitzed the contest with seven figures’ worth of ads describing his rival

as “Data Center David Crowley,” hoping to build a wedge. In the Democratic primary, Crowley’s foe, state Rep. Francesca Hong, a democratic socialist, was the only candidate who called for a moratorium on construction of new data centers in the Badger State.

In response to the Republican attacks, Crowley has spotlighted Tiffany’s voting record in Congress that sought to make it easier to build projects like data centers. The two oppose statewide moratoriums, but both say they want stricter regulations on such developments moving forward.

Trump: A ‘cash cow’ for states

The populist tidal wave over data centers has yet to reach the shores of the White House, where President Donald Trump defended their construction as a “cash cow” for states that embrace them.

“All of this Income, and other benefits, will be going to red States, and some blue, where data centers are sought as cash cows, with lower taxes and record setting jobs,” Trump wrote in a Truth Social post July 15.

Trump’s sentiments echo the feelings of industry leaders who tout the technology’s revolutionary capabilities they argue will power growth. Among those who support fueling AI with these facilities, about two-thirds cite the local economic benefits, according to the Gallup survey.

But the president’s support for data centers is at odds with the advice GOP candidates seeking election this year are being given.

In a memo Aug. 18, the National Republican Senatorial Committee, the

campaign arm for GOP contenders, noted that the data center backlash is hurting incumbent Sen. Jon Husted of Ohio in his closely watched bid against former Sen. Sherrod Brown.

“More than any other thing in this race, data centers are the anchor hanging around Husted’s neck,” the memo said. “If he loses and data centers get the blame, politicians across the country will take notice – and they will not go near the next one.”

The memo dropped almost two weeks after Brown, who once applauded an Amazon data center, released a 30-second spot claiming Husted “forced” the facilities in Ohio, which is home to more than 200 existing or in-development data centers, according to Data Center Map.

As lieutenant governor, Husted championed data center projects and called Ohio the “tech capital of the Midwest.” Now he contends data centers should be a local decision and introduced federal legislation that aims to ensure companies pay for the facilities’ electricity.

Republican strategists in the memo said data centers have become an effective messaging strategy for Democrats.

“Campaigns or party committees can not fix the toxic brand of an entire segment of the economy,” the memo said. “The companies that need these projects built have to fix how Ohioans see them: who benefits, who pays, and why a community should want one. Until that happens, the issue will continue to dominate this race.”

Contributing: Joey Garrison, USA TODAY; Kristian Jaime, El Paso Times; Molly Beck, Milwaukee Journal Sentinel; and Haley BeMiller, Columbus Dispatch



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Justices give Trump a win in dispute over mail-in ballots

But part of order still on hold as fight goes on

Maureen Groppe
USA TODAY

WASHINGTON – The Supreme Court said lower courts moved too soon when they partly paused President Donald Trump’s executive order cracking down on mail-in ballots before November’s midterm elections, which will decide control of Congress.

The court agreed with Trump on Aug. 24 that parts of the policy were prematurely put on hold before the administration had finalized rules for how it would be implemented. The decision lifted a lower court ruling that had blocked those provisions from moving forward for now in nearly half the states that challenged them.

But the most important part of the executive order – a new role for the U.S. Postal Service – remains on hold nationwide through a separate lower court ruling in a different case brought by voting rights groups.

And the Supreme Court’s decision does not prevent the states from renewing their challenge once the administration begins putting new rules in place.

That means it remains uncertain how much of Trump’s executive order will move forward in time for the rapidly approaching midterms.

“Today, the U.S. Supreme Court opened the door for the Trump Administration to try to make it harder for Americans to vote. But today’s decision was not a ruling on the merits, and this fight is far from over,” California Attorney General Rob Bonta said in a statement.

‘Time will tell’ if Trump’s order is lawful

The order Trump signed in March directs agencies to compile a list of confirmed U.S. citizens eligible to vote in each state and to use federal data to help state election officials verify which voters are eligible.

The Postal Service would oversee mail-in voting, establishing “uniform standards” for the ballots and requiring states to provide lists of verified voters.

In an opinion divided along ideological lines, the court said its decision “does not mean that any measure taken by the Government to implement the Order will necessarily be lawful.”

“On that score, time will tell,” the majority wrote in the unsigned opinion.

The court’s three liberal justices dissented.

Justice Ketanji Brown Jackson said the decision “lets another shoe drop in the Kafkaesque nightmare that our precedents have been steadily creating for certain plaintiffs who seek to bring election-related challenges.”

“To be sure, the Court has not foreclosed States from challenging this blatantly unconstitutional Order,” Jackson wrote in her dissent. “But it declines to



Election workers extract mail-in ballots at the registrar of voters’ office during the California primary election in San Diego on June 2. MIKE BLAKE/REUTERS

explain when, exactly, is the right time to bring a meritorious election-rule claim challenging unconstitutional interference with electoral processes.”

Trump’s order partly blocked by lower courts

In June, a federal judge in Boston ruled parts of the order were unconstitutional. U.S. District Judge Indira Talwani said those components can’t be enforced this year in the 23 states, plus the District of Columbia, that sued over the order while the legal fight continues.

The administration argued the states’ lawsuit was premature because the executive order had not been fully implemented.

When an appeals court disagreed, the administration asked the Supreme Court to intervene.

As that request was pending, Talwani blocked the Postal Service from carrying out Trump’s directive in any state in response to a separate legal challenge brought by voting rights groups. Also, the Postal Service finalized its proposal for implementing the order.

The Justice Department described the rules as “modest requirements for preparation and envelope design” for mailed ballots that are well within the Postal Service’s traditional scope of setting mailing standards “for particularly sensitive types of mail.”

States do not have to use the U.S. mail to conduct their elections, the Postal Service said. But for the states that do, the agency said it can take steps to “improve operational efficiency and support the faithful execution of federal law.”

A dozen Republican-led states backed the administration in a separate filing asking the Supreme Court to restore Trump’s full executive order.

The blue and swing states challenging the order said allowing the changes to take effect before the midterms could result in millions of people being denied the right to vote because of the “high risk for errors and the limited window

for correcting mistakes.”

Voting rights groups have said the administration wants to “weaponize” the Postal Service to force states to violate voters’ privacy by getting access to personal information in voter files.

Mailed ballots are a key fight before consequential elections

The fight over what rules govern absentee ballots could be crucial for the 2026 midterms, which will determine which party controls Congress. Democrats can take control by flipping a handful of House and Senate seats.

Voting by mail has decreased since its peak during the COVID-19 pandemic. But nearly 30% of voters still cast a ballot that way in the 2024 elections.

Democrats are more likely than Republicans to vote by mail, according to the MIT Election Data & Science Lab.

Under the Constitution, states are assigned the role of administering federal elections. But Trump has called for greater federal control of the process since losing his 2020 reelection bid. He has continued to claim he lost because of widespread voter fraud and has continued to vote by mail himself.

In July, the Boston-based 1st U.S. Circuit Court of Appeals said Trump’s executive order is already straining states, which must prepare on a tight calendar for the changes. The appeals court also said the order “would sow confusion and threaten disenfranchisement of many eligible voters” if allowed to take effect for the November elections.

In addition to his March executive order, Trump has proposed legislation to require voters to provide identification at polling places and proof of citizenship when registering as part of a broader bill, but it has stalled in Congress.

And judges have blocked another executive order that would have required potential voters to present documentation proving their citizenship before registering.

Judge won’t toss Maxwell’s Epstein-related convictions

Bart Jansen
USA TODAY

A federal judge rejected Ghislaine Maxwell’s request to throw out her five felony convictions from her association with sex offender Jeffrey Epstein.

Maxwell was convicted of what U.S. District Judge Paul Engelmayer called “the sexual abuse of young girls over the course of a decade” and that “trial evidence of her guilt that was overwhelming.”

“Maxwell’s claims are all meritless and all or almost all are frivolous,” Engelmayer wrote in denying her request.

Maxwell, 64, is serving a 20-year prison sentence for helping Epstein, who died in prison in August 2019. She represented herself in challenging her December 2021 conviction.

The Epstein case remains contentious because the Justice Department has refused to release all the documents associated with his investigation, despite Congress approving a law demanding they be made public.

Attorney General Todd Blanche has said all relevant documents have been released, but women who said they were abused by Epstein still push for the names of possible accomplices.

Maxwell was moved from a federal prison in Florida to a lower-security facility in Texas after meeting with Blanche when he was deputy attorney general.

Her lawyers asked the Supreme Court to overturn her conviction while seeking a pardon or commutation for her from President Donald Trump in exchange for her cooperation in the Epstein investigation and broader sex trafficking issues.

Engelmayer ruled that Maxwell’s purported “new” evidence from the release of 3 million documents related to Epstein were “largely irrelevant” and didn’t “support her claims of error.”

“On the contrary, to the extent it is relevant, far from exculpating her, it incriminates her or reinforces the correctness of the legal rulings Maxwell challenges,” Engelmayer wrote.

The Supreme Court rejected Maxwell’s appeal in October 2025.

Judge: Maxwell claims ‘meritless’

In asking Engelmayer to reconsider her case, Maxwell made six new claims the judge said she should have raised in her appeal. Maxwell argued that the lawyers of women who accused Epstein acted like prosecutors, that inaccurate evidence at trial created the impression she profited from her conspiracy, and that Epstein’s contact book should have been excluded from the trial.

Engelmayer said she hadn’t shown that the arguments would have yielded a different outcome.

“On the contrary, these claims are blatantly meritless,” Engelmayer wrote.

‘Operation Economic Outcast’ designed to isolate Iran

Bessent unveils plan to ‘tighten the noose’

Francesca Chambers
and Joey Garrison
USA TODAY

WASHINGTON – Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent announced the United States is launching an “economic onslaught” against Iran with the goal of severing every economic lifeline the country has so Tehran is forced to choose between global isolation and an agreement with the Trump administration.

Bessent said that starting Aug. 24, the Treasury Department and other federal agencies would “tighten the noose and block every potential source of revenue that funds” the regime and Iran’s military, beginning with additional sanctions on Tehran.

“We are enforcing a zero-leakage approach,” Bessent said. “There will be no minimal breathing space for the regime to rebuild its capacity to inflict terror against America and the world.”

Countries that are financially connected to Iran have been contacted by the administration, he said, but would immediately face secondary sanctions, an action the treasury chief acknowledged could throw the global financial system into turmoil.

The remarks came more than a week of warnings from Bessent and President



Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent announces further sanctions against Iran at a news conference on Aug. 24. EVELYN HOCKSTEIN/REUTERS

Donald Trump that hefty sanctions were on the way for nations that do business with Iran as the U.S. shifts its focus from a military bombardment to economic strangulation six months into the conflict. Trump has referred to it as an “economic D-Day” and pledged to punish any nation that allows Iran to use its financial institutions.

Oil purchases, cash transfers, swap lines and ship registries were among the list of actions Trump listed as triggers.

At a news conference at Treasury headquarters, Bessent announced Operation Economic Outcast, calling it “an unprecedented campaign against the Islamic Republic of Iran and its neighbors” and likening it to U.S. efforts to end World War II.

“In the Second World War, D-Day marked the historic beginning of a cam-

paign with our allies to target and drive the enemy from its positions,” Bessent said, “Today, in that same spirit, we are launching an economic onslaught against Iran’s financial connections around the globe.”

Nations that have any economic interaction with Iran should expect to share the country’s isolation, Bessent said. Treasury, State Department and Pentagon teams are meeting with individual nations to give them specific timelines for action, he said.

Trump is also calling world leaders who interact with the Iranian regime, Bessent said. He declined to say which ones.

“We are giving everyone the opportunity to remedy bad behavior. Why would I want to blow up the global financial system?” Bessent told a reporter who pointed out that the United States did not declare its intentions before D-Day in 1944.

The United States is setting expectations and providing a “cure period” because it does not take the imposition of secondary sanctions lightly, Bessent said. “But they should know that that will move very quickly, and we are serious,” he added, calling the actions a “warning shot.”

U.S. targets ‘Iran’s enablers’

Bessent said the United States is also sanctioning 60 entities, individuals and vessels around the world that he said

enable the Iranian regime to procure illicit nuclear and missile technology, conduct cyber operations and generate oil revenue.

“This is a sustained campaign to collapse every last option for Iran,” Bessent said. “Let there be no ambiguity as to the position of the United States: An economic engagement of any kind with this murderous regime will expose those responsible to the full reach of American power.”

Bessent directed much of his comments at “Iran’s enablers” – countries he accused of helping finance Tehran’s military campaign through the purchase and transportation of petroleum. The United States is also warning nations that facilitate trade with and welcome flights from Iran.

Though the nations were not specified, they include U.S. ally Turkey and China, whose president, Xi Jinping, is set to visit the White House next month.

Last week, the United Arab Emirates said it was suspending trade with Iran, depriving Tehran of one of its largest trading partners. The nation cited a ballistic missile attack. Hours later, Trump publicly warned of consequences for nations that have financial connections to Iran.

At his news conference Aug. 24, Bessent indicated the announcements were connected.

“I would think that the actions that they took last week were not coincidental but likely causal,” Bessent said.

Port call is set for crew of Lincoln

Family texts show ship finally is headed home

Chris Quintana and Emily R. Condon
USA TODAY

Crew members aboard the USS Abraham Lincoln finally have a port call scheduled, according to texts sent to family members and shared with USA TODAY.

The Lincoln has a planned stop in Thailand in early September, the texts say. The aircraft carrier is sailing home after an extended, record-setting deployment in the Middle East amid the U.S. war in Iran.

In an Aug. 18 text exchange shared with USA TODAY, a sailor on the Lincoln asked her relative to send recommendations for a couple of hotels in Thailand. In a separate text exchange, a relative told her family member she was excited for him because he had always talked about going to Thailand.

Spokespeople told USA TODAY the Navy does not comment on future operations or ship movements because of operational security.

The ship began its journey home after the U.S. Central Command, which oversees military action in the Middle East, announced that the USS George Washington had arrived in the Arabian Sea.

The aircraft carrier made headlines after Democrats in Congress and family members of service members raised concerns about conditions on the ship, citing crew members' mental health and reports of a sailor who had jumped overboard. They also told relatives about cold showers, clogged toilets and inadequate supplies.

USA TODAY spoke with family members who also expressed frustration about the lack of clear timelines for when their loved ones would return. They said they were incensed by President Donald Trump's comments Aug. 14 when he said that families weren't concerned about the conditions on the ship and that, in his view, the deployment had not gone on nearly long enough.

USA TODAY reported in April on conditions aboard the Lincoln and the USS Tripoli, also deployed to the Middle East. A photo shared with a USA TODAY reporter showed a small handful of boiled carrots, a dry meat patty and a slab of gray processed meat from a meal on the Lincoln.

How long has the USS Lincoln been at sea?

The Lincoln left port in San Diego on Nov. 21, 2025. The crew expected a six-month deployment.

The aircraft carrier made one port stop in Guam in mid-December, according to the Navy. The carrier has since been at sea for more than 250 consecutive days in its nine-month deployment, a record-breaking stint for a carrier without a port stop, according to a review of the lone port-stop announcements.

Sen. Jack Reed of Rhode Island, top Democrat on the Armed Services Committee, said the ship is expected back at its home port within weeks after "a record-setting uninterrupted time at sea."

When will the Lincoln arrive in the U.S.?

A USA TODAY analysis of the journey length and ship speed, which included a review of similar journeys, found the ship probably would arrive at the U.S. mainland in four to five weeks if no unexpected changes were made in the journey.

Where will the Lincoln go next?

The military declined to provide USA TODAY with details on the route or timing, which is standard in such situations. After it returns to San Diego, the Lincoln probably will find a new home at Naval Base Kitsap in Bremerton, Washington, according to the Kitsap Sun, part of the USA TODAY Network.

The George Washington is a Japan-based aircraft carrier, the same type of Nimitz-class carrier as the USS Lincoln, according to its website profile.

Contributing: Bart Jansen and Joey Garrison

Nevada sues over plan for Colorado River

Interior rules call for 21% water cut in 3 states

James Powell
USA TODAY

LAS VEGAS – Nevada has filed a federal lawsuit against the Department of the Interior over new rules that manage how water from the Colorado River is distributed among seven states.

The lawsuit challenges a plan released Aug. 21 that calls for a 21% reduction in water from the river to California, Nevada and Arizona for two years starting in 2027. The states that draw from the Colorado River were unable to agree on how to share the water after more than three years of talks to replace a plan that expires this year.

Nevada would see cuts to the state's 300,000-acre-foot allocation of water from the river by up to 213,556 acre-feet, according to a news release announcing the lawsuit Aug. 24.

Officials from the Southern Nevada Water Authority, who are a part of the lawsuit, say the remaining allotment is not enough to supply southern Nevada's basic water needs.

The rules established by the Interior

Department could leave southern Nevada, home to Las Vegas, with less than 86,500 acre-feet a year. The news release says Las Vegas and its surrounding cities used under 212,500 acre-feet of water in 2024. The lawsuit says the Colorado River supplies 90% of all water used in the Las Vegas Valley.

"Over the past 25 years, southern Nevada has become a global leader in water efficiency, reducing our Colorado River consumption by about 40 percent even as the community added 800,000-plus residents, so we have clearly demonstrated our ability to adapt and do more with less," John Entsminger, the water authority's general manager, said in the news release. "However, conservation has its limits."

The lawsuit says the Interior Department failed to analyze the effect of the cuts on southern Nevada's economy or consider alternatives. It also says the rules violate environmental law and the Law of the River, a group of treaties, agreements and court rulings that have guided river water management.

Water cuts split states

Under the new rules, four states – Colorado, Utah, New Mexico and Wyoming – are allowed to implement volun-

tary water reductions instead of mandatory cuts. The so-called Upper Basin states refused to take mandatory cuts to their water supply from the river, arguing they already face steep reductions because of the decadeslong drought in the western United States.

Nevada Gov. Joe Lombardo said in the news release that the rules solved the water shortage "on the backs of the Lower Basin states" that include Arizona, California and Nevada.

"We've already shown that we're willing to do our part, but the Colorado River is a shared resource, so the solution needs to involve everybody. Until that happens, we are prepared to fight for as long as it takes," Lombardo said.

The lawsuit is the first legal challenge to the rules, though experts warn other Lower Basin states are likely to file their own. Arizona released a letter Aug. 10 objecting to the plan and accusing the Interior Department of violating the 1922 Colorado River compact.

The battle comes as decades of increasing water demand and drought have caused a continual decline in water levels on the river, especially in reservoirs such as Lake Mead and Lake Powell. Both are at record lows in August.

Contributing: Trevor Hughes, USA TODAY; Reuters

No power

Continued from Page 1A

parents to send their children to live with relatives who could care for them during the day.

Massive storms began battering northwest Indiana on Aug. 11. Two tornadoes ripped through the region, and 100 mph winds turned trees into battering rams. Damage to the electric grid was catastrophic: More than 60% of Northern Indiana Public Service Co.'s (NIPSCO) customers lost power.

Some towns have flickered back to life since the widespread outages, but NIPSCO estimates that it will not have widespread power to Gary and Portage, a neighboring city of nearly 40,000 people, until late on Aug. 25.

In the meantime, Gary has taken on a post-apocalyptic atmosphere: Massive trees and broken branches from the storm still litter the sidewalks. Tank-like trucks full of utility crews crawl the streets. With traffic lights dark, vehicles haphazardly make turns at busy intersections.

Some blame "Mother Nature" for the longest outage they have ever endured. Others, including Gov. Mike Braun, have taken aim at the utility company.

The utility, the governor said, "continues to fail Hoosiers despite having access to every state resource available."

"It is time that NIPSCO gets the power back on NOW," Braun said in a statement to IndyStar, part of the USA TODAY Network, on Aug. 23.

'It's like the apocalypse'

Gary, once a bustling Chicago suburb full of steel and refinery workers, was carved up and hollowed out as manufacturing moved overseas in the 1970s. A third of the city's 67,000 residents now live in poverty.

Gary's mayor is adamant the city is on the rebound. Then the storm hit.

Generators, or a lack thereof, now divide Gary residents into those able to meet their basic needs and those who say life is becoming unbearable.

Timothy Holmes said he had no choice but to get a generator, despite the machine's daily appetite for \$30-\$50 of gasoline. Without his personal power system, he wouldn't be able to keep his pacemaker online.

For his neighbors who can't afford a generator, life is bleak.

"We feel like cavemen," said Fantasia Malone, who lives on Arizona Street with her three children. "It's like the apocalypse."

The storm wreaked havoc on the property Malone rents. Water leaked through the ceiling, and debris tore through her backyard, where she now refuses to let her children play.

The first few days without power stripped some Gary residents of all sense of normalcy and brought challenges they never before anticipated.

"When the outage hit, everyone that was open only accepted cash," Montgomery said. "I don't carry any cash at all. Went to the ATM; it was out as well. I had no assets."

Then, Montgomery's refrigerator grew warm. She has been driving 30 minutes into Illinois to find ice and groceries. Sometimes, she'll feed her family fast food or restaurant meals, but the costs are adding up.



Brooklyn Jenkins, second from right, 11, has been helping her siblings keep up with education as schools and day cares wait for power to be restored in Gary, Indiana. PHOTOS BY MICHAEL CLUBB/USA TODAY NETWORK



Destiny Jenkins uses her phone's flashlight as she and her husband, Kevin Jenkins, walk down to their basement to look at water damage on Aug. 23 in Gary.

"I'm afraid to check my bank account," she said. "But I have no choice. It's either that or starve."

Some Gary parents scrambled to find accommodations for their children after powerless schools shut down. Destiny and Kevin Jenkins, who both work at UPS, sent their four children to live with their grandmother in Chicago.

In another part of the city, Jackie Taylor said her daughter's school just got power back on Aug. 22 after canceling classes last week.

By the morning of Aug. 24, the majority of Gary's schools were expected to be open.

"Most of the schools are up," Gary Mayor Eddie Melton told IndyStar on the afternoon of Aug. 23. "We have maybe three or four elementary schools that [NIPSCO is] working on."

Some residents said they are making do by charging their phones in their cars, keeping their front doors open to let in the breeze and filling coolers with ice. Others are at their wits' end.

Donna Tucker, who can't afford a generator, said she's down to her last \$13 until Sept. 3, when her next benefit payment arrives.

"I'm a senior citizen on Social Security income," she said. "Who's gonna give me my food back?"

No power: Who's responsible?

The trees that took down the power lines, plunging the area into darkness, are still everywhere in Gary. They're still

blocking sidewalks, lying on roofs and tangling power lines.

Some residents say they understand why the Herculean task of cleanup is taking so long. Others, however, say NIPSCO has neglected the area, many parts of which are low-income.

The utility has restored service for 357,953 customers since the outages began on Aug. 11, according to the NIPSCO website. But 16,476 remained without power, as of 4 p.m. on Aug. 23.

A NIPSCO spokesperson told IndyStar that restoration plans are dictated by "the severity and extent of the damage. In some areas, repairs to major transmission and distribution infrastructure must be completed before work can begin on smaller sections of the system serving individual neighborhoods. Every community matters to us, and restoration priorities are based on system needs, safety considerations and the work required to restore service to the greatest number of customers as efficiently as possible."

The utility has mobilized all available resources since the onset of the storm, "including our own crews, mutual aid personnel, qualified contractors, affiliated employees and support from the Indiana National Guard and law enforcement," the spokesperson continued.

Braun, however, takes credit for many of the resources restoring life in Gary. He sent 71 National Guardsmen and teams from multiple state agencies last week to clear routes of fallen trees.

Several residents told IndyStar they didn't believe NIPSCO was prepared for the storm. They pointed to the mess of trees toppling power lines throughout the city as evidence.

Melton said that the city of Gary has long known there's a backlog of trees in need of vegetation management but does not have the resources to address the problem alone.

"We were asking NIPSCO to give us what their cadence is on vegetation management, so we can better understand how frequent, should it be more often?" Melton said.

The mayor himself has been living without power for nearly two weeks.

Sophie Hartley covers the environment for the IndyStar, part of the USA TODAY Network. IndyStar's environmental reporting is made possible through the generous support of the nonprofit Nina Mason Pulliam Charitable Trust.

Two killed in strikes on alleged drug boats

Military resumes effort to target alleged trafficking

Zac Anderson
USA TODAY

The U.S. military killed two people in a strike on an alleged drug-trafficking vessel in the Eastern Pacific, resuming a controversial campaign that has faced criticism from legal experts.

The Aug. 23 strike, part of a nearly yearlong operation targeting alleged drug boats in the Caribbean and Eastern

Pacific, was the first such attack in more than two months, according to independent conflict monitor ACLED.

The U.S. military’s Southern Command said in a social media post that the strike targeted a “low-profile vessel” and that “intelligence revealed the vessel’s active involvement in narco-trafficking,” without providing evidence. SOUTHCOM described the two individuals who were killed as “narco-terrorists.” The military released a video showing the strike and the vessel on fire.

“Let me be clear, we will not permit

narco-terrorists to operate with impunity in the Western Hemisphere, nor will we allow their deadly poison to reach American communities,” SOUTHCOM Cmdr Gen. Francis Donovan said in a statement.

More than 200 people have been killed in the military campaign, dubbed Operation Southern Spear, that began in September 2025 and has involved dozens of boat strikes.

Many legal experts have said the strikes amount to extrajudicial killings. The administration’s decision to use military force rather than trying to ap-

prehend suspected trafficking vessels and their cargo also has drawn bipartisan criticism from lawmakers. The administration has released no evidence that the boats being targeted were engaged in drug trafficking.

Administration officials have defended the legality of the campaign.

“All operations are conducted deliberately and lawfully, in full compliance with U.S. and international law, including the law of armed conflict,” SOUTHCOM said in a June statement.

Contributing: Cybele Mayes-Osterman

Two die in Pennsylvania as measles comeback continues

First U.S. deaths this year were PA’s first in 35 years

Saman Shafiq
USA TODAY

At least two people have died of measles in Pennsylvania, the state’s health department said, adding that both were unvaccinated.

The measles deaths were the first in Pennsylvania in 35 years, the state Department of Health said in a news release Aug. 25, and the first such deaths in the United States this year, according to Centers for Disease Control and Prevention data.

“Because measles was largely eliminated in the Commonwealth for more than three decades, people are not familiar with this disease and don’t fully understand the potential severity of the illness,” Pennsylvania Secretary of Health Dr. Debra Bogen said in a statement. “As a physician, I want to make sure that people understand that the MMR vaccine is safe and provides the best protection we have against measles.”

Both patients lived in Lancaster County, the health department said, adding that it would not identify them to protect their and their families’ privacy.

Authorities have confirmed 393 cases of measles in Pennsylvania in 2026, ac-

cording to the news release.

What is measles, and how do you get it?

Measles is a highly contagious virus that can cause severe short- and long-term health problems, including pneumonia and brain swelling. Nearly 20% of people who contract measles end up in the hospital. Though measles-related deaths are rare, they are not uncommon, occurring in 1 to 3 patients per 1,000 cases, according to Pennsylvania health authorities.

“The best protection against measles is getting fully vaccinated,” the state health department said. “The MMR vaccine, administered over two doses, boosts a person’s immune system and provides 97% lifetime protection.”

The measles, mumps and rubella vaccine is usually given in two doses around ages 1 to 5. The CDC also notes that adults and teens should also be up to date on MMR vaccinations.

Is the MMR vaccine safe?

Medical experts long have said the MMR vaccine is safe and effective. For decades, the vaccine has been administered to millions of children, helping prevent severe and life-threatening complications of measles, mumps and rubella. Serious side effects of the vaccine, including seizures, are rare.

“Because measles was largely eliminated in the Commonwealth for more than three decades, people are not familiar with this disease and don’t fully understand the potential severity of the illness.”

Dr. Debra Bogen
Pennsylvania Secretary of Health

The vaccine has been available in its current form since 1971, marking more than 50 years of safe and effective use. It also has been instrumental in curtailing the spread of measles, which, before the vaccine’s introduction in 1963, sickened an estimated 3 million to 4 million people in the United States every year and causing 500 deaths and 48,000 hospitalizations.

Measles cases reach record high

Measles cases in the United States have surpassed last year’s total and are at their highest since the disease was eliminated from the country nearly three decades ago, according to CDC data. The majority, 93%, occurred in unvaccinated people, and nearly 69% of cases were in people ages 19 and younger.

Cases reached a 30-year high in 2025, with 2,289 confirmed infections across 43 states and the District of Co-

lumbia. Nearly 90% of cases were directly linked to 48 known outbreaks, and 93% of infections were contracted by unvaccinated people or those whose vaccination status was unknown. Three people, including two children, died as a result of the outbreaks, the first pediatric measles deaths in a decade.

Dr. Mehmet Oz contradicts Trump’s claims on vaccine

President Donald Trump, meanwhile, signed an executive order Aug. 10 calling for more vaccine “flexibility,” fewer childhood vaccinations and splitting the combined childhood measles, mumps and rubella vaccine into three shots at different times. The order also says all childhood vaccines should be spaced out, with each one administered in a separate doctor’s visit “to the maximum extent feasible.”

Announcing the order, Trump said the MMR vaccine could be “quite lethal.” Experts, however, say the vaccine is safe and effective, and research indicates dividing it into multiple shots has no health benefit.

Dr. Mehmet Oz, head of the Centers for Medicare and Medicaid Services, contradicted Trump’s statement about the MMR shot in an interview Aug. 23 on CBS’ “Face the Nation,” saying it is “not a lethal vaccine.”

Contributing: Zac Anderson and Mary Walrath-Holdridge

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9/11

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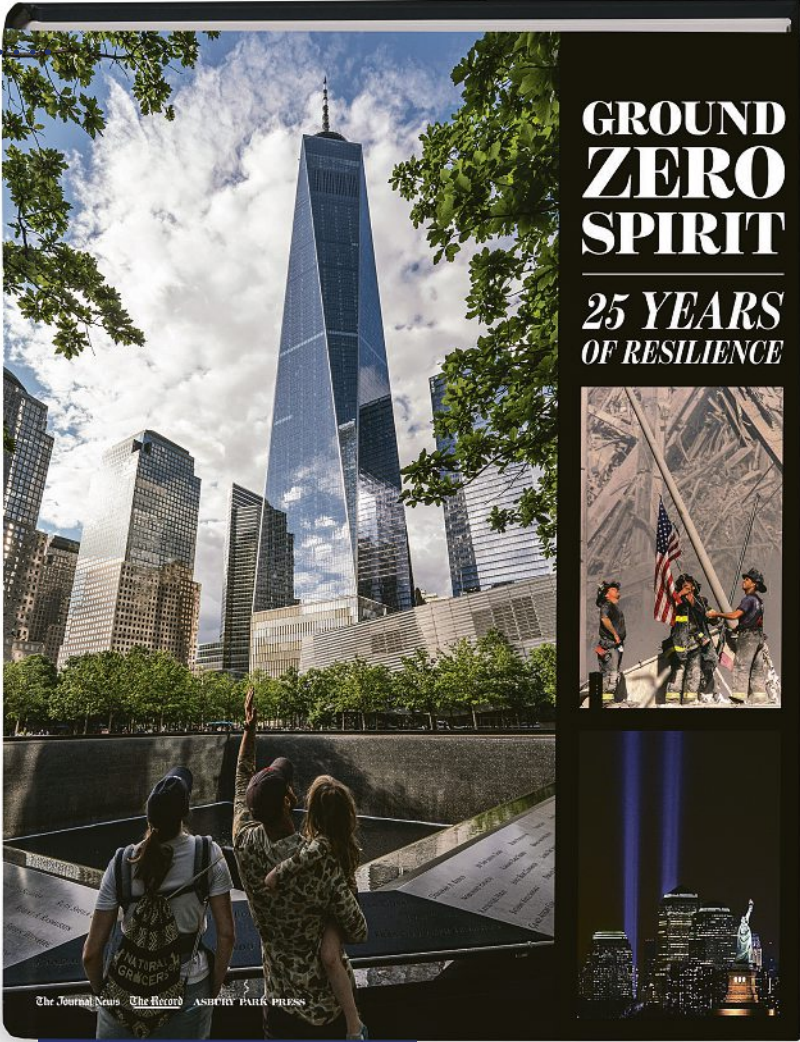
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Back-to-school costs hit home for parents

‘I’m looking for every sale I can,’ Utah mom laments

Christopher Cann, Clayton Park and Erick Trevino
USA TODAY NETWORK

Brandi McGrath usually buys quality, long-lasting school supplies for her 9-year-old son and his teachers. But sharp increases in the cost of folders, pencils and other products have forced her to cut back and search for cheaper alternatives.

“It’s insane how expensive things have gotten,” said McGrath, 48, of Salt Lake City. “I’m looking for every sale I can.”

In Daytona Beach, Florida, Karin Kaiser also was struck by the cost of back-to-school shopping this year.

“It is crazy,” she said, estimating that she and her husband spent way over \$100 on just notebooks and loose-leaf paper for their two daughters. “That’s not counting what we had to pay for back-to-school clothes, shoes, haircuts.”

The cost of a typical school supply list – including notebooks, paper, pencils and glue sticks – is nearly \$175, almost 8% higher than in 2025, an analysis by the progressive think tanks Groundwork Collaborative and The Century Foundation shows.

Some essential items such as lunch boxes, notebooks and tissues cost 20% or more than they did a year ago, the analysis found, pointing in part to the effects of President Donald Trump’s tariff agenda, which the Federal Reserve says raised the cost of many products manufactured overseas for American consumers.

Over the same period, the cost of electronics such as headphones rose 6.6%, the report found. Meanwhile, typical lunch items cost 10.9% more than they did in 2025, the analysis said, citing price hikes on everything from blueberries to deli meat.

The rising prices come as Americans are already struggling with inflation and high gas prices stemming from the war in Iran, forcing many to take on debt and stretch their meals.

A survey by the personal finance company Credit Karma found that 57% of parents are entering the back-to-school season carrying credit card debt, and nearly half plan to pursue new credit to help pay for back-to-school expenses.

USA TODAY Network reporters spoke with families across the country about how the rising cost of school supplies is affecting them. Many said it has worsened their already dire financial situation, forcing them to cut back further, look for donations and buy the cheapest versions of what their child needs for school. Some had to forego school shopping altogether.

“There’s all sorts of balancing I have



Brandi and Tyler McGrath say they have cut back on school supplies for their son, Alton.

PROVIDED BY BRANDI MCGRATH



Lynnette Peavler, left, a third grade teacher in Kentucky, and her family are feeling the back-to-school pinch.

PROVIDED BY JARRETT PEAVLER

to do now,” McGrath said. “Everything is squeezing us.”

Companies are raising prices

Major school supply brands have increased their prices in recent months, citing inflation, rising gas prices and the Trump administration’s tariffs.

Newell Brands, which owns well-known school supply brands such as Sharpie, EXPO, Paper Mate and Elmer’s glue, increased prices on consumers to offset more than \$170 million in tariff costs.

ACCO Brands, which owns school notebook supplier Mead & Five Star, cited costs from tariffs and conflict in the Middle East as headwinds that will lead to higher prices for consumers.

“We do anticipate having to push through additional cost increases globally,” said Thomas Tedford, president and CEO of ACCO Brands, in an earning call in July.

In a statement, White House spokesperson Kush Desai said: “As traffic through the Strait of Hormuz normalizes, energy prices – and thus overall inflation – will come down and real wages will rise. President Trump’s economic agenda delivered historic working-class prosperity in his first term, and this same agenda is cleaning up Joe Biden’s mess to deliver more job, wage, and investment growth.”

McGrath, who leads her local parent teacher association, said she compared receipts from 2025 with what she spent

this year and was “flabbergasted by the difference.”

“I was paying a dollar apiece for basic folders last year, and today they were \$2.79,” she said.

Parents on the hunt for deals

As prices for back-to-school products rise, more families are searching for deals or opting for cheaper alternatives, including donations.

About 62% of back-to-school shoppers said they probably would be seeking out sales this year, according to an annual report by the personal finance money management company NerdWallet. A quarter of respondents said they planned to cut back on school-related spending, and 72% said items like clothing, school supplies and electronics feel noticeably more expensive this year than in 2025.

Jenni Craig of Ormond Beach, Florida, said she spent hundreds of dollars more on school supplies for her three daughters this year than she did last year. To keep costs down, she tried to save where she could.

“I said no to the \$1.50 folders that are nicer simply because they have a cute cat on it,” she said. “We got the plain 49-cent folders instead.”

Others are doing the same.

McGrath said she left the notebooks decorated with elaborate prints and brightly colored animals on the shelves, even though they’re her son’s favorite.

“He’s going to get the cheapest folder that I can afford, and we’ll put stickers on it because I can’t afford the prices that anything fun is going for.”

Across the country, tens of thousands of parents line up for free backpacks, notebooks and other supplies for their children. Many groups organizing these fundraisers say they’ve seen the need for donations rise sharply over the past several years.

The Brevard Schools Foundation, which serves children and families in east-central Florida, went from giving free backpacks to about 3,100 students in 2023 to supplying them to nearly 5,000 children last year.

“Families continue to face rising costs for school supplies, while teachers regularly encounter students who arrive without the basic materials they need to learn,” Joan Perry, a spokesperson for the foundation, told Florida Today, part of the USA TODAY Network.

Americans already under strain

The new school year arrived at a time when families were already struggling to afford everyday expenses.

Studies have shown more Americans are dipping into their savings and taking on debt to cover essential payments on housing, food and rent. In a June survey, 30% of respondents said they used a credit card to pay for essentials in the past three months, knowing they may

not pay off their bills.

Chase Miranda, 36, of Indian Lake, Ohio, said he and his wife have fallen behind on rent and utility payments just to afford groceries, especially after their food stamp benefits were cut by half.

Trump slashed Supplemental Nutrition Assistance Program funding in 2025 in a move the White House said would strengthen the program to “serve those who need it most.” More than 4 million people are estimated to have lost food benefits since the Republican-backed legislation took effect.

Miranda, who’s unable to work because of chronic pain stemming from scoliosis and bulging discs in his back, said the cuts meant he couldn’t buy his 12-year-old son anything new for the upcoming school year. “Until we get enough money saved up, he’ll use last year’s supplies,” he said.

Consumer prices have spiked for five straight years. In that span, prices have risen more than 25%. The inflation crisis began under former President Joe Biden, in the waning months of the COVID-19 pandemic. It has persisted through Trump’s second term, fed by his campaign of import tariffs and a lengthening war against Iran.

Emily Saeteurn, a parent of two in Peoria, Arizona, said the cost of groceries has forced her to consider whether to keep packing her daughter’s lunch. It may now be cheaper to pay for lunches provided by the school, she said.

Teachers feel the squeeze, too

The high prices are also affecting teachers, many of whom must pay out-of-pocket to supply their classrooms with essential items like tissues, wipes, hand sanitizers, paper and pencils.

Jarrett Peavler of Perryville, Kentucky, said his wife, a third grade teacher, had to solicit donations online to stock her classroom with supplies. Her school provides its teachers with only a \$200 allowance for the year.

“That’s like one tank of gas for my truck,” Peavler said. “And they expect that to last her all year? I was like, ‘You’ve got to be kidding me.’”

As teachers struggle to pay for supplies, they’re turning to donations and parents to help fill in the gaps, though that’s often not enough.

In Salt Lake City, McGrath hosts fundraisers and collect supplies for her son’s elementary school. This year, she has brought in about a third of the donations she usually receives.

As parents and teachers alike struggle to keep up with costs, schools may cancel some of their field trips, McGrath said. Some supply closets stocked with clothes and notebooks for students in need may be emptier than usual.

“It’s hurting everyone,” she said.

Christopher Cann reports for USA TODAY; Clayton Park reports for The Daytona Beach News-Journal; and Erick Trevino reports for The Arizona Republic.

Accents

Continued from Page 1A

familiar, since the former British subjects spoke English. But the English they spoke was different from our modern-day diction, from varying accents to unfamiliar words and phrases and even spelling that would make a present-day teacher wear out their red pen.

But how do we know what people in 18th-century America sounded like? There are no recordings from the time, of course, so we’re left to try and glean information from contemporary journals, letters and diaries, said Esteban Touma, a linguistics expert with Babel, the online language learning platform.

“Wouldn’t it be fascinating to have recordings?” Touma mused. “But we can surmise. We have reports about people visiting [America] and writing back to Europe about the differences and similarities in how people sounded.”

Perhaps surprisingly, the early colonists would not sound very similar to the formal British accent we think of today. That posh accent is a relatively modern invention, linguist John McWhorter wrote earlier this year in The New York Times.

“The hallmark of the British accent,” wrote McWhorter, an author and professor at Columbia University, “developed only at the end of the 18th century.”

A 2018 BBC article cites several linguists who say modern Americans in many cases sound more like 18th-century Brits. The article notes how we (and long-ago colonizers) pronounce words like “path” – with the “a” sounding like “aa” and not like modern Brits’ “pah-th,” and Americans saying “fire” “fi-er” as opposed to today’s Britons’ “fi-yah.”

Mixing sounds and cultures

Language, Touma said, “tends to move in patterns,” especially in cities like Boston, New York and Philadelphia, which were busy ports where people from all over Europe, the Caribbean and the colonies landed, traded, lived and worked.

Boston welcomed more people from England than other colonial-era ports, so Touma said the sound of New Englanders’ speech was closer to that of the mother country. Virginia, too, seemed to have a distinctive accent as early as the 18th century. “Speech would mix with later waves of immigrants, so I would speculate that there was a difference in the accents, and they could tell people from different regions” by the way they spoke, he added.

He pointed to the 2008 HBO miniseries “John Adams,” about the Founding Father and second U.S. president; the filmmakers hired a dialect coach to make actor Paul Giamatti sound as historically accurate as possible.

Did Betsy Ross have an accent?

Samantha Ricchiuti is an actor and historic interpreter for Historic Philadelphia Inc. who portrays two very different but important women of the American Revolution: Betsy Ross, credited with sewing the first American flag; and Julia Stockton Rush, wife of Dr. Benjamin Rush (a signer of the Declaration of Independence) who was highly educated and well-read in her own right.

The two women came from very different backgrounds: Ross was a working-class woman who was raised as a Quaker, and she used the sect’s “plain speech” throughout her life, Ricchiuti said. Stockton Rush was born into a

wealthy family; her mother was one of the first female poets published in America and her father’s family had donated the land for Princeton University, where he was a trustee.

Touma said that, not unlike today, access to education and wealth often affected one’s diction and vocabulary.

Books were expensive and rare in Colonial America, and Touma said, people with more money and social standing were able to read more, write more and connect more easily to England and Europe. People from lower social classes might also live in more isolated areas, limiting the languages and words to which they might be exposed.

Regional variations also existed then as now, he added: A poor laborer in Massachusetts would sound more like a wealthy person from the same area than they would to a poor person from, say, Virginia. And yes, people then code-switched at times, such as the way enslaved people spoke amongst themselves, often using vernacular derived from the West African languages, versus the way they spoke in the company of their enslavers.

“When I am Betsy, people tell me they like my accent and I joke, what accent?” Ricchiuti said. A native Philadelphian, she explained that in character, she rounds out her vowels, articulates consonants more clearly and enunciating more than we do today. As Ross, she says “thee,” “thou” and “ye” in keeping with the Quaker speech of the time, but she also says that the seamstress was “very much amongst the people” of Philadelphia: people from England, yes, but also Ireland, Scotland, Wales, Germany, the Caribbean and France. “The way she spoke would have been influenced by the people around her.”

Stockton Rush would likely have

been more soft-spoken, “a woman of her class and her time,” Ricchiuti said, “who was also not afraid to call out the men. She’s a lot less fiery than Abigail Adams,” but from the correspondence between her and her husband that survives, it’s clear Benjamin Rush respected her as his intellectual equal, writing to her about books they could read and discuss together and taking her advice to heart.

Weird words, weirder spellings

Babel’s linguists compiled a list of several words that existed at the time of America’s founding that we’ve largely abandoned, for better or worse. Among them: “Snollygoster,” which describes an unscrupulous politician; “brabble,” to argue loudly about something unimportant; “belswagger,” or a lewd or swaggering man; and “desudation,” to sweat profusely.

Noah Webster, who was born in Connecticut in 1758, wrote the “American Spelling Book” in 1783 and the American Dictionary of the English Language in 1828, and, Britannica writes, “was instrumental in giving American English a dignity and vitality of its own.”

He was also, Babel said in a release, a proponent of spelling reform who wanted to democratize language. He “waged a linguistic revolution against what he saw as British spelling tyranny, driven by a belief that the English language had been corrupted by British aristocracy.” His own form of rebellion was to create a system of spelling, one that was based in phonetics: “ake” for “ache”; “beleev” for “believe”; “wimmin” for “women”; and “dawter” for “daughter.”

Those spellings, much to the chagrin of students for the last couple of hundred years, did not catch on.

OPINION

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2 weeks, and still no power in Gary, Indiana



Kofi Mframa
USA TODAY

About 30 miles east of Chicago, a city remains in the dark. As of Aug. 24, more than 7,000 residents of Gary, Indiana, are without electricity.

The outage followed severe storms, which began on Aug. 11 and caused deadly floods in the state that have killed at least seven people.

For two weeks, the people of Gary have been forced to weather the late summer heat without electricity. Many residents have taken to social media to express the direness of this situation.

But what happened in Gary wasn't just Mother Nature's doing. Gary residents didn't just experience a freak weather event. They were victims of layers upon layers of systemic failures that left a vulnerable population to fend for themselves for far too long.

Black people make up nearly 80% of the city's population of more than 67,000. One third of the city lives in poverty. Marginalized groups being failed by systems in the wake of a natural disaster is no strange occurrence in America, but as our country's cracks widen, tragedies like these seem more and more inevitable – even intentional.

Hold power company, and data centers, accountable

For more than 50 years, Gary has borne the brunt of extreme deindustrialization and disinvestment that have left the city with few resources to meet the needs of its residents. Decades of disenfranchisement and neglect toward its population made Gary prime for the devastation we're seeing now.

Northern Indiana Public Service Co. (NIPSCO), a monopoly utility that Hoosiers pay to keep them powered through disasters, has apparently failed to protect its customers. A class-action lawsuit has been filed claiming inadequate vegetation management – and a possible misuse of funds for infrastructure and reliability improvements – led to the widespread blackout.



Demond Pompy cooks food on a grill at his home in Gary, Indiana, due to a power outage on Aug. 20. Thousands of residents remain without electricity after storms hit on Aug. 11. OCTAVIO JONES/REUTERS

Like many other states, Indiana has entered the data center race and is particularly attractive due to the availability of cheap land. And NIPSCO is leading the effort.

In October, NIPSCO launched a spin-off company, GenCo, to shirk many regulatory proceedings typically required before power plants can be built in the state. NIPSCO claims this move will provide the copious energy that data centers require without increasing costs for customers. But anyone who's been sentient during this data center epidemic should find that claim laughable.

Unsurprisingly, customers say their power bills skyrocketed earlier this year, with some reportedly as high as \$1,447 for one month. Luckily, NIPSCO boasted half a billion dollars in profits since January. If only the company would use that to improve infrastructure or the terrible working conditions that have union members referring to themselves as "slave laborers."

Gary, Indiana, isn't an isolated incident

What happened and is happening in Gary is no isolated incident. Many other areas in Northwest Indiana are still without power.

Now Memphis, Tennessee, is going through a similar situation.

As data centers overload grids across the country, power outages like the ones we're seeing will only become more frequent. Tech oligarchs and government officials will do anything to line their pockets and fulfill their artificial intelligence pipe dreams.

Reliable electricity, clean drinking water and the overall quality of life for some of the most underserved populations in our country are just collateral to these "leaders."

So much of modern American life seems to be getting worse. Between a laundry list of food recalls and mysterious illnesses spawning, to the defund-

ing of infrastructure meant to keep us safe while turning militarized police forces on its own citizens, the loyalty of the U.S. government doesn't lie with the American people.

Instead, the powers that be would rather focus on a foreign war we're losing and aiding our "ally" in committing a genocide. Even military service members aren't exempt from the government's cruelty.

But there is still light in the darkness. Gary residents have come together to help those in need. Food influencer Keith Lee, NBA player Tyrese Haliburton and the Salvation Army have helped distribute food, storm relief, cleaning supplies and community resources. World Central Kitchen has done its thing. Even the Chicago Bears have stepped up to fund relief.

When those above us turn a blind eye, it's up to us to see each other.

Kofi Mframa is a columnist and digital producer at USA TODAY.

Data center opponents should study Quincy, Washington



Dace Potas
USA TODAY

Data centers, the gigantic buildings that house the computing power behind the artificial intelligence boom, are wildly unpopular. A recent Gallup poll found that 7 in 10 Americans oppose one being built in their area.

Most of those objections don't hold up. In town after town, data centers have delivered real benefits to the communities willing to host them. Local officials should be welcoming these projects, not passing laws to keep them out.

Quincy, Washington, is now home to more than two dozen data centers, which pay more than half the city's property taxes. That windfall has bought Quincy a new high school, sports complex, hospital, library, police station, fire department and even a water park. A population of 8,500 people got all of that, plus 900 new jobs. Its poverty rate has fallen from nearly 30% in 2012 to 6.2% in 2024.

Quincy is the high end of outcomes, and it got in ahead of the curve, but data centers bring jobs and tax revenue to any city willing to host them.

An increase in tax revenue let Richland Parish, Louisiana, pay its teachers \$50,000 bonuses. Loudoun County, Virginia, now known as the data center capital of the world, has used the money to cut property tax rates.

Data centers are projected to generate \$27 billion in tax revenue nationwide over the next decade. More communities should be looking at how to claim their share. The centers also need engineers and electricians to maintain them and construction crews to build them. Salaries for construction workers



Large tent-like structures under construction for an expanding data center in New Albany, Ohio, on July 31. DORAL CHENOWETH/COLUMBUS DISPATCH/USA TODAY NETWORK VIA REUTERS CONNECT

on these projects have ballooned into six figures amid the "gold rush."

Misguided concerns on water. Power is another matter.

Companies flocked to Quincy for its cheap land, cheap power and easy permitting. Yet more and more local governments are moving the other way. More than 500 localities have restricted the construction of new data centers.

New York became the first state to pass a moratorium on the projects, and 14 more states have considered similar measures. Sen. Bernie Sanders, I-Vermont, and Rep. Alexandria Ocasio-Cortez, D-New York, have introduced a nationwide version.

Misguided as they are, politicians on both sides of the aisle are just responding to their constituents. The Gallup

poll found that half of opponents are against data centers over their effect on the local environment, meaning water usage or energy consumption.

Water is the most misunderstood concern. Data centers do use it to cool their servers, but not all cooling is equal. Evaporative cooling, the older method, consumes water by evaporating it to pull heat out of the system. Closed-loop systems recirculate the same water over and over instead. Right now, 56% of data centers still use evaporative cooling, but many of the industry's biggest players are moving to closed-loop systems.

U.S. data centers account for just 0.14% of the country's annual water consumption, or 449 million gallons a day. For reference, California almond farms use 4.2 billion gallons a day. Golf courses use 1.4 billion.

Electricity is a tougher case.

Data centers already account for roughly 4% of American electricity use, and that figure could hit 12% by 2028.

Americans are understandably worried about electricity costs, which data centers can push up under some circumstances, mainly when they're built in areas without the grid capacity to support them.

But those increases don't have to be permanent. Data centers add demand in a stable, predictable way, giving power companies time to plan new production and infrastructure to meet it.

Instead of blaming data centers, ease regulations on infrastructure

The real gripe shouldn't be with data centers, but with the regulations that make it so hard to build energy infrastructure in the first place.

Regions with surplus power, such as North Dakota, have actually seen electricity prices fall slightly even as demand rose almost 40%, largely because of data centers.

States with policy constraints, like New York, have made it needlessly hard to build energy infrastructure, a problem that predates data centers entirely. Others, like California, face their own obstacles, from wildfire risk to a permitting process that can take years.

Americans shouldn't be looking for ways to restrict these projects. They should be looking for ways to make it easier to build the infrastructure that powers them. Transmission itself is relatively cheap. It's the infrastructure around it that drives up local costs.

Anyone worried about price increases should take that up with their local government, not with the data centers themselves.

Dace Potas, a law student, is an opinion columnist for USA TODAY. Follow him on X: @DacePotas

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Toyota, Honda readers' top pick

Affordable, popular vehicles lead the pack

Charles Singh
Nashville Tennessean
USA TODAY NETWORK

We asked our USA TODAY Cars newsletter subscribers last weekend their opinion on the best car ever, and the responses were surprising. Instead of expensive luxury models, most of our readers chose affordable and popular mainstream cars. One reader even suggested a minivan should be in the running for the title.

Here are the top picks for the best car ever, sourced from our readers. Join in on the conversation by subscribing to our newsletter and interacting with our team of expert car reviewers, journalists and auto enthusiasts.

The Toyota Corolla makes a strong case for best car ever

One reader responded to my choice of the Honda Civic as the undisputed best car ever with "the Honda Civic is not a bad choice. But what about the Toyota Corolla?" This reader's alternative speaks to an age-old rivalry between the affordable Japanese car brands, and the Corolla isn't a bad

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The 2027 Toyota Corolla Hybrid.
PROVIDED BY TOYOTA

1963 Corvette Grand Sport sells for \$18,705,000

Keenan Thompson
Detroit Free Press
USA TODAY NETWORK

Monterey Car Week in California has concluded, and auction prices are getting more outrageous every year. One of the most anticipated vehicles offered at the auction was the 1963 Chevrolet Corvette Grand Sport sold by RM Sotheby's. This special vehicle was expected to sell for \$11 million to \$13 million but ended up going for an astounding \$18,705,000. That makes this car the most expensive Corvette ever sold and the third-most expensive American car to be sold at auction.

What makes the Grand Sport so special

Corvette generations offer several trims, with the Stingray the base model and the Z06 the more powerful version. Back in the 1960s, the Grand Sport was the top of the line. The original Grand Sport was made in secret since General Motors withdrew from factory racing after the success of its small-block V8 in 1955. Even though corporate support was limited, the man known as "the father of the Corvette," Zora Arkus-Duntov, was working on a masterpiece behind the scenes.

The small-block V8 was replaced with a 377-cubic-inch V8 that had an

See **CORVETTE**, Page 2B

General Motors eyes new profit drivers



GM Defense could win a \$1 billion contract with the U.S. government to build Infantry Squad Vehicles for the U.S. Army, based on the Chevrolet Colorado pickup trucks. PROVIDED BY GM DEFENSE

Automaker bets on defense, insurance growth

Jamie L. LaReau Detroit Free Press | USA TODAY NETWORK

DETROIT – General Motors is looking beyond its core vehicle sales for big revenue in the future, and Wall Street analysts applaud the strategy, hinting the automaker may be better positioned than its rival, Ford Motor, to win government contracts. • CEO Mary Barra told Wall Street during a second-quarter earnings call on July 21 that GM Defense and GM Insurance are on the road to becoming meaningful contributors to the company's profit stream. She even revealed that if Congress appropriates the funds, the company stands to win a \$1 billion contract to build military vehicles off the Chevrolet Colorado frame.

In 2017, GM formed the subsidiary GM Defense to apply its vehicle technology to military equipment in hopes of winning lucrative government contracts with U.S. and foreign governments. The GM Insurance program, which launched in 2024 and is only offered in certain states, including Michigan, sells direct-to-consumer auto insurance, including liability, comprehensive and collision coverage.

Barra told auto analysts on July 21 that GM Defense revenue will grow to nearly \$700 million this year and it is on target to achieve positive earnings before interest and taxes. In the next several years, she said, GM Defense

"We're focusing our efforts on strengthening supply chain management, improving manufacturing readiness, and expanding production capacity in ways that serve the United States and its allies well."

Mary Barra
CEO of GM

will produce double-digit profit margins.

GM Defense also could win a \$1 billion contract with the U.S. government to build light utility vehicles for the U.S. Army, based on the Chevrolet Colorado pickup trucks. The vehicles are dubbed ISVs for Infantry Squad Vehicles.

"After an initial multiyear order of about 1,200 ISVs, the U.S. Army now plans to procure more than 10,000 if the appropriations is passed," Barra said in the call, later adding that the "ISV awards are expected to exceed \$1 billion based on the U.S. Army's procurement objectives."

GM Defense won its first contract, worth \$214.3 million, in 2020 to build the ISVs for the U.S. Army. It has won other contracts since then. In 2021, GM Defense won a \$36.4 million contract from the State Department to develop large support utility commercial vehicles for the department's Diplomatic Security Service, which is the federal law enforcement and security arm of the department.

Barra said GM Defense, which is

See **GM**, Page 2B

Harley-Davidson prepares for customization push

CEO shares plan to add to the company's growth

Ricardo Torres
Milwaukee Journal Sentinel
USA TODAY NETWORK

MILWAUKEE – Customization has always been a part of Harley-Davidson's culture, and the motorcycle maker is preparing a major push for its parts and accessories in 2027.

Harley-Davidson CEO Artie Starrs said customization is a "critical part" of the company's efforts to return to growth.

Starrs made the comment during a July 23 earnings call with analysts and investors.

"Customization is not an add-on to the Harley-Davidson experience. It is core to the Harley-Davidson experience," Starrs said. "It drives rider connection. It creates important opportunities for our dealers and supports a stronger and more diversified revenue



Harley-Davidson CEO Artie Starrs said customization is a "critical part" of the company's efforts to return to growth. SCOTT OLSON/GETTY IMAGES FILE

See **HARLEY**, Page 2B

GM engine recall investigation expands

Jackie Charniga
Detroit Free Press
USA TODAY NETWORK

The National Highway Traffic Safety Administration has escalated one of its investigations into General Motors vehicles for engine failure risks to include newer-model years amid consumer complaints.

The federal agency said Aug. 21 that the new inquiry expands one of two existing recall investigations for the L87 6.2 liter V8 engines that it first began investigating in January 2025.

The issue stems from manufacturing defects to a vehicle’s connecting rod and crankshaft engine component, which GM attributed to multiple supplier manufacturing and quality concerns. Drivers could experience “loss of motive power due to engine failure” as a result.

“The safety and satisfaction of our customers are the highest priorities for the entire GM team, and we continue to cooperate with NHTSA’s evaluation of this matter,” GM spokesman Bill Grotz said in a statement emailed to the Detroit Free Press, part of the USA TODAY Network, on Aug. 21.

NHTSA eyes two additional model years

Vehicles equipped with the engines include the Chevrolet Silverado 1500, Chevrolet Tahoe, Chevrolet Suburban and GMC Sierra 1500, GMC Yukon and GMC Yukon XL, Cadillac Escalade and Cadillac Escalade ESV.

The agency’s initial investigation looked into 877,710 GM vehicles over reports of engine failures involving vehicles with the V8 engine. After its own investigations, GM voluntarily recalled 597,630 U.S. vehicles from model years 2021 through 2024 equipped with the engine on April 24, 2025, in the United States. GM recalled about 721,000 vehicles globally, which includes the U.S. figures.

In October of that year, regulators opened an engineering analysis to investigate the success of the recall. The new engineering analysis covered 286,000 vehicles that were part of NHTSA’s original investigation but weren’t covered under a voluntary recall GM issued earlier that year.

The agency’s Office of Defects Investigation opened another recall investi-



The National Highway Traffic Safety Association expanded its investigation on Aug. 21 into General Motors vehicles for engine failure risks after the agency received hundreds of post-remedy consumer complaints.
PROVIDED BY GM

gation into the engine fixes on Jan. 16.

The new Aug. 21, 2026, investigation adds 2025 and 2026 model years, ballooning the number of vehicles to 997,743 in the United States.

GM has not changed its recall, which still stands at 597,630 U.S. vehicles from model years 2021 to 2024.

What to do if your car is affected

As part of GM’s recall remedy, cus-

tomers were required to bring their vehicles to franchised GM dealerships for an engine inspection.

If the engine passed muster, the vehicle would receive a higher viscosity oil, which also requires a new oil fill cap and an oil filter replacement. But if the engines failed the diagnostic test, dealerships replaced the entire engine.

Pass or fail, GM implemented a special coverage program for all the covered vehicles that protected the engines in case the engines that passed the test were to fail later. That coverage remains in effect for 10 years from the date the vehicle originally was placed in service or after reaching 150,000 miles.

Despite the two possible fixes, NHTSA has received 499 complaints of post-remedy engine failures in those recalls. Of those complaints, 473 customers claimed they received an oil viscosity change and another 26 a full engine replacement. On top of that, a further 191 complaints were submitted of L87 engine failures in engines produced after the production period cited in the recall, the agency said.

It added that GM reported 6,953 complaints of post-remedy engine failure.

GM

Continued from Page 1B

headquartered in Washington, DC, is “building momentum with other products and customers. Those customers include the U.S. State Department and Secret Service, Canada, Qatar, Brazil and “other allies.”

“We’re also supplying battery propulsion technology to Lunar Outpost, which has been awarded a \$220 million NASA contract to build the next generation lunar terrain vehicle,” Barra said.

In May, NASA said GM will build the battery for the next lunar terrain vehicle designed to establish the first long-term human presence on the moon. GM Defense will be a subcontractor in the development of the “Pegasus” Lunar Terrain Vehicle to support NASA’s Artemis mission in 2028 alongside prime contractor Lunar Outpost, Goodyear Tire and Leidos.

GM also is working with Lockheed Martin and other leading companies “to expand speed, scale, and resilience in the defense industrial base,” Barra said.

As The Free Press reported in April, senior defense officials in the Trump administration have had discussions with Ford Motor Co. and GM about the possibility of the automakers’ workforces and factories making munitions to help restock supplies depleted by wars in Ukraine and Iran.

As The Free Press reported in July, GM started collaborations with Lockheed Martin to provide strategic support and potentially munitions parts as part of a Department of War, formally the Department of Defense, initiative to “triple or quadruple” weapons production over the next several years.

Ford also is in discussions with the U.S. government over defense-related projects.

Barra told investors that she sees GM Defense as an increasingly vital part of the automaker’s revenue stream.

“We’re focusing our efforts on strengthening supply chain management, improving manufacturing readiness, and expanding production capacity in ways that serve the United States and its allies well,” Barra said. “Over time, all of this should make GM Defense a more meaningful and diversified

contributor to our earnings.”

Wall Street smiled favorably on the prospects.

“GM is in pole position to benefit from this massive increase in U.S. Defense spending and could be an incremental boom to the GM story,” Dan Ives, partner and senior managing director at New York-based investment banking firm Yorkville Ives, told The Free Press. “Ford is also going after this piece of pie and Barra and team have strategically put GM in the catbird’s seat to get Beltway deals as they are approved in the budget.”

Morningstar’s David Whiston told The Free Press any gains are long overdue given that GM’s various new verticals are something it has talked about since 2021.

“Defense, software and insurance are all interesting growth stories that all will likely keep growing for a while,” Whiston said. “Defense and NASA may be more lumpy as that’s subject to government spending.”

Whiston said GM’s update on revenue from its subscriptions to OnStar and its hands-free driving technology, SuperCruise, also was interesting be-

cause they deliver higher gross profit margins than the legacy business of selling new cars.

“For now, none of these are really big relative to the total size of GM but they all have attractive option value for investors,” Whiston said.

Similarly, Barra said there is the software services growth. She said the high-profit-margin software and services revenues continue to grow rapidly with 1 million new subscriptions expected this year, contributing to more than \$3 billion in recognized revenue.

Finally, she said, GM Insurance is reaching critical mass thanks to what she called GM’s “unique value propositions.”

“For example, when a customer purchases GM Insurance, we create a recurring revenue stream from premiums, along with incremental parts and vehicle sales, all while driving customer loyalty and higher satisfaction,” Barra said. “The business has scaled from three states in early 2024 to 21 states today, making GM Insurance available to over 60% of GM’s U.S. sales, and we are on track to reach over 80% in the near term.”

Best

Continued from Page 1B

choice either.

Toyota’s Corolla nameplate is available as a hatchback or four-door sedan, and it has consistently been one of the most affordable cars on the market since its American arrival in 1968. Decades later, the Corolla remains a top choice in its segment and is now offered as a hybrid with tons of available features.

Honda’s midsize sedan could be the best car ever

The Honda Accord is another Japanese sedan that readers submitted for the title of Best Car Ever. The Accord is a popular midsize car that regularly competes with the Toyota Camry.

Accord models have roomy interiors and they’re sporty. There are also plenty of aftermarket parts available for auto enthusiasts, and the midsize sedan can stand the test of time. In terms of driving verve, the Accord certainly has the edge over the Corolla and is a better family vehicle because of its superior cabin and cargo space.

The Honda Odyssey is the only van pick from readers

A minivan may not be the first thing that comes to mind when you think of the best cars ever made, but the Honda Odyssey was one of the models mentioned by readers responding to our newsletter. The Odyssey arrived in America as a 1995 model year and has remained a staple in the brand’s portfolio for more than three decades.

Drivers love the Odyssey because it has a strong base engine, plenty of cargo space and easy-to-stow seats. It’s an affordable family minivan that can last for more than 15 years with regular maintenance.

Lexus’ ES is a best car ever contender, our audience says

The first Lexus ES (or Executive Sedan) generation was unveiled in America in 1989 as a luxury sedan. The ES is

known for its smooth ride, solid gas mileage and reliability. It’s one of the few luxury models our readers suggested would be worthy of the title of best car ever. Lexus no longer makes gas ES models, but it still offers a hybrid ES and an electric version of the sedan. Fans of the nameplate can find plenty of used gas Lexus ES models on sites like CarMax for affordable prices with relatively low mileage.

Toyota MR2 made a huge impact before its discontinuation

Toyota’s MR2 was introduced to the American market in 1985 and was discontinued after the 2005 model year. It may not have lasted as long as other Toyota nameplates on this list of best cars ever, but it made a huge splash in its 20-year run.

It’s a two-seater midengine rear-wheel drive sports car that was fun to drive because of its great handling and lightweight body. Toyota never made a direct replacement of the MR2, but the automaker still makes plenty of affordable sports cars for driving enthusiasts like the GR86 and GR Supra. Toyota doesn’t just make reliable cars – it also makes fun tuners and daily drivers.

Lexus LS is the most expensive car suggested by readers

The Lexus LS hit the American market in 1989 and was discontinued for the 2026 model year. Its 2025 model year started at \$80,335.

Lexus’ first four LS generations all featured a powerful V8 engine. The LS is also known for its quiet ride, great value and enjoyable performance. In terms of raw power and style, the LS is one of the most worthy models on our list of best cars ever.

Our next big question to readers

We can’t give away everything coming in our next USA TODAY Cars newsletter, but we can tease one of the main questions we’ll pose to our readers. What is your first or favorite car you’ve ever owned? Feel free to send us your submissions along with pics of your most cherished ride to be featured in our next story.

Corvette

Continued from Page 1B

estimated output of 600 horsepower and more than 600 pound-feet of torque. Though the modern Grand Sports are road cars, the original was meant for racing and was not built for regular roads.

One of the most important changes to this car compared with the road-going variants was the lightweight fiberglass body, thinner panels, fixed headlights and other weight-saving additions. Most of the steel in the car was replaced with aluminum and the wheels with lighter-weight magnesium. The regular Corvettes of this era weighed about 3,200 pounds; the Grand Sport was trimmed to 1,900 pounds.

How does a Corvette command this big of a price tag?

The Corvette is referred to by many as the working man’s sports car. It offers the performance to compete with the best-performing cars from Europe

at a fraction of the price. Though that’s still somewhat true today when focusing on the lower trims, auction vehicles are in a different class.

The 1963 Grand Sport is one of five models built by the secret Chevrolet racing program under Arkus-Duntov. It’s a purpose-built race car made to compete with the Shelby Cobra on the track and defeated it, earning the nickname “Snake Eaters.”

Race cars of this tier get sold at auction for high prices because of how rare they are and what they accomplished. The 1963 Grand Sport is a legend in American motorsports history and probably won’t be driven much by whoever wins the auction. The 1963 is even rarer than other legendary race cars such as the Ferrari 250 GTO and Shelby Cobra Daytona Coupe.

Gord Duff, president of RM Sotheby’s, spoke in a video on the auction company’s website about what makes this Corvette Grand Sport so valuable. “The greatest competition cars are not valued just on rarity alone. Yes, it’s one of five but they need great provenance, they need great drivers, they need great engineering and they need to win races. This car has all of those features.”

Harley

Continued from Page 1B

model for the motor company.”

Harley-Davidson reported a profit of \$80 million, which is a 26% decline from the second quarter in 2025. Still, the company did ship 39,200 motorcycles, which is a 9% increase from 2025, and had revenue of \$1.1 billion, a 6% increase from 2025. Worldwide, the company saw a 1% increase in units sold to 42,500.

That said, in the second quarter, the parts and accessories segment of Harley-Davidson was down 5% to \$177 million compared to the same point in 2025.

Customization plays a role in the strategy to increase growth, and Harley-Davidson has also taken feedback from dealerships.

Keith Ulicki, owner of Uke’s Harley-

Davidson in Kenosha, Wisconsin, said the company putting a greater emphasis on customization is good for dealerships.

“That’s been missing, and they’ve been letting the aftermarket companies come in and take that market over. So it’s good that they’re coming out with [parts],” Ulicki said. Harley-Davidson “produces the bike, so when they come out with new models, they can come out with parts and accessories right away because they have the jump on everybody.”

He added, “It’s about time they changed that.”

Ulicki said he believes riders are going to respond well to the new strategy.

“Instead of looking at the internet or through a computer, they can see the parts in stock and see what they are,” Ulicki said. “Anything – accessories, any customized piece that’s not on a standard bike – they can see and customize themselves.”

50★States

News from across the USA

ALABAMA Gadsden: Gadsden State Community College and the city broke ground on a new 10-court tennis center at the Gadsden Sports Park, the latest project in an ongoing partnership to expand athletic and recreational facilities in the city.

ALASKA Juneau: The Juneau Assembly recently voted to sell City Hall to the Sealaska Heritage Institute for \$1.5 million, clearing the way for the nonprofit to demolish the building and develop a proposed \$40 million arts and cultural tourism complex in downtown Juneau, KTOO reported.

ARIZONA Coconino County: After four years of planning, engineering and community review, the Havasupai Tribe broke ground July 31 for construction of a long-awaited, and long-needed, broadband system that will bring the West’s most remote tribal community closer to the world.

ARKANSAS Fort Smith: The University of Arkansas-Fort Smith will open its new Center for Book Arts this fall, creating a space where students and community members can explore traditional bookmaking techniques through hands-on instruction, workshops and exhibitions.

CALIFORNIA Sacramento: California announced that it will implement the nation’s first energy-efficiency standards for replacement tires.

COLORADO Fort Collins: A young black bear found itself wandering the Colorado State University campus as about 6,000 students moved into dormitories on Aug. 18. Colorado Parks and Wildlife spokesperson Kara Van Hoose said the bear caused no known conflicts but was safely tranquilized and relocated.

CONNECTICUT New London County: Connecticut Foodshare and United Way of Southeastern Connecticut have signed a seven-year agreement aimed at expanding food assistance efforts across New London County, continuing a partnership that supports local pantries, meal programs and food distribution services.

DELAWARE Rehoboth Beach: Five red oak trees in Rehoboth Beach’s closed Grove Park infected with a quickly spreading disease must be removed immediately, according to arborists, and 14 more trees there are under evaluation after being flagged as possibly unhealthy.

DISTRICT OF COLUMBIA Washington: Officials said a teenage girl died after first responders pulled her from the Potomac River near the Francis Scott Key Bridge on Aug. 22, DC News Now reported.

FLORIDA Tallahassee: The Florida panther is at a recovery crossroads as it appears the population may be shrinking in overall numbers, a trend that, if true, could mean the state animal will face extinction in the foreseeable future.

GEORGIA Lexington: A federal grant of \$25,000 has been awarded to Lexington for repairs to the Beth Salem Church building, the Georgia State Historic Preservation Office said.

HAWAII Honolulu: American Savings Bank, formerly a subsidiary of utility firm Hawaiian Electric, said it has filed for a U.S. initial public offering.

IDAHO Boise: The state has received nearly \$1 billion in federal funding to help transform rural health care delivery over the next five years, KTVB7 reported, and applications are being accepted now for the first wave of funds.

ILLINOIS Chicago: Residential energy company Solrite Energy said it expects to enroll up to 1,000 Illinois households in its virtual power plant program by year end, as it bets that rising electricity costs would drive demand for home battery systems.

INDIANA Indianapolis: Gov. Mike Braun is calling for an investigation into Northern Indiana Public Service Company following prolonged power outages still affecting Gary and Portage after storms and flooding earlier in August.

IOWA Iowa City: The city is investing nearly \$2 million to help local organizations improve public access to the arts. The City Council approved a resolution to establish an Iowa City Endowment for the Arts, a self-sustaining funding source for local arts programs.

KANSAS Edgerton: The cities of Edgerton, El Dorado and Emporia want to halt citizen-led petitions that, if implemented, would ban data centers of a certain size via ordinance.

HIGHLIGHT: KENTUCKY



This year, Ark Encounter in Williamstown, Kentucky, is on track to have its lowest ticket sales since it opened in 2016. ALBERT CESARE/USA TODAY NETWORK

Williamstown: A replica of Noah’s Ark – 510 feet long and more than five stories high – has drawn millions of people to rural Northern Kentucky for the past decade. It has become like the Disneyland of religious tourism in the region, minus the major rides. The roughly \$100-million attraction celebrated its 10-year anniversary this summer with guest speakers and a concert series. But it also hit two other milestones: the loss of its multimillion-dollar tourism tax breaks and the lowest ticket sales reported since it opened, excluding 2020.

LOUISIANA St. Bernard Parish: The Gulf Coast is preparing for a new generation of container shipping as the Louisiana International Terminal nears construction, with a federal permit now in hand.

MAINE Saco: Leap N Learn held a Kids Summer Fest on Aug. 22, featuring an obstacle course and arts and crafts, to thank the community for helping keep the day care open, WMTW reported.

MARYLAND Hagerstown: The new building sign for the renamed Thomas J. Garner Elementary School was installed on Aug. 19. The school was recently renamed to honor its late principal, Tom Garner, who died in October 2025. A ribbon-cutting for the school will be held on Sept. 3, said Marcie Bureson, the school’s academic achievement coordinator.

MASSACHUSETTS Dartmouth: The University of Massachusetts Dartmouth School of Law is welcoming its largest incoming class ever, with 148 students beginning their legal education ahead of the 2026-27 academic year. The record-setting class follows an admissions cycle that attracted more than 1,500 applicants, a 45% increase over three years, according to a community announcement.

MICHIGAN Lansing: When Michigan public school students return to the classroom this year, they can head to their school cafeteria and have breakfast and lunch for free. A program Michigan started funding in the 2023-24 school year is returning for the 2026-27 school year. The state’s education budget, signed into law in July, includes \$200 million to continue free school meals for 1.4 million public school students.

MINNESOTA St. Paul: A federal judge dismissed a lawsuit brought by nursing home industry leaders seeking to dissolve the state’s nursing home labor standards board, which the Legislature created in 2023 to set minimum wages and employment standards, Minnesota Reformer reported.

MISSISSIPPI Jackson: A monthlong labor dispute that disrupted Jackson’s public transit system has ended after JTRAN drivers and MV Transportation reached and ratified a new contract agreement, city officials announced.

MISSOURI Springfield: Ozarks Food Harvest distributed 23 million meals across southwest Missouri during its most recent fiscal year, supporting children, families and seniors through a network of faith-based and community organizations. The food bank expanded several hunger-relief programs between July 2025 and June 2026, according to a community announcement.

MONTANA Helena: Prickly Pear Land Trust announced the permanent protection of 198 acres at War Eagle Hill near Fort Harrison through a partnership with the Montana National Guard and Double L Family Land, preserving wildlife habitat, public hunting access and open space around the military base, The Daily Montanan reported.

NEBRASKA Lincoln: The University of Nebraska Foundation announced a record \$532.8 million in new funds committed to the University of Nebraska, KOLN reported.

NEVADA Las Vegas: The Nevada Transportation Authority approved applications by Tesla, Waymo and Uber subsidiary Aviri to operate as autonomous vehicle network companies in the state.

NEW HAMPSHIRE Hampton: Police are investigating a scam that swindled an elderly couple out of their home and savings in an elaborate scheme known as a Publishers Clearing House scam.

NEW JERSEY Trenton: More New Jersey private-sector workers will soon have access to a state-run retirement program designed to ensure that people can save for their golden years. Starting in September, program eligibility will expand to businesses that have 10 or more employees, have been in operation for at least two years and do not already offer a retirement plan.

NEW MEXICO Santa Fe: Summer sales have spelled big money for New Mexico’s cannabis industry. As of June 2026, the state has officially surpassed \$2.35 billion in cannabis sales – more than \$1.7 billion in adult-use recreational sales and nearly \$643 million in medical sales, according to the New Mexico Regulations and Licensing Department’s Cannabis Reporting Online Portal. The latest numbers represent a boost of almost \$150 million since March.

NEW YORK Albany: Several Republican lawmakers in New York are pushing to restore funding for New York’s crime victim assistance centers as they’re expected to take a funding hit in the coming months. Senate Republicans sent a letter to Gov. Kathy Hochul asking for increased funding for the impacted rape crisis centers, domestic violence centers and child advocacy centers as well as to provide them with a “more stable and predictable funding stream.”

NORTH CAROLINA Pender County: Seven of Pender County’s 16 public schools are over capacity going into the 2026-27 school year. While relief is on the way in the form of two new schools opening, data shows that it won’t be long before growth is again straining the school system.

NORTH DAKOTA Bismarck: Sen. John Hoeven said North Dakota’s Theodore Roosevelt National Park wild horses are not affected by reports that some Bureau of Land Management horses have entered the slaughter pipeline, citing the herd’s separate protections, KFYYR reported.

OHIO Columbus: Chronically struggling public schools could be converted into charter schools, have their leadership replaced or be forced to close, according to proposed changes Ohio wants federal education officials to approve. The proposal lists 16 ways to improve the state’s lowest-performing schools, which include high schools where at least a third of students do not graduate. But Ohio school leaders worry the changes go too far and weren’t properly vetted.

OKLAHOMA Oklahoma City: Four people were taken to area hospitals after a school bus carrying Mustang High School students from the Canadian Valley Technology Center and another vehicle crashed west of the Oklahoma City metro on Aug. 24.

OREGON Salem: A deep drawdown of the Detroit Reservoir would risk “causing catastrophic damage” to Salem’s water filtration systems and endanger the drinking water supply for its 220,000 residents, attorneys for the city wrote in a request for a preliminary injunction filed in federal court.

PENNSYLVANIA Pittsburgh: An 18-year-old in Pennsylvania is accused of stabbing his girlfriend to death, and his mother is accused of helping him cover it up, according to investigators in criminal complaints against the pair.

RHODE ISLAND Providence: A drought watch, as expected, will remain in place in Rhode Island for another month. Despite record-breaking rainfall in July and continued precipitation in August, groundwater resources still aren’t back to levels that would support lifting the watch designation, members of a state committee said.

SOUTH CAROLINA Greenville: Students at Greenville County Schools outperformed the state in SC READY, End-of-Course, and Career Ready Assessments in the 2025-26 academic year.

SOUTH DAKOTA Pierre: A South Dakota Health Department official told lawmakers that the number of medical marijuana patients in the state who are licensed to grow medical cannabis at home has grown by more than 1,000% over the past four years, South Dakota Searchlight reported.

TENNESSEE Nashville: Anheuser-Busch InBev sued the state of Tennessee and its Commissioner of Revenue David Gerregano, claiming state officials wrongfully denied the company a \$1.8 million tax refund.

TEXAS Dallas: A laptop caught fire on an American Airlines flight on Aug. 21, with one passenger treated after the plane landed in Dallas-Fort Worth.

UTAH Cedar City: Southern Utah University has been selected by NASA to lead Utah’s new statewide Aerospace Skilled Technical Workforce Hub, connecting schools, colleges and industry partners to expand career pathways and help build the state’s future aerospace workforce, KSL reported.

VERMONT Montpelier: Vermont fifth-graders will again have the opportunity to elect a “kid governor” during the 2026-27 school year as the state continues the civic education program introduced last year.

VIRGINIA Arlington: For more than a century and a half, the teenage soldier lay buried and forgotten on a Virginia battlefield. This fall, the unidentified Union soldier will receive the honor he never got in life: a military burial at Arlington National Cemetery. Researchers believe he was only 16 to 19 years old when he fought and died during the Second Battle of Manassas in 1862, one of the Civil War’s bloodiest struggles.

WASHINGTON Kitsap County: The Kitsap Public Health District issued advisories warning residents to avoid all contact with Wye Lake and Panther Lake due to the presence of potentially toxic cyanobacteria.

WEST VIRGINIA Mill Creek: Valley Health Care recently celebrated the grand opening of its new Mill Creek Health Center, a renovated and expanded facility that more than doubles its clinical space and is expected to improve access to primary, specialty and behavioral health services in rural Randolph County, WDTV reported.

WISCONSIN Waukesha: Gas engine manufacturer Innio plans to invest more than \$300 million in its Waukesha facility and to create more than 500 jobs in the coming years – in part due to increased business with data centers.

WYOMING Laramie: The city of Laramie’s new bike park held its grand opening on Aug. 22, WyoFile reported. The park includes beginner, intermediate and advanced mountain bike features, according to the news outlet.

From USA TODAY Network and wire reports

Carvana’s new-car push is rattling dealers

Juggernaut has rapidly grown its business

Luke Ramseth
The Detroit News
USA TODAY NETWORK

Used car juggernaut Carvana has rapidly grown its business selling new cars over the past few months, data shows, using an established nationwide logistics system to ship Chrysler, Dodge, Jeep and Ram vehicles to customers who often live hundreds of miles from its nearest dealership.

Since last year, Carvana bought seven Stellantis NV dealerships spread across the country for a combined \$200 million. But similar to its existing used car operation – long known for a streamlined no-haggle online buying process and home delivery – the company has been shipping its new cars to customers who live all over the country, not just near its stores.

In June, 1,378 new Carvana-purchased vehicles were registered in 1,205 ZIP codes across 37 states, according to an analysis by Chris Wood, vice president of automotive client strategy for USA TODAY Co.’s LocalIQ Automotive. He said Carvana has steadily opened up online ordering in more cities and states this year, from New York to Wisconsin, though Michigan shoppers still aren’t able to use the company’s new-car purchasing feature. Carvana often advertises free shipping and next-day delivery for the new vehicles listed on its website.

Carvana’s aggressive entry into the new car world has rattled some Stellantis dealers and is being closely watched by other industry insiders who wonder how it might affect an overall franchised dealership system that counts 16,990 retailers who did \$1.3 trillion in sales in the United States last year.

The company hasn’t publicly reported its new car sales or discussed in detail how that side of its business is performing, but the vehicle registration data compiled by Wood’s research indicates Carvana is rapidly gaining steam. From March to June, its new car registrations surged by 65%, and its market share doubled – growing even as overall

new Chrysler, Dodge, Jeep and Ram registrations declined. In all, more than 4,300 new vehicles purchased from Carvana were registered over those four months, surpassing such big retailers as AutoNation.

Carvana’s new car business is “going to continue to grow,” Wood said. “We’ve seen it each month – the numbers keep ticking up. I don’t see a ceiling for them at this point.”

From a few dozen sold to nearly 1,000 at Phoenix CDJR store

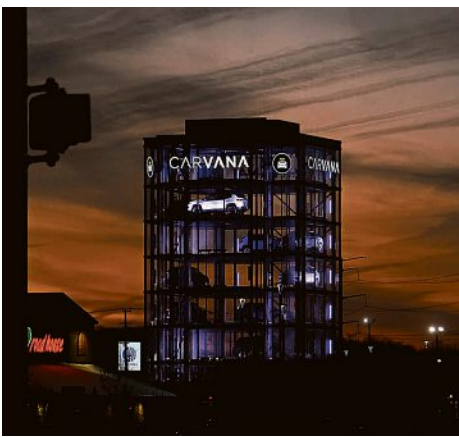
Dealer sales figures obtained by The Detroit News confirm the growth. In June, Carvana’s CDJR store near Phoenix sold nearly 1,000 new cars – three times the next-closest Stellantis retailer in the automaker’s 2,400-member dealer network. Before Carvana bought the dealership last year, it typically sold a few dozen new cars each month. The same Phoenix-area store continues to lead the rankings by a wide margin in August.

Stellantis dealers have grown concerned that Carvana could upend their dealer model and siphon sales from their stores. They’ve questioned whether the automaker is treating Carvana the same as its other dealers on rules such as website standards, allocation of vehicles, and the ability to ship new cars free all over the country. They’ve also raised concerns about whether Carvana is taking care of customers, including with vehicle maintenance and repairs, at the same level their own dealerships must.

“Dealers welcome the challenge, so long as it’s fair,” said Sean Hogan, a Los Angeles-area retailer who heads the national Stellantis dealer council.

Hogan said Stellantis leaders have assured retailers in recent meetings that there has not been preferential treatment for Carvana. But concerns remain, especially over Carvana’s service capacity and whether the company can handle customers who need assistance after the sale. Carvana says its franchises are fully operational and can support customers however they need, including with vehicle service.

Stellantis, for its part, said it’s committed to treating all its dealers fairly



Carvana’s used car business is known for its “vending machines” located around the country, including this one in Novi, Michigan. But many customers opt to have their car delivered.

DAVID GURALNICK/USA TODAY NETWORK

and in line with its various dealer agreements and policies. “Maintaining the confidence of our dealers in the fairness and integrity of the franchise system is critically important to us,” a statement from spokesperson Ann Marie Fortunate said. “We remain focused on building a healthy, competitive dealer network that provides exceptional service for our customers with the brands and products they love and trust.”

Carvana’s evolution in new cars: From ‘experiment’ to ‘playgrounds’

For Carvana, the entry into new cars – which CEO Ernie Garcia previously described as an “experimenting and learning” process – is made easier by its existing used car sales infrastructure. That includes its streamlined online purchase process, its existing sites for vehicle storage and reconditioning already scattered around the country, and a beefy digital advertising presence.

And unlike typical CDJR dealers, Carvana is sending its new cars all over the place: From April to June, just 27% of its new car sales were registered in the same market as one of its seven dealerships, Wood’s report found. That’s compared with 86% of vehicles staying in the home market for the average CDJR dealer.

Though a handful of CDJR dealers

also specialize in shipping new vehicles long distances to the customer’s door, often out of state, it’s difficult to compete with the size and scope of Carvana’s existing logistics system that’s already set up to sell used cars, Wood said.

Another advantage for Carvana as it quickly grows its new car sales is the company’s in-house financing operation, said Kevin Tynan, director of research at the Presidio Group, an investment banking and advisory firm that works with dealers. That gives Carvana flexibility to finance a wider variety of customers, including those with lower credit scores whom a traditional dealer might not be able to serve because of more restrictive terms of the banks it works with.

“If I were looking at it through their lens, I’d be pretty happy with how things have gone,” Tynan said of Carvana’s foray into new vehicles, adding he’ll be watching to see if the company seeks to sell other brands beyond the Stellantis stable of Chrysler, Dodge, Jeep and Ram.

The new car side of Carvana’s business is profitable, Garcia said on a recent earnings call in which he described positive customer feedback. In June, the company unveiled a new concept for in-person new car shopping at its Dallas CDJR dealership that includes “playgrounds” for customers to experience various vehicles.

At the Dallas “test drive center,” customers are encouraged to use their smartphones to explore Jeep Wranglers, Chrysler Pacificas or Ram 1500s on the lot in a self-directed way. But just like with Carvana’s used-car business, all purchases must take place online. Carvana hasn’t yet discussed plans to roll out additional test drive centers at its other Stellantis dealerships in Ohio, Massachusetts, Georgia, Arizona and California. The company’s new car business “is still in its very early days,” Garcia said, declining to go into detail with analysts. “The operational implications of new cars are very different than used cars. In used cars, we need to kind of re-manufacture those cars. In new cars, you are outsourcing manufacturing to somebody else. It’s a simpler operational problem for us.”





TOP WORK PLACES 2027

USA

It starts with a nomination... and ends in Boston!





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QUACK ATTACK

Dan Lanning is just Steve Sarkisian in Ducks gear; prove me wrong



Blake Toppmeyer
Columnist
USA TODAY NETWORK

What’s the difference between Steve Sarkisian and Dan Lanning? One pays no state income tax (and everyone in Texas said, amen). The other bears slight resemblance to Chris Pratt. • Otherwise, these two coaches seem like the same guy. • That’s not a stinging criticism, just an observation. Most schools would be fortunate to employ either. They’re top-10 coaches at premier jobs, but they don’t win the biggest games. • That’s the rub. • You say Lanning once beat Ryan Day, I say Sarkisian once beat Nick Saban.

You say Lanning won the Big Ten in Oregon’s first year in the conference and reached the College Football Playoff semifinals the following year, I say Sarkisian reached the playoff semifinals in consecutive seasons.

Each guy has pelts on the wall. Neither has advanced to a national championship game, despite persistently loaded teams.

(As an aside, neither beats Kalen DeBoer, either. Alabama’s highly scrutinized coach went a combined 5-0 against Lanning and Sarkisian while at Washington, but that’s a subject for another day.)

Sarkisian came closer to reaching a season’s finish line than Lanning. Texas’ semifinal games in the 2023 and ’24 seasons came down to the wire. By halftime of Oregon’s



Dan Lanning
4
seasons with the Ducks
48-8
record
6
bowl appearances



Steve Sarkisian
5
seasons with the Longhorns
48-20
record
6
bowl appearances

blowout playoff losses the past two seasons, you were wondering what’s airing on MeTV.

“We’re close,” Lanning told reporters at Big Ten Media Days.

Well, the Peach Bowl wasn’t close. So, why is it only one of these coaches, Sarkisian, faces much pre-season scrutiny, while the other’s team gets feted?

Oregon is ranked No. 2 in each of college football’s major polls. The Ducks received 14 first-place votes in the Associated Press Top 25.

Texas is No. 4 in the US LBM Coaches Poll and No. 5 in the AP. The Longhorns did not receive a single first-place vote among the 69 media members who voted in the AP poll.

Why so much skepticism for Sark

See TOPPMEYER, Page 2C



PHOTOS BY MICHAEL REAVES/GETTY IMAGES AND TIM HEITMAN/IMAGN IMAGES VIA REUTERS CONNECT

Power leagues consider ban on a pro return

Craig Meyer
USA TODAY NETWORK

What was already an eventful and dizzying offseason in college football got a bit more surreal over the past several days, with players who had been with NFL teams during the preseason and in training camp making the once-unthinkable move back to college.

Now, arguably the biggest, most powerful entity in college athletics is trying to do something about it.

The Big Ten is set to pass a rule that would forbid NFL players from returning to college and suiting up for a Big Ten school, according to a report from ESPN on Aug. 25.

The report added that the measure would apply to anyone who declared for the NFL draft and didn’t withdraw, appeared on an NFL roster or signed a contract with a professional team, which would extend the rule’s scope beyond just the NFL.

The impending action comes after LSU is set to add two players, tight end Dae’Quan Wright and defensive lineman Zxavian Harris, who played for new Tigers coach Lane Kiffin at Ole Miss before signing NFL contracts. Both players were granted a temporary restraining order against the NCAA by a Louisiana judge. Other college players who spent time with NFL franchises during the preseason, such as former Oregon State and Colorado running back Anthony Hankerson, are exploring a return to the college game.

The Big Ten may not be alone, either.

According to a report Tuesday from Yahoo Sports, the ACC and Big 12 are also set to explore a ban on professional players. Additionally, Yahoo reported that SEC presidents are expected to direct athletic directors against adding professional players and doing so under

See BAN, Page 2C



Enes Kanter Freedom had stated an intent to apply for the 2027 WNBA draft. PATRICK GORSKI/IMAGN IMAGES

Former NBA players are ineligible for WNBA draft

Callie Fin
USA TODAY

Former NBA players Enes Kanter Freedom and Royce White are not eligible to enter the WNBA draft after declaring themselves women in separate “publicity stunts” in early August, a person with direct knowledge of the situation told USA TODAY Sports.

The person spoke on condition of anonymity because they were not authorized to speak publicly. The person said Aug. 24 that the league is not going to “give oxygen to efforts designed to mock the league or use this topic to demean or marginalize others.”

Kanter Freedom and White inserted themselves into the conversation around trans athlete participation in women’s sports on Aug. 7, fanning flames that began intensifying when

See INELIGIBLE, Page 2C

College coaches talk on NFLers seeking to return

Matthew Glenesk, Jordan Mendoza and Zac Al-Khateeb
USA TODAY

Another day, another controversy in college sports. The latest entry into what has already been a chaotic football offseason is unprecedented in the sport. As state courts issue temporary restraining orders across the country, players who have been signed by NFL teams or thought to be out of eligibility are being cleared to return to play another season in college. In some cases, agreements are already in place for players to return, such as Lane Kiffin and LSU gaining commitments from former Ole Miss standouts Dae’Quan Wright and Zxavian Harris. What college coaches are saying:

Lane Kiffin, LSU

“Through (players) winning injunctions and entry into the portal, they are available to recruit. Ourselves and many places around the country are recruiting them,” Kiffin said. “Because of the rulings, they are going to play for you or someone else. We made the decision to recruit them. It’s wrong to be critical of these kids. They were granted a fifth year and a judge said they were wronged.”

Dan Lanning, Oregon

“I think there’s a lot of negatives that are involved around it,” Lanning said. “One, once you go to the NFL, to me, you’re in the NFL. You don’t get the opportunity to come back. Two, most of us have built our rosters, and you have a limited roster limit now. So if you invited somebody back to your team, that means you’re kicking somebody else off your team to match your roster limits. I don’t think that’s fair to the players that worked all summer, all spring, and put themselves in position to be ready to work for a team to have somebody come back.”

Ryan Day, Ohio State

“If there are teams that have some players out there who are cut from NFL rosters that are gonna be on other teams, we have to at least consider it and look at it,” Day said. “Do I like anything about it? Absolutely not, but we gotta do what’s right for Ohio State.”

Kalen DeBoer, Alabama

“Overall, as a general, how that works, (Alabama athletics director) Greg Byrne’s communicating with me and us about just what we can and can’t do,” DeBoer said. “There’s a possibility out there of someone that was on our roster in the past, but right now, he wouldn’t be able to come in and play. So I can’t control that. I can’t worry about that. We’ve just got to see how things move forward and progress.”

Barry Odom, Purdue

“Would I take Mani Powell back? That’d be kind of fun,” Odom said of last year’s starting middle linebacker, now with the Tennessee Titans. “But who am I going to walk in the locker room and say ‘Hey, all the work you’ve put in from January to today, I appreciate it, but we’ve got this guy, he just played the Miami Dolphins last week, and he’s going to take your locker and scholarship and your game time.’”

Bob Chesney, UCLA

The Bruins just added former James Madison linebacker and reigning Sun Belt Conference Defensive Player of the Year Trent Hendrick, who joins after he was one of the players granted an extra season with the temporary restraining order. He was practicing with the team on Aug. 24. While he was undrafted and did participate in NFL minicamps with the Kansas Chiefs and Cleveland Browns, he did not sign. Chesney said the familiarity with Hendricks played a key role in wanting him to come to UCLA. “We’re slowly moving to more of a you know AAA team for the NFL in a way, and I think that just is what it is. We had that conversation with the team, and I think they all left at the end of it, linebackers in particular, of thank-you. I think that they said ‘I’m sure many coaches and many programs that never would even have that conversation. The kid would just show up.’ So I think it’s important that we had those conversations about who he was as a player, that he’s guaranteed nothing, and just like everybody on this team, whatever they’re going to get, they got to work for.” Chesney said Hendricks does not impact the roster limit and is on track to play in the season opener.

Ineligible

Continued from Page 1C

Indiana Fever guard Sophie Cunningham said young girls playing sports “shouldn’t have to go against biological men.” The WNBA collective bargaining agreement requires “only players who are women are eligible to play in the WNBA.” The league does not have a gender inclusion policy that would outline the eligibility of transgender or intersex athletes. There are no eligibility matters requiring action by the WNBA, the person with direct knowledge said, describing the gender declarations by Kanter Freedom and White as “manufactured controversy” and attempts “to sow division and get attention.” The news comes one day after Kanter Freedom was escorted out of a game between the Indiana Fever and Chicago Sky at Wintrust Arena in Chicago after a verbal exchange with Sky guard Natasha Cloud. Kanter Freedom, the No. 3 pick by the Utah Jazz in the 2011 NBA draft, was sitting courtside in a black T-shirt that said “WOMAN noun. adult human female.” Cloud walked toward Kanter Freedom during a timeout and shouted at him. Kanter Freedom, standing with his arms outstretched, stepped onto the court and past photographers before security intervened. “I just got kicked out of a @WNBA game for supporting WOMEN!” Kanter Freedom wrote on social media after the incident. “Let that sink in, AMERICA!” The WNBA has not announced plans to keep Kanter Freedom from attending games. Kanter Freedom, 34, had an 11-year

career in the NBA, playing from 2011 to 2022. White, 35, was the No. 16 pick by the Houston Rockets in 2012 but played in three games during his career, all with the Sacramento Kings. The players added to the national discourse about transgender athlete participation in the WNBA on Aug. 7 when they declared they would identify as women and enter the 2027 WNBA draft. A transgender woman has never played in the WNBA, but the league has become a lightning rod for the topic after comments made by Cunningham were published in an ESPN story on July 21. Legislation passed in 27 states barring transgender girls and women from participating in women’s sports is aimed at a small portion of the population – 1% of people age 13 and over in the U.S. identify as transgender, according to a 2025 study by the Williams Institute at UCLA Law. The Human Rights Campaign reported in 2023 that 19% of transgender youth nationwide were playing sports, including fewer than 1,300 who played sports in school.

Cloud stands with LGBTQIA+ community

Cloud has been a vocal advocate on many social issues since she was drafted in 2015. She didn’t speak at the Sky’s postgame media availability Sunday but addressed the transgender community via Threads that night. “To every trans kid/person, You are a part of MY community & tribe. You belong. You’re loved. You’re seen. You’re perfect as you are. & you will always be protected by me,” Cloud wrote. The league is expected to continue to have thoughtful internal conversations surrounding the topic and will ignore attempts to mock the league and demean and marginalize others, the person said.

Ban

Continued from Page 1C

the threat of penalty, as league bylaws allow conference commissioner Greg Sankey and university presidents to deem a player ineligible. The ACC and SEC declined to comment on the matter in emails to USA TODAY Sports. Similar requests to the Big Ten and Big 12 were not immediately returned. The SEC, the league where much of this pro-to-college activity has been unfolding, issued a statement Aug. 24

saying former professional athletes should not be permitted to return to college but stopped short of any sort of action. “College athletes, not former professional athletes, have been at the heart of the Southeastern Conference. Individuals who choose to leave college athletics, sign professional playing contracts, and compete professionally should not then be permitted to return to college competition,” the statement read. “Allowing that to occur will blur the line between college and professional sports, create significant competitive equity concerns, and reduce opportunities for high school and current college athletes.”

Toppmeyer

Continued from Page 1C

and Texas, while Lanning and the Ducks soak up the love?

The Oregon vs. Texas debate

OK, let’s answer that question. Four reasons why Sarkisian and Texas face more skepticism than Oregon: 1. **Recency bias.** Texas fizzled last season. Sark’s finest hours came in 2023 and ’24. Texas earned the preseason No. 1 designation last summer, but Arch Manning got off to a rocky start, Texas lost three times, and it missed the playoff. Oregon fared better. Indiana trounced the Ducks in the end, but at least Oregon made the playoff. Its only losses came to the Hoosiers, twice, the eventual champion. If you’re a poll voter who typed in Texas as preseason No. 1 last summer, you might hesitate to do it again, with ghosts of 2025 in your brain. 2. **Voters trust Dante Moore more than Manning.** Manning faced unparalleled scrutiny throughout his first full season as Texas’ starter, and The New York Times absurdly positioned Manning as the first “bust” in college football history. A perception formed that Manning performed worse than he did. He wasn’t great. He wasn’t terrible. Moore was better, although Manning faced a tougher schedule. While Manning opened his season with growing pains against Ohio State, Moore opened against Montana State. Talk about a tailor-made confidence boost. How good will Manning be in his encore? Fair question. Texas will go as he goes. 3. **Voters trust Oregon to avoid the bad loss.** As much as Sarkisian might want to point the finger at the selection committee, Texas missed the playoff last season because it lost to a bad Florida team. Oregon and Texas compiled similar records the past three seasons – the Ducks averaged one more win per season – but Lanning never served a loss as unsightly as Texas’ meltdown in The Swamp. Counterpoint: Sarkisian beat Texas A&M and Oklahoma last season, two rivals and a pair of playoff qualifiers.



Oregon coach Dan Lanning walks off the field as the Ducks practice ahead of the Orange Bowl on Dec. 30. BEN LONERGAN/THE REGISTER-GUARD – USA TODAY NETWORK



Texas Longhorns coach Steve Sarkisian looks on before the Cheez-It Citrus Bowl Dec. 31 against Michigan at Camping World Stadium. MATT PENDLETON/IMAGN IMAGES

4. **People tend to enjoy putting Texas in its place.** Before Sarkisian righted the program, Texas spent many years acting bigger and better than its record said it was. Your average observer got

exhausted by that, and “Texas is back!” became something of a punchline. So, one year after Texas failed to live up to the hype, here’s a chance to make the Longhorns earn their way to the top.

That’s fine, but if Texas must prove it, why doesn’t that same thinking apply to Oregon? Oregon’s roster is stacked. So is the team in Austin. Lanning and Sarkisian are like that Spider-Man meme. You know, the one where two Spider-Men dressed identically point at each other. We’re waiting on either to win the big one.

Are Oregon and Texas in the same boat?

Neither Texas nor Oregon would have a good excuse for not playing deep into January. True, each faces a difficult regular-season schedule, and making the finish line of a 12-team playoff is no cakewalk, but these programs are as well-positioned as any to thrive. Each program spent a war chest to assemble two of college football’s most expensive rosters. Does anyone possess a more talented roster than either Oregon or Texas? Maybe Ohio State. *Maybe.* I don’t think the conversation goes much further than that. If you’re building a preseason All-American team, keep the Oregon and Texas rosters handy. They’re armed with candidates at nearly every position. Lanning and Sarkisian each had an ample runway to establish their culture. This will be Sark’s sixth season and Lanning’s fifth. A quarterback with superstar potential headlines each team. They’ve got everything a coach could want. Ryan Day and Kirby Smart didn’t join the champions club until their sixth season. So, you could argue Lanning and Sarkisian remain on schedule. Or, you could say: I’ll believe it when I see it. I still see one Spider-Man pointing at another. Until one of these guys shows he’s made for the champions club, Lanning is Sarkisian, and Sarkisian is Lanning. *Blake Toppmeyer is the USA TODAY Network’s senior national college football columnist. Email at BToppmeyer@gannett.com and follow him on X @btoppmeyer*



ACC rivals Clemson's Dabo Swinney, left, and North Carolina's Bill Belichick will be scrutinized. BOB DONNAN/IMAGN IMAGES

Coaches are feeling the heat as season dawns this week



Blake Toppmeyer
Columnist
USA TODAY NETWORK

College football's hot seat cranked to inferno status last season. Seats melted and turned to ash across the land, from LSU to Penn State.

In the SEC and Big Ten alone, nine coaches were fired across the two super conferences.

That breakneck twirl of the coaching carousel could mean a slightly quieter spin this year. Quieter, but not silent.

Here's our list of notable coaches who'll need to beat the heat in 2026:

SCALDING HOT SEATS Luke Fickell, Wisconsin

Fickell seemed like a good choice when Wisconsin plucked him from Cincinnati, not long after he took the Bearcats to the College Football Playoff. Not all hires that look smart on paper turn out to be good in reality. Wisconsin faced a decision last year amid a second straight losing season: Fire Fickell and fork over millions in buyout bucks, or up the ante on name, image and likeness (NIL) investment. Wisconsin kept Fickell, choosing to pour more into its roster. Chris McIntosh, Wisconsin's athletic director who retained Fickell, left in April for a job at the Big Ten offices. That leaves Fickell on a scorching-hot seat, working for a boss who didn't hire him. It's win or walk, and Fickell knows it.

Mike Norvell, Florida State

Lane Kiffin sprinkled an interesting breadcrumb during his introductory news conference at LSU: He revealed *three* schools tried to hire him away from Ole Miss. LSU, Florida and ... well, Kiffin didn't reveal the third, but ESPN later reported Florida State was that mystery school. It's no surprise FSU considered ousting Norvell last year, when he served a fourth losing season in six years on the job. Norvell's big buyout (plus Kiffin choosing LSU) protected him, but he can't hide any longer. Florida State would owe Norvell a buyout of about \$45 million if it fires him after this season. That will be failure money the Seminoles must stomach if he can't reignite a starved program.

Dave Aranda, Baylor

Aranda survived the hot seat two years ago by delivering a winning record. But after going 5-7 last season, he's back in the hot box. He's put his hopes in Florida transfer quarterback DJ Lagway to bail him out of trouble. Aranda won the Big 12 championship in 2021, but that's too long ago to offer him any support. Plus, like others on this list, he's working for a different AD than the one who hired him. Like Norvell, Aranda is entering his seventh season. Coaches who fizzle in year seven typically don't see year eight.

Mike Locksley, Maryland

Locksley reiterated his recruiting chops a couple of years ago when he signed blue-chip quarterback Malik Washington. To keep his job, Locksley must show his coaching chops and accelerate in Washington's second season as the starter. Locksley delivered some solid records and bowl bids in the middle of his tenure, now entering its eighth season,

but he's only under contract through the 2027 season. That leaves him protected by a buyout that's peanuts compared to most peers. Maryland ratcheted up NIL support, and so now Locksley's gotta win, or he's gotta go.

Bill Belichick, North Carolina

Belichick hasn't just been bad for North Carolina. He's been a national embarrassment. There was his bizarre interview with CBS before he coached a game. There's the persistent drama with his 25-year-old girlfriend, aka his "Muse," who has waged a crusade against the university. Then, Belichick's GM got placed on administrative leave. Belichick might be the GOAT in the NFL, but he's a joke in college football, and it's hard to justify playing the long game with a 74-year-old coach. Either he wins now, or North Carolina can fork over \$10 million to fire him after this season and cut its losses.

Shane Beamer, South Carolina

Nobody can say Beamer didn't deliver good times for South Carolina. Twice, he beat Dabo Swinney and Clemson. His Gamecocks hung 30 points *in the first half* on then-No. 3 Texas A&M in November. Then, the second half started, and South Carolina blew a 27-point lead. Hello darkness, my old friend. Beamer switched offensive coordinators in the offseason, but his roster includes many familiar faces, including veteran quarterback LaNorris Sellers. Beamer has supplied a yo-yo tenure. To keep his job, the Gamecocks must climb the string once more.

IT'S WARM AND COULD GET HOT Lincoln Riley, Southern Cal

USC pushed in a big stack of chips to plunder Riley from Oklahoma. What's it got to show for its investment? No playoff appearances, and Riley's best season was his first, when the Trojans played in the Pac-12. USC is a private school, so Riley's buyout is not public, but it's believed to be a whopper. That may keep him off the scalding seat, but he's facing undeniable pressure in year five. Perhaps, he's ready to kick into gear with an experienced team. No team returned more starters than USC.

Scott Satterfield, Cincinnati

The temperature around Satterfield fluctuates like spring in the Midwest. One day it's warm, next day it's cool, then warm again. He entered last season facing heat. Then, the Bearcats started 7-1. Ah, a nice, cool breeze. But, wait. They finished by losing five straight, continuing Satterfield's trend for November swoons. Then, Cincinnati got caught up in the Brendan Sorsby offseason saga. Maybe, Satterfield's just a .500 coach. That's about what he was at Louisville, and that's about where the record finished last year. Satterfield can't expect any contract protection. His buyout is cheap.

Jeff Lebbey, Mississippi State

Lebbey chalked up a few "almost victories" (is that a stat?) by taking Texas, Tennessee and Florida to the brink. That's nice, but moral victories tend to dry up for a coach now entering his third season. He needs more real W's. Athletic director Zac Selmon hired Lebbey and would love to see this work, but Lebbey needs to show progress. Fortunately, the

bar for progress isn't that high. Lebbey won just one SEC game through two seasons. Quarterback Kamario Taylor drew rave reviews in the preseason. Turn that hype into results.

Bill O'Brien, Boston College

What does Boston College expect out of its football program? Seriously, that's a relevant question. O'Brien went 2-10 last year. Obviously, the school decided that wasn't entirely the coach's fault. To keep up with ACC peers, Boston College needed to invest more in its roster. Boston College joins a few other schools on this list that retained a struggling coach and ponied up more money for athletes. With more investment, comes expectations for improvement.

Derek Mason, Middle Tennessee State

Mason's hire seemed OK in theory. He'd brought respectability to Vanderbilt up until a dreadful pandemic season that got him fired. He's a respected defensive mind, so couldn't he succeed at a Conference USA program that had, for years, been competitive under Rick Stockstill? Apparently not. Mason is 6-18 after two years. That's dangerous footing.

THEY'RE FINE, BUT KEEP AN EYE ON ... Dabo Swinney, Clemson

When a legend like Swinney supplies a bad season, you don't even think about firing him. What if he has consecutive bad seasons? Clemson fans widely cherish Swinney. They'll give him a pass for last year's fizzle if he rebounds, but Swinney's dynasty is finished. One of the great sign-and-develop coaches of his generation, he's struggled to adapt in the player free agency era. Swinney, 56, says he has no plans to retire. That's grand if he wins. And if he doesn't? Swinney's résumé and his \$57 million buyout offer security, but a season that mirrors the last would accelerate angst.

Matt Rhule, Nebraska

Athletic departments specialize in fiscal irresponsibility. Exhibit A: Nebraska, perhaps scared by Penn State's opening, gave Rhule an extension and increased what it would cost to fire him. All this for a coach who is .500 through three seasons. Nebraska shows little sign of momentum, with modest projections for the season win total. Thanks in part to the extension, Rhule's buyout would top \$60 million if he's fired after this season. Is that too expensive for Nebraska to admit a mistake?

Brent Venables, Oklahoma

Venables, facing the hot seat last season, took over play-calling for the defense. It worked. Oklahoma's defense propelled the Sooners to the playoff, and Venables put the thermometer in the cooler. And yet, expectations never wane at Oklahoma or inside the SEC. Venables' tenure has lacked year-to-year consistency, and OU faces one of the nation's toughest schedules. If the Sooners backtrack, Venables could find himself inching back toward the hot seat.

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UNFILTERED PODCAST

Bill Belichick about to give it another go

Blake Toppmeyer, John Brice and Matt Hayes
USA TODAY

College Football Unfiltered: Presented by Sports Seriously is USA TODAY Sports' newest podcast, hosted by USA TODAY Sports columnist Blake Toppmeyer. With sharp analysis, real perspective, and a finger on the pulse of the biggest storylines in college football, delivering news, opinions and context that fans actually care about.

You can also find our episodes at USA TODAY Sports on YouTube, Apple podcasts or Spotify.

This week, Blake is joined by USA TODAY Sports college Insider John Brice and columnist Matt Hayes to discuss Week 0, including the start of Bill Belichick's second season at North Carolina (in Dublin vs. TCU), the rising costs of putting a roster together and whether it's Miami and everyone else in the ACC title race.

Here are a few excerpts from the episode released Aug. 24:

Can it get worse for the coach in year two at UNC?

Hayes: "You know, what's amazing to me is Belichick was always seen as this great personnel guy who knew players and knew exactly what he needed and how to make everything fit and work. He got 70 new players the first year, 60 new players a second year. I'm not that good at math, but I can guarantee you that means he missed on a lot of guys in year one. So I still don't have a quarterback. I don't have a defensive coordinator now either. His son apparently away for whatever reason. The GM's away because they're investigating him for an HR issue.

"There's a lot going on there at North Carolina, and they're playing a really good TCU team that's got a little edge right now. Got a little chip on its collective shoulder because Josh Hoover left for Indiana because he wanted to go play for a championship. And it's a pretty good TCU team that won nine games last year. So this is going to be, I hate to say this for North Carolina fans, might even be worse than last year."

Is this the year Miami finally wins an ACC title?

Toppmeyer: "It's like Miami and everybody else (in the ACC). I mean I guess it's open for No. 2. I feel like the ACC is Miami's to lose far and away. So, is like when we say it's an open conference, are we talking about like if it becomes a two-bid league it's the second bid that is open or do you really see it being open at the top?"

Brice: "Look, Miami has one of the most expensive rosters in all of college football, and they're looking to build off the success that they had last year. But they stubbed their toe a couple of times over the balance of last season. And they still have to prove that they can navigate a full campaign without doing that."

Hayes: "I think we have to look at this realistically. In the time that Miami's been in the ACC, Duke and Wake Forest have won the ACC, Miami has not. Miami hasn't won the ACC. So I mean, I'm with you like I see it and I think I mean it's Miami and the 16 dwarfs, maybe SMU, 15 dwarfs. But until Miami does it, until you see Miami go in there and actually take control of that league, I don't know how anyone could say, yeah, of course it's Miami. Obviously, Darian Mensah puts them high in the list right now as far as favorites to win that league. But I'm a big track record guy, and Miami hasn't done it yet. I want to see them do it."

Toppmeyer: "I think that's fair. Like if you're in the prove it camp, I get that if you're in the who's got the best roster, I think Miami clearly has the best roster in the conference."



Sonny Dykes, left, and TCU play Bill Belichick, right, and North Carolina on Aug. 29. JARED C. TILTON/GETTY IMAGES

WNBA POWER RANKINGS

Best but not necessarily best at home

Cydney Henderson
USA TODAY

Seven of the eight WNBA playoff bids have been claimed, but teams are still jockeying for postseason seeding with six to seven games remaining in the regular season for every team.

The Minnesota Lynx are the favorite to lock up the No. 1 seed and home-court advantage throughout the postseason. The remaining teams are locked in a much tighter race. Only three games separate the No. 2 seed from No. 6 seed, meaning the final games in the regular season will determine which four teams get to play at home in the first round and beyond.

Home court is a bigger deal for some teams than others. For example, the Golden State Valkyries have the best home record, while the Las Vegas Aces seem to play better on the road this season.

Let's take a look at how each franchise fares at home in this week's USA TODAY Sports' WNBA power rankings.

1. Minnesota Lynx (31-8)
Previous rank: 1 (-)

Record at home: 14-6

It's tradition for the Minnesota Lynx to do the Electric Slide after every victory at Target Center, and let's just say the Lynx have done a lot of dancing this season. Minnesota has a 14-5 record at home and has performed even better on the road at 17-2. The Lynx need one more victory to lock up the No. 1 seed for the WNBA playoffs, securing home-court advantage throughout the post-season.

2. Indiana Fever (25-14)
Previous rank: 3 (+1)

Record at home: 13-6

The Fever are shooting lights out at Gainbridge Fieldhouse. Indiana is averaging 99.8 points at home this season and have scored 100 or more points 11 times on its home court this year. In comparison, the Fever average 93.7 points per game on the road. The Fever are tied with the Lynx for the highest 3-point percentage in the league at 39.5%, but Indiana's shooting from beyond the arc improves to 40.2% at home. The Fever closed a five-game road trip with a 113-90 victory over the Chicago Sky on Aug. 23 to pick up their 25th win of the season, setting a franchise record for the most regular-season wins in a season.

3. Golden State Valkyries (26-11)
Previous rank: 2 (-1)

Record at home: 15-5

There's no place like Ballhalla. The Valkyries have the best home record of the league at Chase Center and that may have to do with the atmosphere. Golden State has sold out all of their 42 regular-season games. The record crowd helps fuel Golden State, especial their 3-point shot. The Valkyries attempt the most 3-pointers per game (12.0) in the league, shooting 36.2% from beyond the arc at Ballhalla, compared to 32.3% on the road. Golden State is shooting 42.1% from the field, which ranks last in the league and drops even further, to 41.9%, on the road. The Valkyries have surpassed their win total (23) and home win total (14) from their historic inaugural season in 2025, but would be wise to lock in home-court advantage heading into the postseason.

4. Las Vegas Aces (26-13)
Previous rank: 4 (-)

Record at home: 12-7

The defending champion Aces have performed better on the road this season than at the Michelob Ultra Arena in Las Vegas. The Aces have the highest field-goal percentage in the league on the road, shooting 49.2% from the field as the visiting team, compared to 47.3% on their home turf.

5. Atlanta Dream (25-13)
Previous rank: 5 (-)

Record at home: 12-6

The Atlanta Dream clinched a playoff spot behind Angel Reese's 31-point, 14-rebound double-double in the Dream's 99-89 win over the Phoenix Mercury on Aug. 22. The Dream have been consistent at home and on the road this season, although their field-goal percentage is slightly better at the Gateway Center Arena. Their offensive production is also higher at home, averaging 93.7 points compared to 89.3 points per game on the road. The Dream are currently fourth in the standings and have to close the season out on a high note to lock in home-court advantage.



Olivia Miles reacts after making a shot for the Minnesota Lynx, who have the league's best record at 31-8.
EZRA SHAW/GETTY IMAGES

6. New York Liberty (23-15)
Previous rank: 6 (-)

Record at home: 13-5

The New York Liberty know the importance of home-court advantage. The Liberty hosted the 2026 Commissioner's Cup championship at the Barclays Center in June and walked away with the trophy in front of an amped crowd. New York will have some work to do to climb the WNBA standings and host in the playoffs. The Liberty are in sixth place in the standings, three games out of second with six games remaining. If the season were to end Aug. 25, the Liberty would face the Aces in the first round in a rematch to the Commissioner's Cup.

7. Washington Mystics (22-15)
Previous rank: 7 (-)

Record at home: 13-7

The Washington Mystics have the youngest roster in the league with Sonia Citron, Kiki Iriafen and Shakira Austin. But the team's rebuild may be ahead of schedule, as it secured its first playoff berth since 2023. The Mystics are currently in seventh place in the standings and 3.5 games out of the No. 2 position. Washington averages 85.1 points per game at home, about five points more than their road average.

8. Dallas Wings (22-16)
Previous rank: 8 (-)

Record at home: 12-6

The Dallas Wings are closing in on their first postseason berth since 2023. They would secure the eighth and final playoff spot with a win against the Portland Fire on Aug. 25. Even if the Wings make the playoffs, they won't have home-court advantage and will be on the road to start the first round, but that doesn't seem to be a problem. The Wings have performed slightly better on the road, averaging 89.6 points per game, compared to 87.6 at home in Dallas.

9. Portland Fire (15-22)
Previous rank: 9 (-)

Record at home: 8-11

The Portland Fire's bid to become the second consecutive expansion team to make the playoffs in their inaugural season is on life support. The Fire must defeat the Wings on the road to stay in the postseason race. The Fire have had slightly more success at home at the Moda Center this season with an 8-11 record, compared to a 7-11 road record. Portland is averaging 35.2% from the 3-point line, but that number drops to 32.5% on the road.

10. Chicago Sky (15-23)
Previous rank: 11 (+1)

Record at home: 10-10

Even though they've been eliminated from the playoffs, the Sky have performed relatively well in Chicago and are a .500 team on their home court at Wintrust Arena. Look no further than Sydney Taylor's game-winning 3-pointer with 0.6 seconds left to stave off the Golden State Valkyries' 21-point comeback on Aug. 21. On the road, however, the Sky have struggled with a 5-13 record. The Sky average 6.8 more points per game at home, the largest differential in the league.

11. Phoenix Mercury (13-24)
Previous rank: 10 (-1)

Record at home: 5-12

The Mercury have struggled on their home turf in Phoenix, a head-scratching development after recording a 15-7 record at Mortgage Matchup Center during last season's run to the WNBA Finals. Phoenix has been mathematically eliminated from the postseason with seven

regular-season games remaining, becoming the first team to miss the playoffs after reaching the WNBA Finals the season before since 2008. "It's definitely disappointing. Definitely not what we anticipated for the season," Mercury forward Alyssa Thomas said.

12. Los Angeles Sparks (13-25)
Previous rank: 12 (-)

Record at home: 6-13

The Los Angeles Sparks haven't made the playoffs since 2020 and that drought isn't going to end this season after they were eliminated from the postseason yet again. The Sparks rank bottom three in defensive rating (112.1) and have consistently struggled at home and on the road (7-12).

13. Toronto Tempo (11-26)
Previous rank: 13 (-)

Record at home: 7-13

After a 6-5 start to the Tempo's inaugural season, the injuries ravaged Toronto, which has won five game since. The Tempo snapped their 12-game losing streak with a 82-79 win over the Portland Fire on Aug. 21, but it's too little too late for the playoffs. The Tempo have performed better on Canadian soil this season with seven of their 11 wins coming at home.

14. Connecticut Sun (9-27)
Previous rank: 14 (-)

Record at home: 6-12

Wins have been hard to come by for the Sun, whether the team is at home or on the road. They have won twice as many games at Mohegan Sun Arena than on the road in the franchise's final season in Connecticut.

15. Seattle Storm (7-31)
Previous rank: 15 (-)

Record at home: 5-13

The season hasn't gone well for the Storm. They've won five games at Climate Pledge Arena, compared to two wins all season on the road.

Reese sets rebound marks

Cydney Henderson
USA TODAY

When Atlanta Dream forward Angel Reese sees a basketball coming off the glass, only one thing crosses her mind.

"Anything that goes up is mine," Reese said Aug. 24. "I want to be one of (the best) when I walk away from the game."

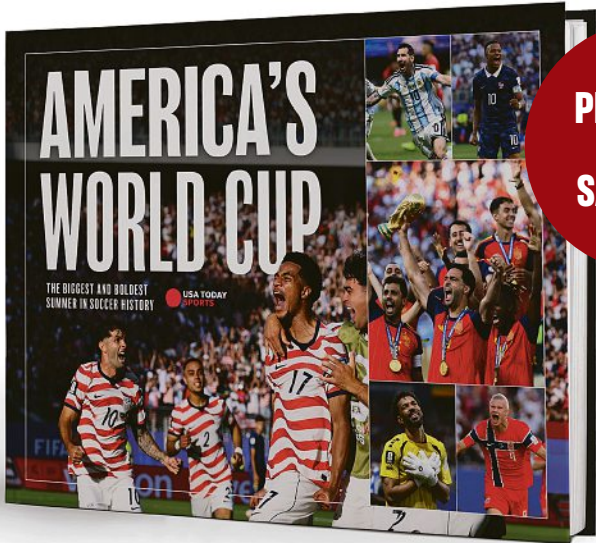
That mentality was on display in the Dream's 78-71 win over the Los Angeles Sparks, during which Reese set a WNBA single-game record with 26 total rebounds (18 defensive and eight offensive boards). She added 11 points, marking her 27th double-double of the season, one shy of tying Alyssa Thomas' WNBA record set in 2023.

That's not the only milestone Reese reached. With her historic rebounding on Monday, Reese also set a single-season record with 458 total rebounds. Reese surpassed the mark of 451 rebounds set by Las Vegas Aces center A'ja Wilson in 2024.



Dream forward Angel Reese (5) rebounds the ball Aug. 24 against Sparks forward Dearica Hamby.
KIRBY LEE/IMAGN IMAGES

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USA TODAY SPORTS

Browns picked now over future at QB1



Nancy Armour
Columnist
USA TODAY

The Cleveland clown show continues.

By settling on Deshaun Watson as their starting quarterback, the Cleveland Browns managed to stick both a finger in the eyes of their fans and a fork in yet another season. That’s an impressive level of ineptitude even for this franchise.

Making Shedeur Sanders QB1 would have been a gamble, yes. He’s young and still very much a work in progress. He was 3-4 as a starter his rookie season, and his performances in the Browns’ first two 2026 preseason games were, to put it nicely, rough. Sanders is, however, the closest thing Cleveland has to a future right now, and parking him on the bench does nothing to speed his development.

Even if he’d wind up being a five-alarm dumpster fire, Sanders would *still* be a better choice for the Browns than an aging, injury prone, mediocre quarterback and unrepentant accused sexual predator who the fan base loathes even more than the Pittsburgh Steelers.

“Ultimately, the fans want us to win. I mean, ultimately put a good product on the field. That’s really what they want,” Browns coach Todd Monken said on Aug. 24 after announcing Watson as the starter.

“(Fans) don’t decide who plays,” Monken added. “I mean, who would I be if I let someone outside the building decide who plays?”

Someone who can read a room?

Watson’s past hangs over present

Watson is more toxic than the Cuyahoga River ever was, and four-plus years have done nothing to soften Cleveland fans’ opinions of him.

“I think the whole world knows it has nothing to do about the performance,” Watson told reporters after he was booed during the Aug. 22 preseason game. “It’s a little bit more personal than that. So, I think it’s a disrespectful thing.”

Of course it’s personal. But if you want to talk disrespectful, let’s talk



Browns quarterback Deshaun Watson played in the exhibition game Aug. 22 at Huntington Bank Field.

KEN BLAZE/IMAGN IMAGES

about those lawsuits Watson settled with 27 women who detailed unwanted touching and/or sexual harassment by the quarterback.

While it’s true Watson was never charged – go look up the statistics on the percentage of sexual assault cases that actually get pursued – and denied wrongdoing, a police detective said in a deposition in one of the civil cases she believed his behavior was criminal. The NFL’s independent disciplinary officer, a former U.S. district judge, determined Watson had a “sexual purpose” for the appointments.

Watson has never apologized or taken responsibility for his dehumanizing treatment of those women. He’d rather throw himself pity parties because Browns fans aren’t willing to gloss over his misdeeds.

“I thought I was gonna get a little different response, but I think my emotions got the best of me,” a more contrite Watson told reporters at training camp Aug. 24. “My comment wasn’t intending

to go at any of the fans around the city, because there’s been a lot of great fans that have been supporting me.”

Are those fans here in the room?

Watson’s lack of success on the field doesn’t help

The thing is, with the NFL being the NFL and society having as dim a view of women as it does, Browns fans probably would have been willing to give Watson a fresh start if he’d had success on the field. Or even just been available. But he hasn’t done either.

Since owners Dee and Jimmy Haslam foisted him on the Browns ahead of the 2022 season, Watson has played all of 19 games. He is 9-10 as Cleveland’s starter, with 19 touchdowns, 12 interceptions and an 80.7 QB rating.

Compounding that lack of reliability and productivity is the worst contract in sports: \$230 million, every penny of which is fully guaranteed, according to USA TODAY Sports reporting.

If the Browns cut him this season, they take a cap hit of \$86.2 million next season, according to Spotrac.

If they wait until the league’s next calendar year, they at least can spread that pain over 2027 and 2028, according to Over The Cap.

So the Browns are stuck and their fans are stuck with Watson. It’s a lose-lose scenario for a franchise that has known little else since it returned to Cleveland almost 30 years ago.

“What are we really in this for? What am I in it for? To have the Browns be an organization that people aspire to be,” Monken said.

Instead, Cleveland is squandering its future for a guy with an ugly past, while telling fans their feelings about it don’t matter.

Maybe one year the Browns will act like a serious NFL team. This year isn’t going to be it.

Follow USA TODAY Sports columnist Nancy Armour on social media @nrarmour

Browns hope to recoup by giving Watson one last try



Tyler Dragon
USA TODAY

Of course the organization with a perpetual quarterback merry-go-round made a perplexing decision about their starting quarterback. We shouldn’t be surprised by the Cleveland Browns’ choice to name Deshaun Watson their starting quarterback over Shedeur Sanders.

After all, this is a Browns franchise that’s trotted out the most starting quarterbacks in the NFL since 1999.

Watson and Sanders have performed about evenly throughout their offseason competition. Watson outplayed Sanders in Cleveland’s preseason opener versus the Chicago Bears. He completed more passes, had more passing yards and a superior passing rating. Sanders fared better in the Browns’ second preseason contest against the Buffalo Bills. The second-year QB completed more passes, threw for more yards, tossed a touchdown and had the better passer rating.

Each preseason contest typified the back-and-forth nature of an offseason-long QB competition.

“Took in the full body of work over the course of offseason to training camp to the games, the joint practice, and ultimately felt like to start the season on the road, Deshaun gave us the best chance to move the ball and score points,” Browns coach Todd Monken said to reporters on Aug. 24. “That’s really what it’s about.”

Deshaun Watson contract

Watson’s albatross contract certainly factors into the Browns’ decision whether the organization wants to admit it or not. The Browns gave Watson a five-year, \$230 million fully guaranteed contract in March 2022 and have subsequently received diminished returns – a 9-10 record as starter, a sub-mediocre 80.7 passer rating, an average of less than 180 passing yards per game (177.1) and two seasons in the last two years that have ended early due to injury.

Lackluster quarterback play from Watson all under the backdrop of accusations of sexual assault and inappropriate conduct during massage sessions by more than two dozen women.

Oddly enough, the boobbirds Watson’s heard in Cleveland have largely been performance based despite Watson’s tone-deaf comments on Saturday that he later

apologized for on Monday. It’s also why Browns owner Jimmy Haslam told reporters the organization “took a big swing and miss with Deshaun” in March 2025.

Watson has one year remaining on his contract. Monken and the Browns’ choice to start the polarizing QB is a final act to try to salvage arguably the worst contract in NFL history.

“I know the frustration. This organization has put a lot of investment to get me back and things haven’t been going in the right direction that we thought it was. A lot of injuries, a lot of time off and not playing the best football,” Watson told reporters on Aug. 24. “I understand the frustration. I understand kind of everything that goes into that.”

Starter choice out of line with reality

Still, starting Watson doesn’t align with the current state of the Browns organization. The Browns traded the face of their franchise Myles Garrett in June and have two first-round picks in the 2027 NFL Draft. The organization’s in the midst of a rebuild and the moves that preceded Watson being named starter illustrated it.

The only reasonable rationale to start Watson is to give the 30-year-old QB one last chance to attempt to rekindle the form he displayed during three Pro Bowl seasons as a member of the Houston Texans (2018-2020), which included a 2020 campaign in which he was the NFL’s passing leader – a stat that seems unfathomable today.

The Browns begin the regular season with two road games against the Jacksonville Jaguars and Tampa Bay Buccaneers.

A slow start by Watson will for sure aggravate a fan base undoubtedly ready to go in a different direction under center. If Watson begins the year like he’s played his entire tenure in Cleveland, the Browns should bench Watson and move forward with Sanders.

Yes, the Browns’ decision to start Watson runs counter to where the franchise is right now. But there are enough regular-season games on Cleveland’s slate to offer Watson one more opportunity and give Sanders an in-depth assessment before the Browns inevitably restart their quarterback merry-go-round ahead of what’s anticipated to be a quarterback-rich 2027 draft class.

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REQUEST FOR PROPOSALS

AscendRural, a program of Sourcewell — a State of Minnesota local government unit and service cooperative — is requesting proposals for the AscendRural Innovation Challenge: Bridging Distance to Rural Care & Services, to result in a procurement solution for use by Sourcewell Participating Entities.

This solicitation seeks innovative technology-enabled solutions that reduce the impact of distance on rural communities’ access to healthcare, services, and essential goods. Proposals must address one or more of five problem areas: transportation access and coordination; local access to primary, specialty, and oral care; managing chronic conditions; last-mile delivery of essentials; and strengthening the business of rural access. Sourcewell Participating Entities include thousands of governmental, higher education, K-12 education, nonprofit, tribal government, and other public agencies located in the United States.

A full copy of the Request for Proposals can be found on the Sourcewell Procurement Portal <https://portal.sourcewell-mn.gov>.

Only proposals submitted through the Sourcewell Procurement Portal will be considered.

Proposals are due no later than October 6, 2026, at 3:30 p.m. Central Time, and late proposals will not be considered.

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MLB

American League

East Division

	W	L	Pct	GB
Tampa Bay	78	53	.595	—
N.Y. Yankees	74	56	.569	3½
Boston	72	59	.550	6
Toronto	64	68	.485	14½
Baltimore	63	68	.481	15

Central Division

	W	L	Pct	GB
Chi. White Sox	68	63	.519	—
Cleveland	66	66	.500	2½
Minnesota	64	68	.485	4%
Detroit	61	70	.466	7
Kansas City	58	74	.438	10½

West Division

	W	L	Pct	GB
Texas	66	66	.500	—
Houston	65	66	.496	½
Seattle	63	69	.477	3
L.A. Angels	52	80	.394	14
Athletics	51	81	.386	15

National League

East Division

	W	L	Pct	GB
Atlanta	76	55	.580	—
Philadelphia	73	59	.553	3½
Miami	67	65	.508	9½
Washington	62	71	.466	15
N.Y. Mets	59	72	.450	17

Central Division

	W	L	Pct	GB
Milwaukee	81	50	.618	—
Chicago Cubs	76	56	.576	5½
St. Louis	66	66	.500	15½
Pittsburgh	64	69	.481	18
Cincinnati	62	70	.470	19½

West Division

	W	L	Pct	GB
L.A. Dodgers	80	51	.611	—
San Diego	71	61	.538	9½
Arizona	69	63	.523	11½
San Francisco	53	78	.405	27
Colorado	50	81	.382	30

Monday's Scores

Tampa Bay 4, Detroit 1
Boston 4, Miami 2
Washington 13, Colorado 3
Texas 11, Chi. White Sox 2
Cleveland 4, L.A. Angels 2
Chicago Cubs 7, Arizona 0
Minnesota 9, Athletics 6
Seattle 9, Philadelphia 2
Pittsburgh 3, San Diego 2
San Francisco 5, Cincinnati 0

Tuesday's Games

Tampa Bay at Detroit
Boston at Miami
Colorado at Washington
Houston at N.Y. Yankees
Kansas City at Toronto
Milwaukee at N.Y. Mets
L.A. Dodgers at Atlanta
Texas at Chi. White Sox
Baltimore at St. Louis
Cleveland at L.A. Angels
Chicago Cubs at Arizona
Minnesota at Athletics
Philadelphia at Seattle
Pittsburgh at San Diego
Cincinnati at San Francisco

Wednesday's Games

Tampa Bay at Detroit, 1:10 p.m.
Chicago Cubs at Arizona, 3:40 p.m.
Cincinnati at San Francisco, 3:45 p.m.
Cleveland at L.A. Angels, 4:07 p.m.
Philadelphia at Seattle, 4:10 p.m.
Pittsburgh at San Diego, 4:10 p.m.
Boston at Miami, 6:40 p.m.
Colorado at Washington, 6:45 p.m.
Houston at N.Y. Yankees, 7:05 p.m.
Kansas City at Toronto, 7:07 p.m.
Milwaukee at N.Y. Mets, 7:10 p.m.
L.A. Dodgers at Atlanta, 7:15 p.m.
Texas at Chi. White Sox, 7:40 p.m.
Baltimore at St. Louis, 7:45 p.m.
Minnesota at Athletics, 9:05 p.m.

Thursday's Games

Colorado at Washington, 1:05 p.m.
Baltimore at St. Louis, 2:15 p.m.
Houston at N.Y. Yankees, 7:05 p.m.
Kansas City at Toronto, 7:07 p.m.
Milwaukee at N.Y. Mets, 7:10 p.m.
L.A. Dodgers at Atlanta, 7:15 p.m.
Arizona at San Francisco, 7:45 p.m.
Friday's Games
Cincinnati at Chicago Cubs, 2:20 p.m.
L.A. Dodgers at Detroit, 6:40 p.m.
Miami at Washington, 6:45 p.m.
San Diego at Tampa Bay, 7:10 p.m.
Kansas City at Cleveland, 7:10 p.m.
Houston at N.Y. Mets, 7:10 p.m.

Seattle at Toronto, 7:15 p.m.
Colorado at Atlanta, 7:15 p.m.
Boston at N.Y. Yankees, 7:15 p.m.
Texas at Milwaukee, 7:40 p.m.
Chi. White Sox at Minnesota, 8:10 p.m.
Pittsburgh at St. Louis, 8:15 p.m.
Philadelphia at L.A. Angels, 9:38 p.m.
Baltimore at Athletics, 9:40 p.m.
Arizona at San Francisco, 10:15 p.m.

CFL

EAST DIVISION

	W	L	Pct	PF	PA
Montreal	9	1	.900	367	263
Toronto	5	5	.500	304	311
Hamilton	4	7	.364	257	319
Ottawa	0	10	.000	223	368

WEST DIVISION

	W	L	Pct	PF	PA
Edmonton	8	3	.727	323	279
Saskatchewan	6	4	.600	309	271
BC	5	5	.500	274	267
Winnipeg	5	5	.500	204	243
Calgary	4	6	.400	352	297

Thursday's Score

Friday's Score

Saturday's Score

Sunday's Score

BC 30, Saskatchewan 16

Friday's Game

Montreal vs. Winnipeg, 8:30 p.m.

Saturday's Games

Hamilton vs. Calgary, 3 p.m.

Toronto vs. Saskatchewan, 7 p.m.

Sunday's Game

BC vs. Ottawa, 7 p.m.

NFL

Preseason Week 2

Friday's Scores

N.Y. Jets 17, Pittsburgh 0

Carolina 34, Jacksonville 17

Green Bay 33, Denver 13

Saturday's Scores

Detroit 17, Washington 13

Buffalo 31, Cleveland 7

Baltimore 13, Minnesota 3

Atlanta 34, Indianapolis 6

N.Y. Giants 26, Miami 3

L.A. Rams 34, New Orleans 0

New England 24, Philadelphia 21

Cincinnati 27, Chicago 9

Tampa Bay 16, Kansas City 15

Dallas 34, Arizona 13

Sunday's Score

Tennessee 19, Seattle 16

Preseason Week 3

Thursday's Games

Pittsburgh at Buffalo, 7 p.m.

New England at Cleveland, 8 p.m.

San Francisco at Las Vegas, 8 p.m.

L.A. Rams at L.A. Chargers, 10 p.m.

Friday's Games

Washington at Baltimore, 6 p.m.

Atlanta at Miami, 7 p.m.

Houston at Carolina, 7 p.m.

Tampa Bay at Jacksonville, 7:30 p.m.

N.Y. Giants at N.Y. Jets, 7:30 p.m.

Cincinnati at Philadelphia, 8 p.m.

Seattle at Kansas City, 8 p.m.

Arizona at Green Bay, 8 p.m.

New Orleans at Dallas, 8 p.m.

Minnesota at Denver, 9 p.m.

Saturday's Games

Detroit at Indianapolis, 1 p.m.

Chicago at Tennessee, 6 p.m.

SOCCER

English Premier League

	GP	W	D	L	GF	GA	Pts
Arsenal	1	1	0	0	3	0	3
Everton	1	1	0	0	2	0	3
Manchester City	1	1	0	0	2	1	3
Chelsea	1	1	0	0	3	2	3
Ipswich Town	1	1	0	0	2	1	3
Leeds United	1	1	0	0	1	0	3
Hull City	1	1	0	0	2	0	3

	GP	W	D	L	GF	GA	Pts
Brighton & Hove Albion	1	1	0	0	4	0	3
Brentford	1	1	0	0	3	0	3
Liverpool	1	0	1	0	2	2	1
Newcastle United	1	0	1	0	2	2	1
Aston Villa	1	0	0	1	0	4	0

	1	0	0	1	0	3	0
Tottenham	1	0	0	1	2	3	0
Hotspur	1	0	0	1	2	3	0
Fulham	1	0	0	1	2	3	0
Manchester United	1	0	0	1	0	2	0
Coventry City	1	0	0	1	0	3	0
Sunderland	1	0	0	1	1	2	0
Crystal Palace	1	0	0	1	0	2	0
Nottingham Forest	1	0	0	1	0	2	0
Forest	1	0	0	1	0	1	0
Bournemouth	1	0	0	1	1	2	0

Note: Three points for win, one point for tie.

Friday's Score

Arsenal 3, Coventry City 0

Saturday's Scores

Hull City 2, Manchester United 0

Everton 2, Crystal Palace 0

Ipswich Town 2, Sunderland 1

Nottingham Forest 0, Leeds United 1

Brentford 3, Tottenham Hotspur 0

Sunday's Scores

Brighton & Hove Albion 4, Aston Villa 0

Manchester City 2, Bournemouth 1

Newcastle United 2, Liverpool 2

Monday's Game

Chelsea 3, Fulham 2

Friday's Game

Manchester City at Crystal Palace, 3 p.m.

Saturday's Games

Nottingham Forest at Liverpool, 7:30 a.m.

Hull City at Coventry City, 10 a.m.

Everton at Bournemouth, 10 a.m.

Newcastle United at Tottenham, 12:30 p.m.

MLS

EASTERN CONFERENCE

	W	L	T	Pts	GF	GA
Nashville	15	2	4	49	43	17
Inter Miami CF	11	4	6	39	49	40
Chicago	11	6	3	36	37	26
New England	10	7	4	34	33	26
Charlotte FC	9	7	5	32	38	32
Cincinnati	8	6	7	31	49	47
NY City FC	7	8	6	27	35	30
NY Red Bulls	7	9	5	26	31	43
Orlando City	7	11	3	24	44	51
Toronto FC	5	7	9	24	31	37
D.C. United	5	7	9	24	28	36
Atlanta	6	12	3	21	25	36
Philadelphia	5	10	6	21	31	38
CF Montreal	5	10	6	21	29	39
Columbus	5	11	5	20	30	36

WESTERN CONFERENCE

	W	L	T	Pts	GF	GA
Vancouver	12	4	4	40	45	18
Houston	12	7	5	35	36	22
Los Angeles FC	10	7	5	35	36	22
San Jose	10	8	3	33	39	34
FC Dallas	9	6	6	33	38	34
Saint Louis	9	6	6	33	30	27
Colorado	9	11	1	28	30	28
Real Salt Lake	8	9	4	28	34	32
Portland	8	9	4	28	38	37
Minnesota	7	7	7	28	27	29
San Diego FC	7	8	6	27	37	32
LA Galaxy	6	8	6	26	27	32
Seattle	7	9	4	25	22	27
Austin FC	5	10	6	21	26	30
Sporting KC	4	14	3	15	20	51

Note: Three points for win, one point for tie.

Saturday's Scores

Cincinnati 1, Seattle 1

CF Montreal 2, LA Galaxy 2

Orlando City 2, Real Salt Lake 1

Inter Miami CF 1, Toronto FC 2

Charlotte FC 3, D.C. United 1

NY Red Bulls 1, Chicago 1

Saint Louis 2, Houston 1

Nashville 3, Columbus 2

Austin FC 1, Philadelphia 1

Vancouver 5, FC Dallas 0

San Diego FC 3, Colorado 0

Los Angeles FC 1, Portland 1

San Jose 1, Minnesota 5

Sunday's Scores

New England 1, NY City FC 1

Atlanta 2, Sporting KC 1

Saturday's Games

Chicago at Seattle, 4:30 p.m.

Philadelphia at NY Red Bulls, 7:30 p.m.

New England at Columbus, 7:30 p.m.

NY City FC at Toronto FC, 7:30 p.m.

CF Montreal at Inter Miami CF, 7:30 p.m.

Los Angeles FC at D.C. United, 7:30 p.m.

Charlotte FC at Atlanta, 7:30 p.m.

San Jose at Houston, 8:30 p.m.

Cincinnati at Nashville, 8:30 p.m.

Orlando City at Minnesota, 8:30 p.m.

Vancouver at Sporting KC, 8:30 p.m.

Real Salt Lake at Colorado, 9:30 p.m.

LA Galaxy at San Diego FC, 10:30 p.m.

Austin FC at Portland, 10:30 p.m.

NWSL

	W	L	D	Pts	GF	GA
Gotham	13	3	5	44	26	13
Washington	11	6	4	37	30	19
Portland	11	6	4	37	35	29
Utah	11	7	3	36	37	27

San Diego	11	7	3	36	29	23
North Carolina	10	7	3	33	36	30
Kansas City	9	8	4	31	32	29
Seattle	8	8	4	28	25	26
Angel City	7	7	5	26	27	20
Houston	7	9	5	26	28	25
Orlando	8	11	2	26	25	31
Denver	6	8	6	24	25	26
Louisville	7	12	2	23	32	40
Bay	6	10	4	22	21	27
Boston	5	11	5	20	24	34
Chicago	5	15	1	16	12	4

Note: Three points for win, one point for tie.



The Dodgers' Tyler Glasnow hasn't pitched since May 6.
RON CHENOY/IMAGN IMAGES

Dodgers welcome back another star pitcher amid surge

Josh Peter
USA TODAY

It's like whiplash. The sky was falling on the Los Angeles Dodgers, and now the sky is the limit. At least that's how it feels. The Dodgers lost 10 of 13 games between July 26 and Aug. 9. Now they have won 10 of 13 games and entered Aug. 25 with the second-best record in baseball, one game behind the Milwaukee Brewers with five weeks until the playoffs start. There's no question the quality of opponents was superior during the Dodgers' losing skid. But there's no denying there's reason for optimism on the field. (Owner Mark Walter and the investigation into potential business fraud, well, that's another story.) As the Dodgers headed into a three-game road series against the Atlanta Braves on Aug. 25, here's the best news: Pitcher Tyler Glasnow is scheduled to make his first start in 3½ months after being sidelined with back spasms. "I'm excited to see Tyler back and I know he's been missing competing," Roberts told reporters. This comes two weeks after pitcher Blake Snell returned in spectacular fashion and, according to Bob Nightengale of USA TODAY Sports, the Dodgers expect Shohei Ohtani to resume pitching next month barring any setbacks. Glasnow, the mop-haired right-hander, was 3-0 with a 2.72 ERA in seven starts this season before he ended up on the injured list. He was sharp in two rehab starts with the Dodgers' Triple-A affiliate in Oklahoma City. And the hope is Glasnow can recapture his form from the 2025 postseason, when he threw 21½ innings with a 1.69 ERA. He figures to be tested by the Braves, who had a 76-55 (.580) record and led the NL East. Said Roberts: "It's going to be a fun series here ... and it'll be good to get Tyler back in the mix."

Scintillating on the mound

Glasnow will rejoin the starting

rotation rounding into top form. "Starting pitching has been fantastic," Roberts told reporters after Blake Snell threw six scoreless innings in the Dodgers' 4-0 victory over the Pittsburgh Pirates on Aug. 23. Snell, in three starts since returning from elbow surgery, is 2-0 with a 1.00 ERA with 21 strikeouts in 18 innings. Dodgers ace Yoshinobu Yamamoto is 3-0 with a 1.98 ERA over the past six starts with 39 strikeouts in 41 innings. Tarik Skubal, the prized pickup at the trade deadline, is coming off his finest performance in four starts with the Dodgers. In a 4-3 victory over the Pirates on Aug. 22, the left-hander struck out 11 batters in seven innings, gave up three earned runs and got the win. Right-hander Roki Sasaki has gone from occasional liability to asset. In his last six starts, he's 2-0 with a 2.31 ERA and 34 strikeouts in 35 innings. The rotation could go from stacked to crowded if Ohtani regains his form and endurance. He hasn't pitched in a game since July 3 because of issues with his left knee. He is 8-2 with a 1.79 ERA, The Dodgers bullpen has show dependability too. Roberts said there was no option other than Edwin Diaz to close games even after Diaz's disastrous outing Aug. 13 against the Brewers, but he appears to be wrong. Dodgers reliever Tanner Scott has picked up three saves in the past four games.

Reality check?

When the Dodgers lost 10 of 13 games, eight defeats came against three teams: the Boston Red Sox, Chicago Cubs and Arizona Diamondbacks. Through Monday, those teams had a combined record of 217-178 (.549). By contrast, on their recent tear, the Dodgers won nine games against three teams: the Pirates, Kansas City Royals and Colorado Rockies. Through Sunday, those teams had a combined record of 172-223 (.435).

'Sky's the limit': Cubs are rolling, believe they can win Series



Bob Nightengale
Columnist
USA TODAY

PHOENIX – The Chicago Cubs might not be the best team in their own division. They might not even be the best team in their hometown. But, oh, as they proved Aug. 24 with a 7-0 victory over the Arizona Diamondbacks in front of largely their own fans at Chase Field, they sure are armed and dangerous. The Cubs, 76-56 and running away with the National League wild-card race, are dreaming big. Yes, World Series big. "I think one of the big things is having a real honest belief that you can win the whole thing," Cubs veteran outfielder Michael Conforto said, "and I think there's no doubt that we believe that. I don't think that's super common around the league to fully believe that you can win the whole thing." Conforto, cast off by the Los Angeles Dodgers this winter when they replaced him with Kyle Tucker, has been an integral part of the Cubs' success in a part-time role. He signed a minor league contract in February for \$2 million. After going 3-for-3 with a double, homer and two RBIs on Monday, he has 12 homers for the season. That's only one more homer in 270 fewer plate appearances than Tucker, and also \$238 million cheaper. Yes, Cubs manager Craig Counsell says, Conforto definitely has exceeded expectations. "I think when you can sign a player of his stature and they come in and accept a role that's not something they've done before," Counsell said, "I think it build things around the room. I think Mike's been a real connector for this group. So that his production and his leadership from that perspective has been really important." This is the first time Conforto, who has played for 11 years, has been a part-time player. He has made nearly \$80 million. But now, at this stage of his career, it's all about winning. "I felt more like I've come in here and just joined the party," Conforto said. "The big thing is coming in here and being honest at this point in my career. I just want to win games. You can get to a place in your career where maybe it's not so much about the money and the playing time, it's about being part of something special. I was lucky enough to be somewhat a part of that last year, and I just want to do my part to help us get there. That's really the biggest thing for me." Veteran starter Kevin Gausman, who the Dodgers faced in the World Series a year ago with the Toronto Blue Jays, certainly pitched like a guy who plans a return trip to the big dance. He was acquired at the trade deadline and showed just why he could be invaluable for the Cubs rotation, giving up three hits in seven scoreless innings. Maybe it wasn't his best start of the

season, saying he still will take that seven-inning, one-hitter over the New York Yankees in June ("Hey, anytime you can beat the Yankees"), but he showed off why he could be a force in their playoff rotation. The Diamondbacks were looking for his split-fingered fastball all night, and he instead pounded them with four-seam fastballs, giving everyone a glimpse of what to expect in October. When MVP candidate Pete Crow-Armstrong can go hitless in five at-bats, red-hot Alex Bregman can manage just one hit, and the bottom three hitters of Pedro Ramirez, Conforto and Carson Kelly can go 6-for-10 with a double, triple, two homers, four runs and four RBIs, you've got a complete team. "The sky's the limit," Gausman said. "This defense, this offense, the pitchers that we have here, it's a really great team. Not many weaknesses. When you play good, clean baseball, you're going to put your team in a good spot to win every night. "I mean, they're just relentless, from one through nine. There's no gaps in this lineup." The Cubs could have more reinforcements coming, too, with pitcher Ben Brown (neck stress reaction) expected to fly back to Chicago with the team and perhaps start a rehab assignment and Justin Steele, who has been out since April 2025, hoping he can return in relief in September. "It's been a long road and feels really good to get towards the end of that tunnel," said Steele, who is scheduled to throw two bullpen sessions this week with hopes of beginning a rehab assignment in early September. "You see how the team's playing. You just want to get back and help." Still, as much as Counsell loves the enthusiasm, he tapped the brakes on a potential return for Steele. He didn't completely rule it out but reminded everyone that Steele hasn't pitched in 16 months after having elbow surgery, has yet to go on a rehab assignment, and has pitched to live batters only once. For Steele to return and pitch effectively for a team fighting for the NL Central title with hopes of playing deep into October, it might be as realistic as the Cubs inviting the Green Bay Packers to sing the seventh-inning stretch at Wrigley. "We have a lot of steps to go before we get there," Counsell said. "I mean, he hasn't pitched in an affiliated game in almost two years, so let's get him pitching in an affiliated game. I think we can understand that he's going to have to pitch in multiple games before he's ready." No matter, the Cubs, who planned to show off their other big trade addition Tuesday with starter Clay Holmes, believe they're ready to make this a memorable October, perhaps even resurrecting memories of 2016. This team, Conforto will tell you, exudes that same confidence the Dodgers had a year ago, believing there's no reason they can't be the last ones standing. "There's just people who really, really want to win," he said. "There's one goal. And it's just winning."

New Tour Championship format highlights vision

Adam Schupak
Golfweek | USA TODAY Network

ATLANTA – PGA Tour CEO Brian Rolapp rolled out the new postseason format the tour will adopt in 2028 among other updates at his State of the Tour press conference on Aug. 25 at the Tour Championship at East Lake Golf Club. The PGA Tour's Championship Series Finale will serve as the final 72-hole stroke play event of the year, featuring the top 90 in the season-long standings. From there, the top 32 in the standings will advance to a two-week match play competition at rotating, prestigious venues. The first week will include World Cup-style group play, with the 32 qualifiers broken into eight groups of fours. The top two will advance to the final week, with ties decided in a sudden-death playoff. The finale will be at a separate venue. Week two is four rounds of match play. All 16 players competing all four rounds. Every match impacts the final standings. The player who goes undefeated will be crowned the winner of the Tour Championship. "Throughout this process, we listened carefully to our fans, players and

partners," Rolapp said. "One message came through clearly: the culmination of our season should be worthy of the journey it takes to get there. The result is a season-ending structure that rewards excellence over the course of the year while building toward a reimagined Tour Championship. We are creating something different, something distinct within professional golf that can resonate far beyond it." This marks the first time match play will be featured in the tour's postseason, and first time the format has been contested on tour since the 2023 World Golf Championships-Match Play. "The conclusion of the season should be worthy of the journey it takes to get there," wrote Tiger Woods, the chairman of the future competitions committee, in a social media post on X. "Today's announcement is a result of the hard work and passion of our players. Excited to usher in a new era of match play on the PGA Tour." Rolapp spent much of the rest of his update detailing developments of his two-tiered mode. The Championship Series will feature the top performers



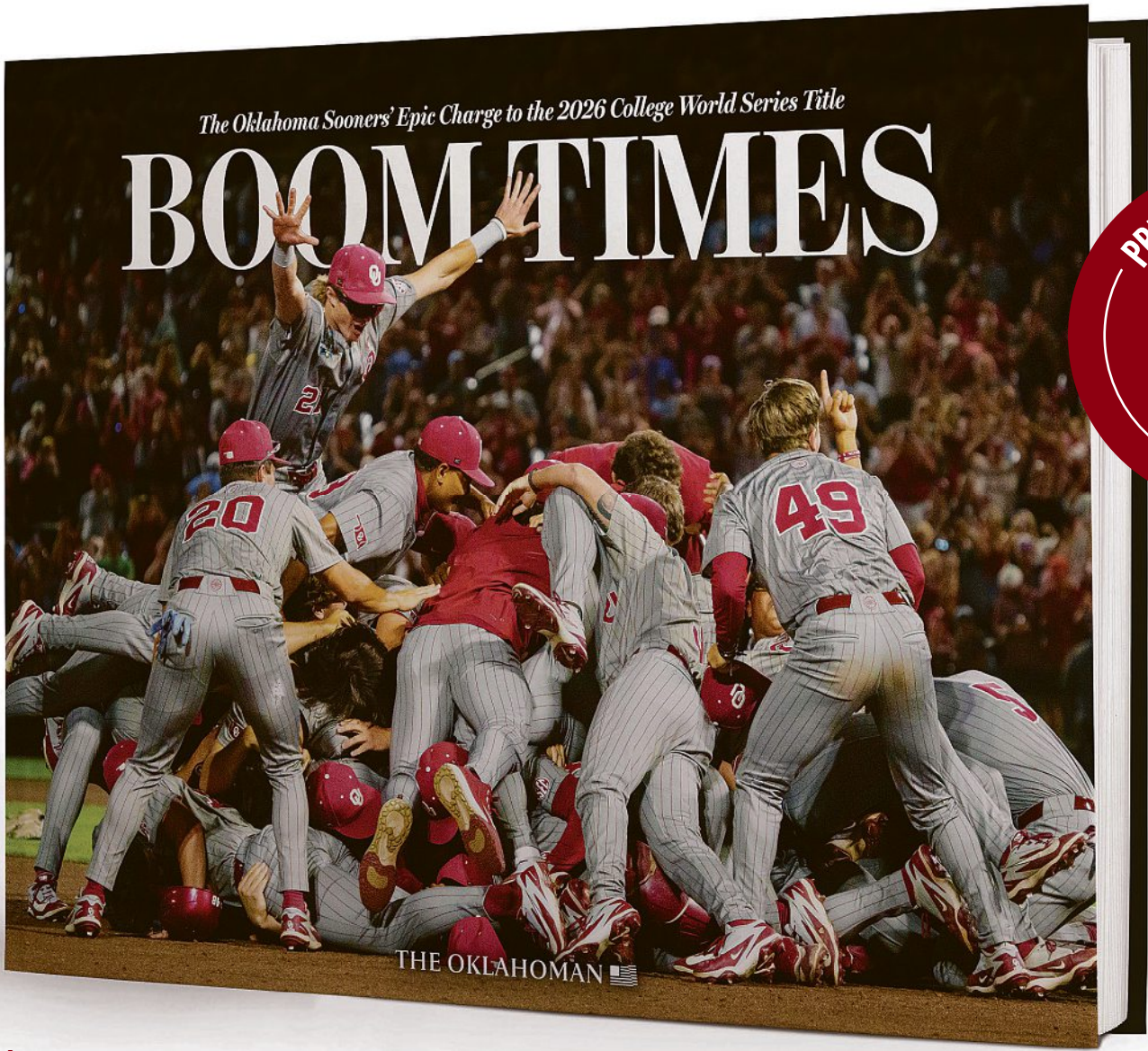
Rolapp

competing head-to-head across the season in 72-hole stroke-play events with a cut, with players measured through a straightforward, season points system. The tour has announced seven of the 15 regular-season events on the 2028 Championship Series. An additional four have been identified and are expected to be announced in the coming weeks. Rolapp said discussions with 14 prospective partners for the remaining four regular-season events are ongoing. "It's a high-class problem. We're glad we have it," he said. Rolapp said the decision will not simply be determined by the highest bidder. "It's not just financial, although that's a factor, of course," he said. "It's the quality of the golf course. It's the quality of the sponsor, what they can do for not only the tournament but the PGA Tour and how they continue to promote the sport and the tour." He said final decisions will be made "soon" and noted the full Championship Series schedule would be announced Feb. 22 at a new televised event hosted at its headquarters in Ponte Vedra Beach, Florida.

The Tour will turn its attention to the Challenger Series, the second tier of events, and Rolapp said, "we've had unsolicited inbound interest," and "not only from existing sponsors but also new sponsors who have not been associated with the Tour." He expects to announce "a significant portion of the schedule by next year's Players Championship in March, with the full schedule finalized by the 2027 Tour Championship. When Rolapp was asked about the possibility of LIV Golf players returning to the PGA Tour, he was quick to shoot that down. "Currently there's no current plans for Returning Member Program like you saw earlier this year," he said. But Rolapp did leave a window cracked by saying that the starting point for any discussion of a return will depend on a player leaving LIV and no longer being contractually bound like Brooks Koepka, who came back this season. "Anyone who's interested in coming to the PGA Tour needs to demonstrate that they are relieved of their contractual commitments or any tail obligations they might have in that legacy model," Rolapp said.

CHAMPS!

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They weren't supposed to win it all. They barely made the NCAA Tournament after a 14-16 record in the brutal SEC. But the Sooners caught fire and didn't stop burning until they captured the College World Series for the third time. In one of college baseball's greatest Cinderella stories, the Sooners finished on an 11-2 tear, outscoring their foes 118-53. From the walk-off home run that eliminated Georgia Tech to the 13-2 trashing of Kansas to the five homers that ousted Georgia to the 13-2 wipeout of North Carolina, Skip Johnson's squad left no doubt which team deserved the CWS mountaintop.

"BOOM TIMES: The Oklahoma Sooners' Epic Charge to the 2026 College World Series Title" is an exclusive hardcover collector's book capturing every clutch moment of the greatest season in Sooners history, told by the award-winning journalists at The Oklahoman. Preorder now and own the thrilling story!

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THEY SAID WHAT?
THE STARS’ BEST QUOTES

“It’s not a coincidence that so many former, specifically pre-sexualized female, child ‘stars’ have profoundly sad lives and untimely ends. We were not as protected by the ‘systems’ that look great on paper as we are supposed to be.” – Anna Paquin on Instagram, reacting to the death of Hayden Panettiere while also honoring former child actors Michelle Trachtenberg and Daveigh Chase, who died in 2025 and in June, respectively. Paquin, who won an Oscar at age 11 for “The Piano,” encouraged former child stars to message her directly, writing that it’s a “strange small club we belong to and you are worthy of support, no matter how our industry made us feel.”

IT’S YOUR BIRTHDAY
WHO’S CELEBRATING TODAY



Culkin

Director **Barbet Schroeder** turns 85. Singer **Valerie Simpson** (Ashford & Simpson), 80. Saxophonist **Branford Marsalis**, 66. Actor **Chris Burke**, 61. Singer **Shirley Manson** (Garbage), 60. Actor **Melissa McCarthy**, 56. Actor **Macaulay Culkin**, 46. Actor **Chris Pine**, 46. Composer **Nico Muhly**, 45. Actor **John Mulaney**, 44. Actor **Keke Palmer**, 33. – *USA TODAY Network*

HOROSCOPE | SANCTUARY
More: www.sanctuaryworld.co

Aries (March 21-April 19). Relationships feel like a cool breeze today! You’ll feel refreshed by the support of a partner or close friend.

Taurus (April 20-May 20). Teamwork makes the dream work! Or at least it can help take a serious load off your plate.

Gemini (May 21-June 21). New experiences have something special in store! Your curiosity leads you straight to pleasure.

Cancer (June 22-July 22). Emotional honesty can improve relationships. Are you ready to put your guard down and relax around someone you trust?

Leo (July 23-Aug. 22). Well, aren’t you a charmer? You know just the right thing to say.

Virgo (Aug. 23-Sept. 22). Routines feel good when they support your well-being. What can you treat yourself to that would improve the day?

Libra (Sept. 23-Oct. 23). You turn heads today when you stop trying to impress anyone. What feels fun to pursue just for yourself?

Scorpio (Oct. 24-Nov. 21). Loving your alone time? Sink into the comfort of your own little world.

Sagittarius (Nov. 22-Dec. 21). A casual conversation could introduce an exciting social opportunity! Are you ready to follow up on this promising connection?

Capricorn (Dec. 22-Jan. 19). Open to putting your talents on display? Positive attention comes your way when you share your creativity with the world.

Aquarius (Jan. 20-Feb. 18). Stepping into unknown territory can feel especially pleasing today. What new experience is beckoning to you? Answer the call.

Pisces (Feb. 19-March 20). Accept the emotional support that surrounds you today. Are you able to receive the care that others want to give?

MOVIES



“The more I got to know her, she astounded me in every way,” says Jane Schoenbrun, left, of Hannah Einbinder. NATHANIAL GARY/USA TODAY

Einbinder and Schoenbrun bond over ‘Camp’ trip

Patrick Ryan *USA TODAY*

NEW YORK – Growing up, every queer person has that one gay awakening movie. ● For filmmaker Jane Schoenbrun, it was watching “The Royal Tenenbaums” and wanting to make mix-tapes with Gwyneth Paltrow’s smoky-eyed sphinx. Hannah Einbinder, meanwhile, was smitten with the sports comedy “Bring It On.” ● “Gymnastics and cheerleading have such homoerotic overtones, so that was probably something I was responding to,” says Einbinder, seated with Schoenbrun on a visit to USA TODAY’s studio. “I went on to become a cheerleader from 11 to 18 and it’s like, ‘Yeah, there was also something else you were trying to do, too, girl!’ ”

Einbinder, 31, stars in Schoenbrun’s erotic horror fantasia “Teen-age Sex and Death at Camp Miasma” (in theaters now), a highly meta exploration of how the media we consume shape our attitudes toward sex and sexuality.

The Emmy-winning comedian plays Kris, a burgeoning queer director who’s tasked with rebooting the ’80s slasher franchise “Camp Miasma,” which since has been deemed problematic for its trans killer, Little Death (Jack Haven). She pays a visit to the series’ original “final girl” Billy Presley (Gillian Anderson), now a vampy, reclusive actress who helps Kris overcome her anxiety and shame around physical intimacy.

The film is immensely personal to Schoenbrun, 39, who uses they/them pronouns. They examined

trans body dysphoria in 2022’s “We’re All Going to the World’s Fair” and 2024’s “I Saw the TV Glow.” With “Camp Miasma,” Schoenbrun wanted to show the “mystery and terror and joy” of finally being comfortable in one’s own body.

After transitioning, “I literally remember figuring out what love songs were,” Schoenbrun says. “You can listen and understand them intellectually, but if you haven’t dared to be yourself and get your heart broken, you’re not going to really understand. That was something I didn’t allow myself until transition.”

During production, “I remember talking to Hannah about this particular joy of first love post-transition with somebody who saw me as me. If little me could feel what I’m feeling

See **CAMP MIASMA**, **Page 2D**



Kris (Einbinder, left) has hang-ups about sex until she meets Billy (Gillian Anderson). PROVIDED BY RYAN PLUMMER/MUBI

STREAMING

‘Pitt’ star draws on ADHD to play Mel

Bryan Alexander
USA TODAY

Before even taking on the role of Dr. Mel King in 2025 on HBO’s “The Pitt,” Taylor Dearden faced the most personal decision of her acting career.

The then-little-known actress, daughter of actors Bryan Cranston and Robin Dearden, had to consider whether she was ready to publicly reveal her own ADHD diagnosis by playing the character even she refers to simply as Mel.

Dearden, 33, recalls a pivotal conversation with “The Pitt” executive producer and showrunner John Wells before taking the spotlight role.

“John said something incredibly thoughtful when he asked: ‘Are you ready to metaphorically come out of the neurodivergent closet? Are you ready to represent?’ He said to me, ‘Take the weekend and let me know if you’re ready to be a figurehead for this.’ That really affected me. Because I realized I wanted to see more real portrayals on TV. But I’m also going to unmask myself. Am I ready for that?”

“And after the weekend, I came back in and said, ‘Let’s go.’ ”



Taylor Dearden stars as Dr. Melissa “Mel” King in HBO Max’s “The Pitt.” PROVIDED BY WARRICK PAGE/MAX

Dearden took off as fan-favorite Mel at the fictional Pittsburgh Trauma Medical Center, and the personal gamble paid off. In July, the breakout “Pitt” star celebrated in scrubs with her cast-mates on the hospital set after earning her first career Emmy nomination for supporting actress – part of “The Pitt’s” awards juggernaut as the medical drama led all shows with 25 nominations for Season 2.

But for Dearden, the impact of playing Mel goes well beyond awards recognition. Her nuanced portrayal has given neurodivergent viewers a rare chance to see their own experiences authentically reflected on screen while bringing greater visibility and understanding to a community long saddled with Hollywood stereotypes.

“It means, here’s this group of people who thought they were freaks for so long,” Dearden says. “So many people see themselves in Mel. So that’s very special.”

Dearden didn’t know that when first reading for Mel, a character who still has not expressed a specific diagnosis, the character was going to exhibit traits of neurodivergence.

“But when I read the scripts, I got the vibe,” she says. “The producers didn’t initially know that I was neurodivergent when I auditioned, but I really leaned into that aspect with Mel.”

When producers later mentioned they wanted to cast a neurodivergent actor for the role, Dearden spoke up.

“I remember that day, because when they told me that I went, ‘Well, you’re in luck, because I’m also *spicy*,’ ” she says.

Dearden has worked closely with “The Pitt” team, including Wells, Noah Wyle and autism consultant Dr. Wendy Ross, to bring aspects of Dearden’s personality to the character, even though “Mel’s diagnosis is different

See **DEARDEN**, **Page 2D**

MOVIES

‘Ice Princess’ preserves late actors’ legacies

Krystie Lee Yandoli
USA TODAY

For 94 minutes, Hayden Panettiere and Michelle Trachtenberg are still teenagers whose dreams are ahead of them, adulthood hasn’t complicated their lives, and the tragedies that would befall them are nowhere in sight.

That’s what screenwriter Hadley Davis sees when she looks back on the Disney film “Ice Princess.”

“When you watch ‘Ice Princess’ for that hour and a half, Hayden Panettiere and Michelle Trachtenberg are kind of forever Gen and Casey,” Davis exclusively tells USA TODAY. “They’re forever high schoolers with their dreams and their lives stretched out before them.”

Released in 2005, “Ice Princess” wasn’t a box office hit, but the coming-of-age movie left its mark on a generation of millennial girls. Now, after Panettiere and Trachtenberg died more than a year apart, fans are returning to the movie, and Davis is seeing the story she wrote about two teenage girls chasing their futures through a different lens.

“It’s really hard to digest the dichotomy between the tragedy of their lives and the feel-good nature of a G-rated Disney movie for young girls,” Davis says. “I think this is part of the reason why it strikes a chord. It does make us all ache for a simpler, kinder moment in time.”

‘Ice Princess’ is beloved by a generation of fans

In “Ice Princess,” Panettiere plays Gen Harwood, a gifted figure skater whose mother, also her coach, pushes her to compete. Trachtenberg’s Casey Carlyle is a Harvard-bound physics whiz who discovers an unexpected passion for figure skating. Both teenagers find themselves caught between the futures their mothers envision for them and the lives they want for themselves.

Davis came to the project after getting her start writing for “Dawson’s Creek” and “Spin City.” During a meeting with Disney, she was asked to rework “Skate,” a script written by “The Princess Diaries” author Meg Cabot about a young woman hockey player. Davis transformed the premise into the story that became “Ice Princess,” and says she came up with the title, too. Disney greenlit the movie after her first draft and sent it into production.



Hadley Davis bemoans “dichotomy between ... tragedy” of Hayden Panettiere and Michelle Trachtenberg’s lives, and “Ice Princess.” PROVIDED BY RAFY/DISNEY

“This was unheard of then and it’s still unheard of now,” she says. “The movie had some pixie dust on it from the beginning.”

As Davis reshaped the story, she drew from her own adolescence. A serious dancer growing up in Massachusetts, she studied under a former American Ballet Theatre dancer who had daughters about her age. At home, Davis had what she calls an “anti-stage mom” who supported her dancing but encouraged her to go to college.

Those experiences helped Davis frame the themes at the heart of “Ice Princess,” including the girls’ pressure to excel, the expectations parents place on their children, and the desire to choose a future for yourself. Looking back, Davis also sees an aching parallel between those themes and the young actresses who played Gen and Casey.

“The essence of the story in ‘Ice Princess’ is having dreams for yourself that are different from those of your parents. That’s universal and timeless. It’s part of the story of growing up,” Davis says. “It’s not lost on me that [Panettiere’s] character in the movie has a dream to be a normal kid and go to the prom. That’s her arc, and it’s not the arc that she got to live.”

Panettiere and Trachtenberg brought ‘Ice Princess’ to life

For Davis, visiting the film’s Toronto

set meant stepping inside a world that had existed only in her imagination. Panettiere and Trachtenberg ultimately gave Gen and Casey their personalities, transforming the characters Davis had written on the page into the teenagers a generation of viewers would come to love.

“Hayden and Michelle were total pros,” Davis says. “They were funny, heartwarming, and kind of everything I had pictured and more.”

Panettiere was only about 14 when “Ice Princess” was filmed, but Davis remembers her star power already being undeniable and that she brought a maturity to the role – and an unexpected ability on the ice.

“She was not only a natural actress but to everyone’s amazement, she was also a natural ice skater, and everyone was amazed by her,” Davis says. “She had a certain maturity about her. She was actually playing a character slightly older than she was, but that wouldn’t occur to you watching the movie. She was just a star, it was obvious.”

What ‘Ice Princess’ means now

Long before its recent resurgence, Davis has been privy to the film’s cult following.

Before “Ice Princess” was available to stream on Disney+, viewers sent her letters in the mail, and she grew accustomed to the “outsized reactions” from

millennial women who learned she had written the movie.

In 2017 Davis even connected with Zahra Lari, the first competitive hijabi figure skater, after Lari mentioned loving “Ice Princess” in an interview with The New York Times. The duo even went on to write a children’s book together, “Not Yet: The Story of an Unstoppable Skater.”

“It’s a reminder of the reach and impact of the stories we tell in Hollywood, and these are the stories that Hayden Panettiere and Michelle Trachtenberg helped to tell.”

But seeing “Ice Princess” resurface in the days since Panettiere’s death has made Davis think differently about the movie and the two young actresses preserved within it.

“What’s incredible about art is that it’s immortal. It lives on, and the beauty and the talent of Michelle and Hayden are preserved in this movie and in their entire body of work,” Davis says. “It’s a G-rated movie and from that moment in their lives. The complications of fame and adulthood hadn’t factored in yet. There’s just this purity to that.”

Even the movie’s soundtrack has taken on new resonance. Fans have been sharing Aly & AJ’s “No One,” which plays over the opening titles, but Davis finds herself thinking about another song in the film: Diana DeGarmo’s “Reachin’ for Heaven,” which plays during the climactic sequence as Casey competes at Sectionals. After falling on the ice, she gets up and finishes her program.

“It’s an uplifting song about resilience, but now it takes on this uncanny and deeply tragic meaning,” she says.

More than two decades after she wrote “Ice Princess,” Davis could never have anticipated what the movie would eventually come to represent. For the generation that grew up watching it, the film remains a piece of childhood. For Davis, it has also become a lasting record of Panettiere and Trachtenberg when they were young, talented, and still standing at the beginning of everything.

“You write a screenplay and you have no idea what’s going to happen to it, you don’t even know if it’s going to get made. So to have it be such a big part of people’s memories and childhood’s is really special,” she says. “I hope that Hayden’s daughter, if she hasn’t already seen it, watches it. It shows her mother in the most beautiful light.”

Camp Miasma

Continued from Page 1D

now, little me would be like: ‘Oh, awesome. Magic is real.’ ”

For Einbinder, sexuality felt like a ‘performance’

“Camp Miasma” is the first movie for Einbinder since her TV breakthrough in “Hacks,” where she plays comedy writer Ava Daniels opposite Jean Smart’s comic legend Deborah Vance. Throughout the show’s five-season run, Einbinder spent most of her off time honing her stand-up, although when Schoenbrun’s script came along, she was eager to try something new as a performer.

“The film is incredibly relatable to me,” Einbinder says. A self-described late bloomer who was “kind of a prude,” the actress was diagnosed with ADHD as a teen and prescribed a “pretty high dose of Adderall.” Consequently, she felt disconnected from her emotions and body for years. She came out as bisexual in 2016, a year before graduating college.

“I think I realized I was queer first, and then I started to connect more to my sexuality,” Einbinder says. “But still, I wasn’t embodied. I had no practice communicating what I wanted. ... Regardless of gender, we all get used to performance and playing certain roles, and I was doing a lot of performing.”

Schoenbrun similarly shut themselves off from intimacy growing up, although the desire was still there.

“It’s not like I didn’t know what sex was from a decent enough age, but the darkness around it was this thing where you’re not in the right body,” Schoenbrun says. As a result, “you develop this sort of irony pill. My adolescent perspective on sex was just like: ‘Ha ha, you guys are all so dumb! I’m just going to be over here not having sex!’ It’s puritanical in its own way, because you’re denying yourself human experience.”

Schoenbrun won’t let Hollywood ‘steal my soul’ after ‘Camp Miasma’

Schoenbrun and Einbinder were introduced over a Zoom call to discuss the



Jane Schoenbrun, left, with Hannah Einbinder, is adapting the graphic novel “Black Hole” for Netflix.

NATHANIAL GARY/USA TODAY

project and bonded instantly while attending a Godspeed You! Black Emperor concert before filming started.

“It was extremely, ‘Do you wanna go do karate in the garage?’ ” Einbinder says, quoting “Step Brothers.”

“We loved each other,” Schoenbrun adds. “I do my best work if I’m surrounded by people who I feel comfortable being vulnerable around. I was awed by Hannah’s work ethic, but she’s also just really brave and open-hearted. Hannah is the rare person who may be qualified for sainthood.”

“What the heck? Thanks,” Einbinder says. “Listen, I’m just trying to get to those pearly gates and eat a big old hot dog when I get there.”

The actress wants to continue making work such as “Camp Miasma” that she finds funny, meaningful and cool.

Schoenbrun, meanwhile, has been the lone trans person in many industry meetings and finds the state of Hollywood “pretty bleak” right now. They’re now adapting the graphic novel “Black Hole” for Netflix, although they no longer feel the need to chase what’s considered “mainstream.”

“I’m so proud of the things I’ve made, and I’m trying to be like, ‘Anything that’s going to steal my soul from me is ultimately not it,’” Schoenbrun says. “I used to be like: ‘I’m going to start a production company! I’m going to be the trans JJ Abrams and we’re going to totally transform everything!’ ”

“They They Abrams?” Einbinder says, grinning as Schoenbrun laughs. “Sorry, sorry!”

Dearden

Continued from Page 1D

than my own.”

During Season 1, as the cast geared up for the depiction of a mass-casualty shooting, Dearden pitched an idea to Wyle.

“I said, ‘I don’t know if you know this, but there’s this thing with my neurodivergence or ADHD – we’re really good in emergencies,’” she says. “Emergency departments and firefighters are disproportionately ADHD-represented. But I feel like Mel could click in here and filter out the noise. And Noah told me ‘You don’t know how, but that’s really going to work.’ ”

When the shooting victims flooded the ER in Episode 11, Mel became noticeably calmer, more focused and decisive.

The Renaissance Faire-loving Mel’s humor is an especially unexpected reason why the character has become a fan favorite.

Mel also can be screamingly funny, often without realizing it. Her earnest oversharing, unexpected bluntness and tendency to take words literally give Dearden some of “The Pitt’s” best deadpan moments, often from improv.

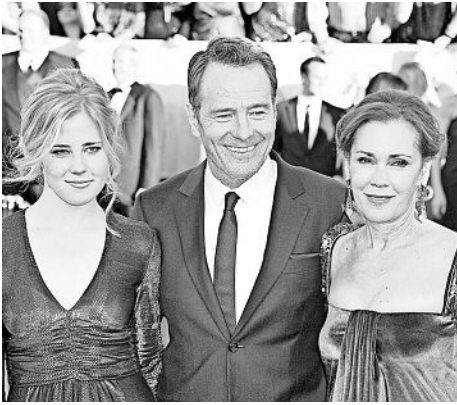
“Often with Mel, it’s that she’s so invested in everything else that she’s not noticing the joke she’s set up,” Dearden says.

“I’ll tell the directors: ‘Just tell me to turn it up or turn it down. But I’ll keep trying stuff. And if it works, it stays.’ ”

What will happen in Season 3 for Mel in ‘The Pitt’?

Season 2 has seen two dominant Mel storylines – a taxing deposition in a medical malpractice lawsuit that leaves Mel increasingly preoccupied, and her relationship with her neurodivergent sister, Becca King (Emmy-nominated actress Tal Anderson), who begins dating despite Mel’s overprotective concerns.

Both storylines will continue into Season 3, now in production, which takes places in November, months after the July Fourth holiday in Season 2.



Taylor Dearden, left, and her parents, Bryan Cranston, and Robin Dearden, arrive at the Screen Actors Guild Awards at The Shrine Auditorium on Jan. 29, 2012 in Los Angeles.

ALBERTO E. RODRIGUEZ/GETTY IMAGES

“Mel’s been acting as Becca’s caretaker, whether Becca wanted it or not,” Dearden says. “Season 3 is going to be a lot trying to figure who she is as herself for the first time.

“We’ll see her trying to be her own person with her own friends.”

Viewers already got a glimpse of how this could play out during the blowout final Season 2 scene – a tiki bar karaoke post-shift outing with Dr. Trinity Santos (Isa Briones), offering a rare “Pitt” look at any character outside the hospital walls.

“It was so weird. They created this tiki bar nowhere close to the hospital set. It felt so odd,” Dearden says of the early morning shoot, which saw Broadway star Briones deliberately holding back vocally for TV.

“Before we shot, Isa said, ‘I don’t think Santos is a great singer.’ I was like, ‘Oh, thank God!’ Because otherwise, that would have sucked. If Isa and Taylor ever went out to karaoke, I wouldn’t sing at all.”

Both actresses pulled off the hair-flipping, tension-relieving version of Alanis Morissette’s ’90s rage-anthem “You Oughta Know,” putting an exclamation mark ending on “The Pitt” Season 2.

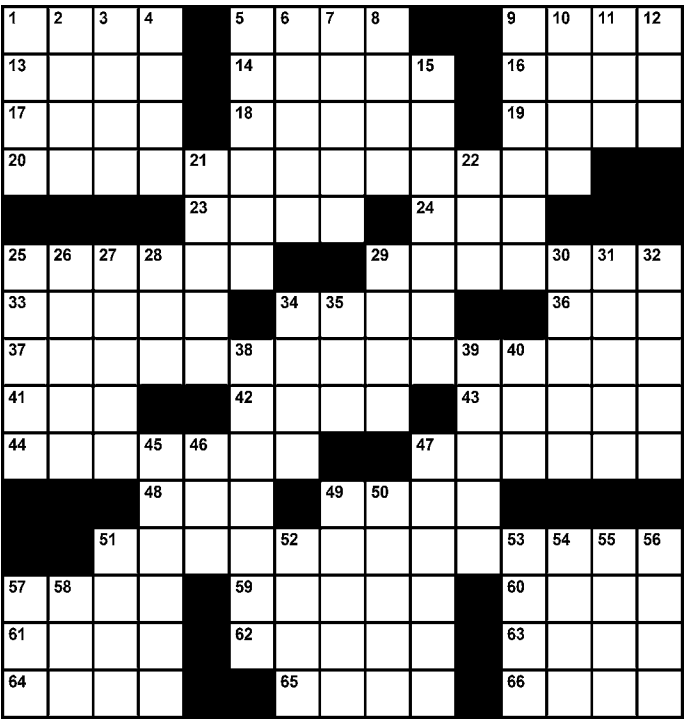
“We got ourselves hyped up, and we did the song twice,” Dearden says. “And the director was like: ‘Yep, we got it. We’re good.’ It was a blast.”

USA TODAY CROSSWORD

EDITED Amie Walker
BY Ron Ammirante

BURY THE LEDE

- ACROSS
- 1 Big name in luxury perfumes
- 5 "Hey, you!"
- 9 Woodwind instrument featured in "Kiss From a Rose"
- 13 Snowballs or water balloons
- 14 Vanish into the ____
- 16 Radiologist's image
- 17 Palindromic address with an apostrophe
- 18 "Mystical Magical" singer Benson
- 19 Olden times
- 20 Offerings at many hotel breakfast buffets
- 23 World Cup cries
- 24 Fib
- 25 Slender
- 29 Left and right turn indicators, e.g.
- 33 Home for an eagle
- 34 "Big Mistakes" character played by Mark Ivanir
- 36 ____ chi
- 37 Charred vegetable often paired with tahini
- 41 Key next to F1
- 42 "Lovely ____" (Beatles song)
- 43 Size above medium
- 44 Scallops, shrimp, etc.
- 47 Adorable ones
- 48 Surgeons' workplaces, for short
- 49 Period in office
- 51 Money put into a bank account via smartphone
- 57 Radio knob
- 59 Great Plains nation
- 60 General feeling
- 61 Move like a sci-fi blob
- Answers: Call 1-900-988-8300, 99 cents a minute; or, with a credit card, 1-800-320-4280.



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8/26

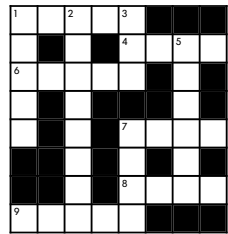
- 62 Identified
- 63 Limbs on cacti
- 64 Fed a line to
- 65 Coin ____
- 66 "It's on my to-do ____" ("I haven't forgotten about that")
- DOWN
- 1 Beavers' creations
- 2 Computer whose original model featured a translucent blue exterior
- 3 Representative Ilhan
- 4 Italy's capital, in Italian
- 5 Tiny rock
- 6 Took without permission
- 7 Loafers and sneakers
- 8 ____ to (take care of)
- 9 Element in water
- 10 Dudes
- 11 Rower's tool
- 12 "____ of the Tiger"
- 15 Unsteady
- 21 Place to stay
- 22 ____ economy
- 25 Wise people
- 26 Part of a poem
- 27 "Fear of Flying" author Jong
- 28 Rapper ____ Kim
- 29 Super-long story
- 30 Asteroids game developer
- 31 "Tootsie" Oscar winner Jessica
- 32 Web locations
- 34 "____ it my way"
- 35 Doc that gives pet scans?
- 38 Process of wearing away
- 39 Fluff, like pillows
- 40 Back muscle, for short
- 45 "Ha, I ____ you!" ("Gotcha!")
- 46 Spherical object
- 47 Doctrines
- 49 "I love you," in Spanish
- 50 Outer boundaries
- 51 Puzzle with an exit
- 52 Future atty.'s exam
- 53 Shape of some nails
- 54 Apple assistant
- 55 Certain PCs
- 56 Midterm or final
- 57 Physician, for short
- 58 Promise of payment



8/25

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TXTPERT



- Across
1. 64687
4. 3224
6. 34448
7. 8367
8. 6637
9. 48377
- Down
1. 66335
2. 63428483
3. 738
5. 242623
7. 8967

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Today's theme
Mathematics



Use the phone keypad to decode the clues.
For example: 2 could be A, B or C, and 5678 could be LOST



8/25

Numbers

More puzzles: [PLAY.usatoday.com](https://www.play.usatoday.com)
Want solutions? [answers.usatoday.com](https://www.answers.usatoday.com)
Feedback: feedback@usatoday.com



SUDOKU

Complete the grid so that every row, column and 3x3 box contains the numbers 1 through 9 (no repeats).



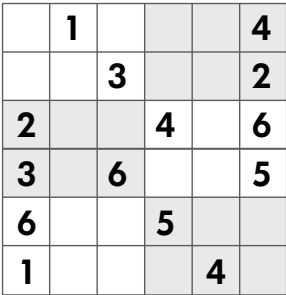
8/26

DIFFICULTY RATING ★★☆☆☆

SUDOKU FUSION
ON YOUR PHONE
puzzles.usatoday.com

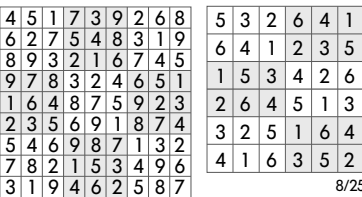
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Complete the grid so that every row, column and 3x2 box contains the numbers 1 through 6 (no repeats).



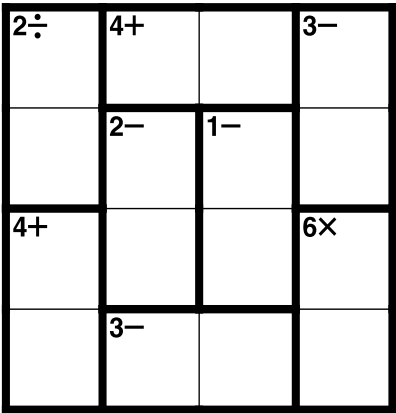
DIFFICULTY RATING ★★☆☆☆

Tuesday's Answers



8/25

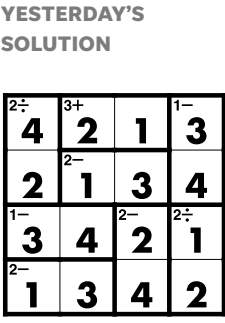
KENKEN



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1. Each row and column must contain the numbers 1 through 4 without repeating.
2. The numbers within the heavily outlined boxes, called cages, must combine using the given operation (in any order) to produce the target numbers in the top-left corners.
3. Freebies: fill in single-box cages with the number in the top-left corner.

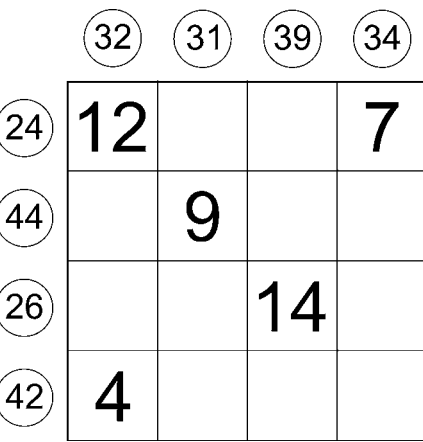


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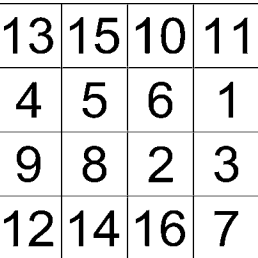
KUBOK 16

By Davide Coppo

Difficulty: HARD



Solution to Tuesday's puzzle



Enter the missing numbers from 1 to 16 without repetitions so that the sum of the four numbers in each row and column is the same as the corresponding circled number.

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8/26/26

Words

WORD ROUNDUP

By David L. Hoyt and Jeff Knurek

- Find and Circle:
Eight world rivers
Six four-letter colors
Three five-letter palindromes
Only one-syllable U.S. state
Five-letter unit of volume

Tuesday's answer: STARLING SPARROW SWALLOW STORK SWAN / SHIFTY NIFTY HEFTY LOFTY / PETER PAUL MARY / PERIOD COMMA COLON / STORMY

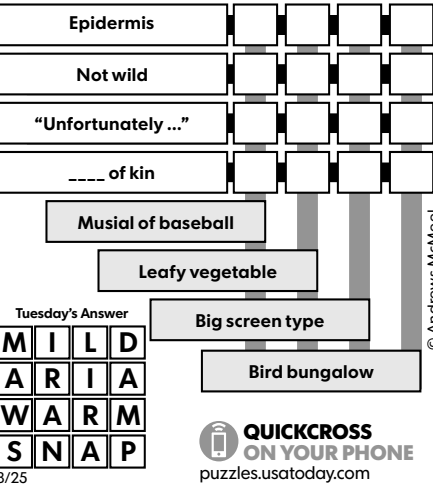
8/26



QUICKCROSS

By John Wilmes

8/26



8/25

QUICKCROSS ON YOUR PHONE
puzzles.usatoday.com

UP & DOWN WORDS

By David L. Hoyt and Russell L. Hoyt

8/26

1. SQUEEZE
- 2.
- 3.
- 4.
- 5.
- 6.
- 7.
- Clues:
1. Many a condiment container
2. Type of firework
3. Spaceflight engineering
4. Intro to Physics, e.g.
5. Type of lawsuit
6. Film packed with excitement
7. Cinema's promotional image
- Tuesday's Answer
- FIDDLER
- CRAB
- APPLE
- TREE
- FARM
- TO
- GO
- CRAB
- APPLE
- FARM
- TO
- GO
- SHOPPING

PLAY ONLINE
[PUZZLES.USATODAY.COM](https://puzzles.usatoday.com)

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BONUS CROSSWORD

ACROSS

- 1 Chopped cabbage and mayo
- 5 Montana city
- 10 Trees
- 14 In — (wholly)
- 15 Seething
- 16 Hardware item
- 17 Orchestra woodwind
- 18 Standards
- 19 Adjust a certain way
- 20 Strutting fellow
- 22 Undermined
- 24 Chimney dirt
- 25 Sink or —
- 26 Office communication
- 28 Relaxed (Hyph.)
- 32 Donated
- 33 Stop
- 34 That girl
- 35 — — shoestring
- 36 Rich cake
- 37 Shoe part
- 38 Show of assent
- 39 Ointment
- 40 Disdain
- 42 Brewed beverage (2 wds.)
- 44 "Present!"
- 45 Lab animals
- 46 Pole on a ship
- 48 Spectrum color
- 51 School-related
- 55 Leaf
- 56 Countrified
- 58 Gas (Prefix)
- 59 Iowa city
- 60 French writer — Zola
- 61 Lantern
- 62 Roster
- 63 In a state of shock
- 64 Do in
- DOWN
- 1 Layover
- 2 Gray wolf
- 3 On
- 4 "Alas!" (3 wds.)
- 5 Dueling instrument?
- 6 Sub (Hyph.)
- 7 Conservative Brit
- 8 Singer Tiny —
- 9 In a different way
- 10 Bury
- 11 Praise
- 12 "Yours, — & Ours"
- 13 Vehicle on runners
- 21 Midday
- 23 Fair attraction
- 25 Fry
- 26 Lesser
- 27 Sidestep

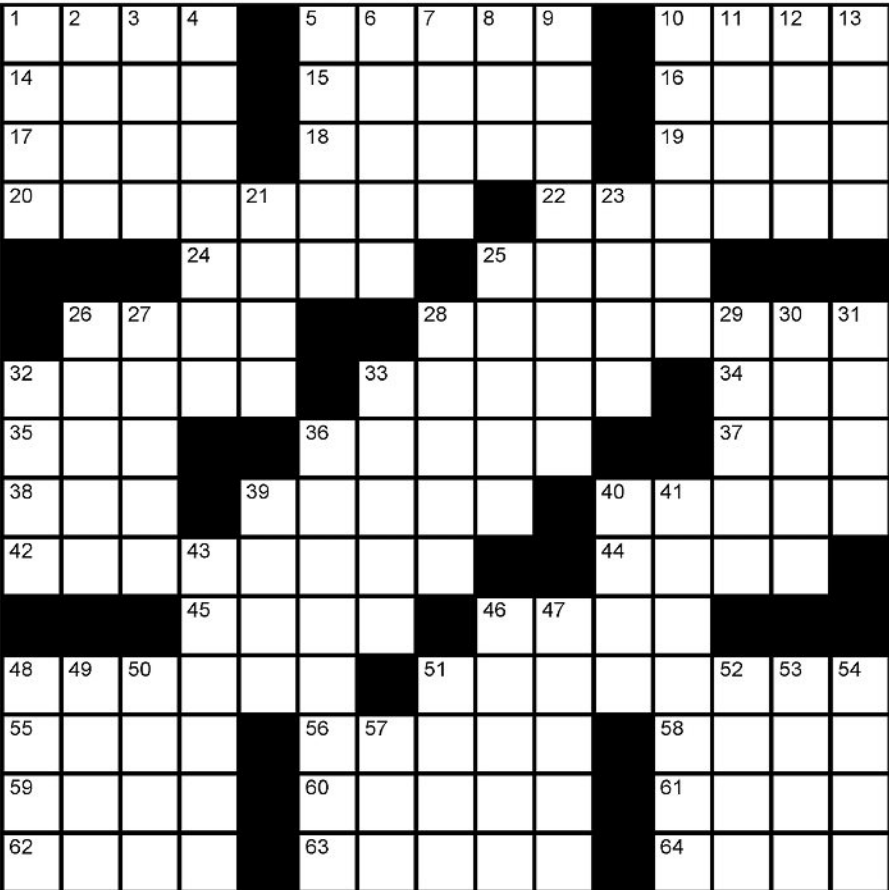
PREVIOUS PUZZLE SOLVED



8-26-26

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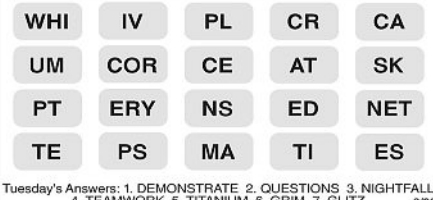
- 28 Insect stage
- 29 John Jacob — task
- 30 Disagreeable
- 31 Sharp
- 32 Large percussive instrument
- 33 Warsaw residents
- 36 Ragged
- 39 Unforeseen problem
- 40 Food fish
- 41 Breakfast options
- 43 Writer — Hemingway
- 46 Climb
- 47 Blanched
- 48 Milky gem
- 49 Actor — Malek
- 50 Times
- 51 State near Nev.
- 52 Breakfast, lunch or dinner
- 53 "— la Douce"
- 54 Duplicate
- 57 Actress — Thurman



7 LITTLE WORDS

Find the 7 words to match the 7 clues. The numbers in parentheses represent the number of letters in each solution. Each letter combination can be used only once, but all letter combinations will be necessary to complete the puzzle.

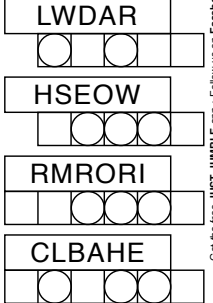
- CLUES
- 1 unironed (8)
- 2 enthralls (10)
- 3 troubles "afoot" (5)
- 4 in need of a shave (8)
- 5 2020 sci-fi action thriller (5)
- 6 spice from a nutmeg (4)
- 7 what a server is waiting for (4)
- SOLUTIONS



Tuesday's Answers: 1. DEMONSTRATE 2. QUESTIONS 3. NIGHTFALL 4. TEAMWORK 5. TITANIUM 6. GRIM 7. GLITZ

JUMBLE

Unscramble these Jumbles, one letter to each square, to form four ordinary words.



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THAT SCRAMBLED WORD GAME
By David L. Hoyt and Jeff Knurek



Now arrange the circled letters to form the surprise answer, as suggested by the above cartoon.

" " (Answers tomorrow)

Yesterday's Jumbles: CROWD FRAME SLUDGE BECOME
Answer: The monsters' baby wouldn't be hideous enough to scare people until he — GREW SOME

MOVIES

‘Downward goat’ left ‘Spa’ star ‘scratched up’

Erin Jensen
USA TODAY

LAS VEGAS – The “Spa Weekend” filmmakers have a bit of life advice. “We hate goats,” says Jon Lucas, making his codirector and screenwriting partner Scott Moore laugh. “Don’t ever work with goats.”

The duo behind beloved comedies such as “The Hangover” and “Bad Moms” have writers’ regret about a scene in their new farce, in theaters now. In “Spa Weekend,” a longstanding group of friends – played by Michelle Buteau, Anna Faris, Isla Fisher and Leslie Mann – try out goat yoga while staying at a resort, where they reconnect and recuperate from their busy lives.

“We didn’t have any CGI goats,” Moore reveals. “They’re all real goats.”

Fisher, 50, says this scene was the most challenging to film, thanks to her unpredictable, four-legged costars.

“It was as if the goats had never seen humans before. They were pooping and peeing and screaming,” she said at the movie’s world premiere at Fontainebleau Las Vegas. “I was happy when that scene was over.”

For research, producer Suzanne Todd attended a goat yoga class, “which was terrifying and smelly and hard, really hard!”

“We went into it thinking it was going to be this magical goat thing,” Todd says, predicting the goats would intuitively apply a bit of pressure at the appropriate time, like an instructor. “None of that from the goats, none at all!”

“When they would stand on your back, it’s actually really hard because the goat is heavy, and those hooves are sharp!”

Moore remembers Mann handling the goats like a champion, while clad only in yoga attire.

“It was her bare back with these hooves,” he says. “And every time I’m like, ‘Oh, my God. We’re scratching up her back.’ Leslie did not complain. She was just in it.”

Mann, 54, smiles while recalling the experience at the premiere, where she wore a strapless, vintage gown embellished with stones.

“The goats were a lot older than they



Filming a scene set in a goat yoga class proved challenging for Michelle Buteau, from left, Leslie Mann, Isla Fisher and Anna Faris, thanks to the unpredictable animals. PHOTOS PROVIDED BY VINCE VALITUTTI/BLACK BEAR



The “Spa Weekend” costars bonded over their work with animal actors.

said they were going to be, so they were large, like full-grown goats,” Mann says. They “liked to climb on our backs, and I was scratched up and bruised, but it was fun.”

Injuries are nothing new for the leading ladies, who have “all been in the world of comedy for so long,” Faris says in an interview with her costars.

“I remember in ‘George of the Jungle,’ being in a scene with a lion!” Mann says, astonishing her costars.

In the 1997 film, the title character (Brendan Fraser) tussles with the beast before rescuing Ursula (Mann). The actress says the lion wasn’t sedated and had a “trainer guy off to the side. But the lion could reach me before the trainer guy could” intervene.

“Leslie, I feel that experience,” Faris, 49, says, “because doing those ‘Scary Movies,’ early on, back in the day, it was like, ‘Oh, they don’t mind if I drown? Uh, OK.’ ”

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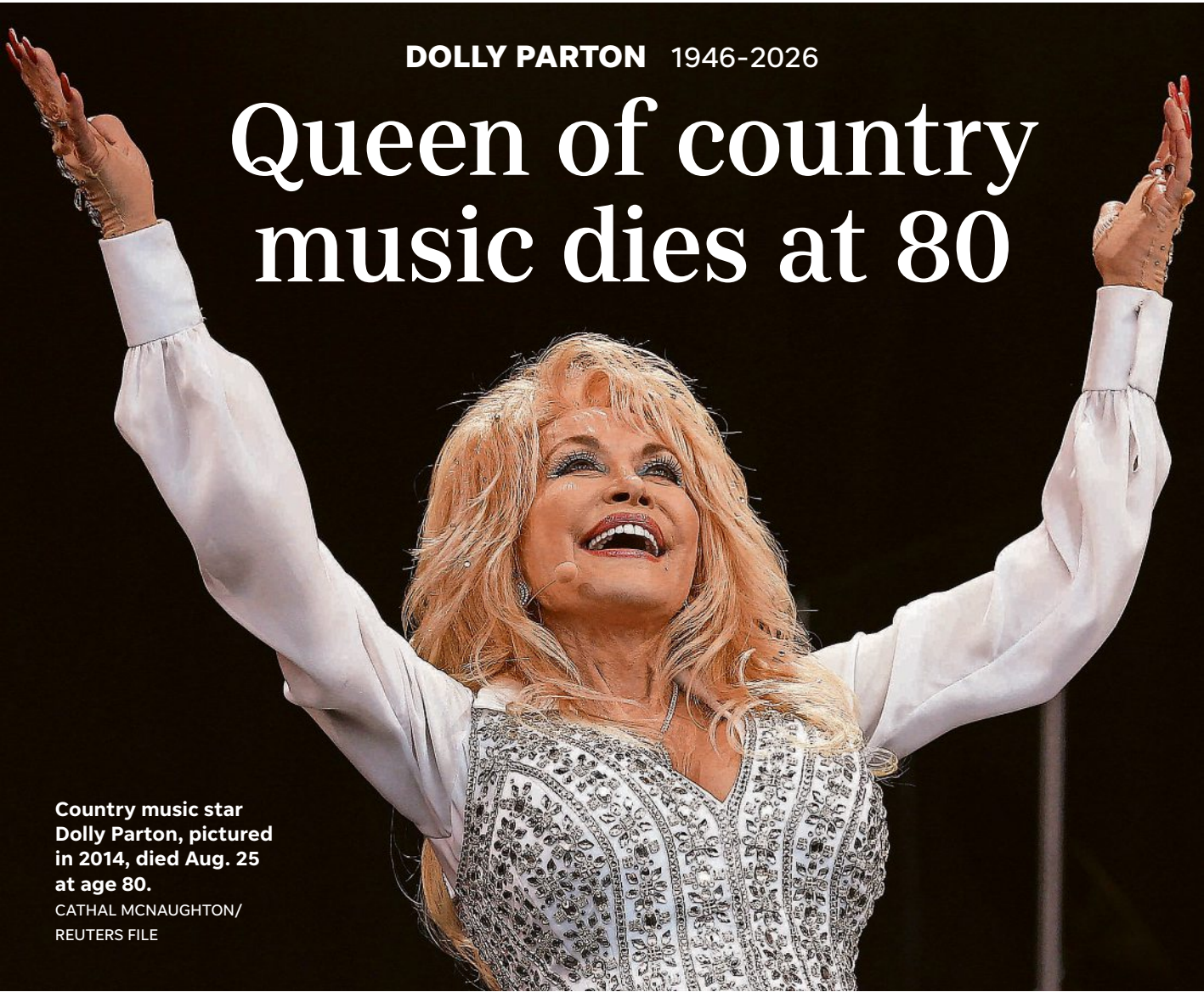
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NATION&WORLDEXTRA



Singer and songwriter captured the public’s imagination with her charisma, heartfelt lyrics

REUTERS

Dolly Parton was around 6 when she wrote her first song: “Little Tiny Tassel-top,” an ode to her corncob doll with corn-silk hair. Her mother stored it preciously in a shoebox. • “I loved that little doll,” Parton wrote decades later. “I expressed myself and my feelings through writing — I’m sure what I was thinking was, ‘Well, Tasseltop has to have a song about her.’ ” • Parton never stopped making music after that.

The irrepressible country music singer, songwriter and actress whose charisma, heartfelt lyrics and business acumen captured the public’s imagination for nearly six decades, died on Aug. 25 aged 80, her family said in a statement.

No cause of death was disclosed, but her publicist said she died peacefully in Nashville. Days earlier, she told People magazine she was dealing with unspecified health issues but planned to keep working.

“By her example, we believed anything was possible,” her nephew Bryan Seaver said in a video message. “She never saw a door she couldn’t open, and the doors she opened made and changed history.”

With classic songs including “Coat of Many Colors,” “Jolene” and “I Will Always Love You,” Parton became one of the best-selling female artists of all time, with over 100 million records sold. She won 11 Grammy awards, including a Lifetime Achievement Award.

Parton’s wholesome personality, combined with her towering blond hairdos, flamboyant costumes and giddy delight at holding center stage, endeared her to Americans of all backgrounds and helped introduce country music to international audiences.



Over the years, Parton hosted a TV variety show, starred in movies and even created a theme park, Dollywood, a popular tourist spot in her home state of Tennessee — all in addition to her lauded work as a songwriter.

But the quality that gave her enduring star power was her ability to connect with people. Coming from a self-described “dirt-poor” family, Parton

Flowers lie at Parton’s star on the Hollywood Walk of Fame after it was announced that the country music icon died Aug. 25.

MARIO ANZUONI/REUTERS

See **PARTON**, Page 5NN

Survey: Dems leading on costs

Party’s edge on issue is troubling sign for GOP

Jason Lange and Nathan Layne
REUTERS

WASHINGTON — Democrats have gained a significant edge over Republicans in voter perceptions on which party has a better approach to the cost of living, a troubling sign for President Donald Trump’s party heading into the midterm elections, a Reuters/Ipsos poll found.

The four-day poll, completed on Aug. 24, asked 951 registered voters which party had a better plan or approach for handling the cost of living. Thirty-six percent picked Democrats and 28% picked Republicans. The rest weren’t sure or said neither party was good on the matter.

The 8-point gap was the biggest Democratic advantage since Reuters/Ipsos began asking the question in October 2025. Democrats started having tiny advantages on the subject after Trump launched a war on Iran in February that has pushed gasoline prices near record highs.

“I don’t think it’s great for Republicans,” said Republican political consultant Jeanette Hoffman.

But Hoffman said Democrats don’t come out looking that much better considering that a significant slice of the survey — 37% — said they weren’t sure which party was better or that neither was.

“I would rather be eight points ahead on the issue versus eight points down. But I don’t think Democrats should be feeling great about it either,” Hoffman said.

Congress up for grabs

Voters all year have signaled the cost of living will be the most important factor for how they vote in November, when the entire U.S. House of Representatives and 35 U.S. Senate seats will be up for grabs.

Several Democratic candidates are

See **SURVEY**, Page 5NN



ANGELA WEISS/AFP VIA GETTY IMAGES

Iraq shows how U.S. may squeeze Iran’s trade



U.S. Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent on Aug. 24 announced “an economic onslaught” against Iran with sanctions.

EVELYN HOCKSTEIN/REUTERS

Bessent has warned of ‘economic onslaught’

Michael Georgy
REUTERS

DUBAI — Iraq could serve as an example of how the United States could carry out its threat to force countries that continue trading with Iran out of the dollar-based financial system.

Washington has already sanctioned a host of Iraqi banks accused of doing business with Tehran, though it has

avoided measures that would devastate the economy of the strategic ally of both countries.

President Donald Trump has warned that any country that provides Iran with an economic lifeline would face severe consequences. That could put Iran’s main trading partners of recent years in the frame: China, the United Arab Emirates, Turkey, India, Pakistan and Oman.

U.S. Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent on Aug. 24 announced “an economic onslaught” against Iran with sanctions, saying that Tehran’s trading partners would be targeted, without

naming them.

How the United States influences the Iraqi economy

The United States, since its 2003 invasion of Iraq, has held effective control over the country’s oil revenue dollars, primarily through the Federal Reserve Bank of New York, giving Washington extraordinary leverage over Baghdad’s affairs.

A rare ally of both the United States

See **IRAQ**, Page 4NN



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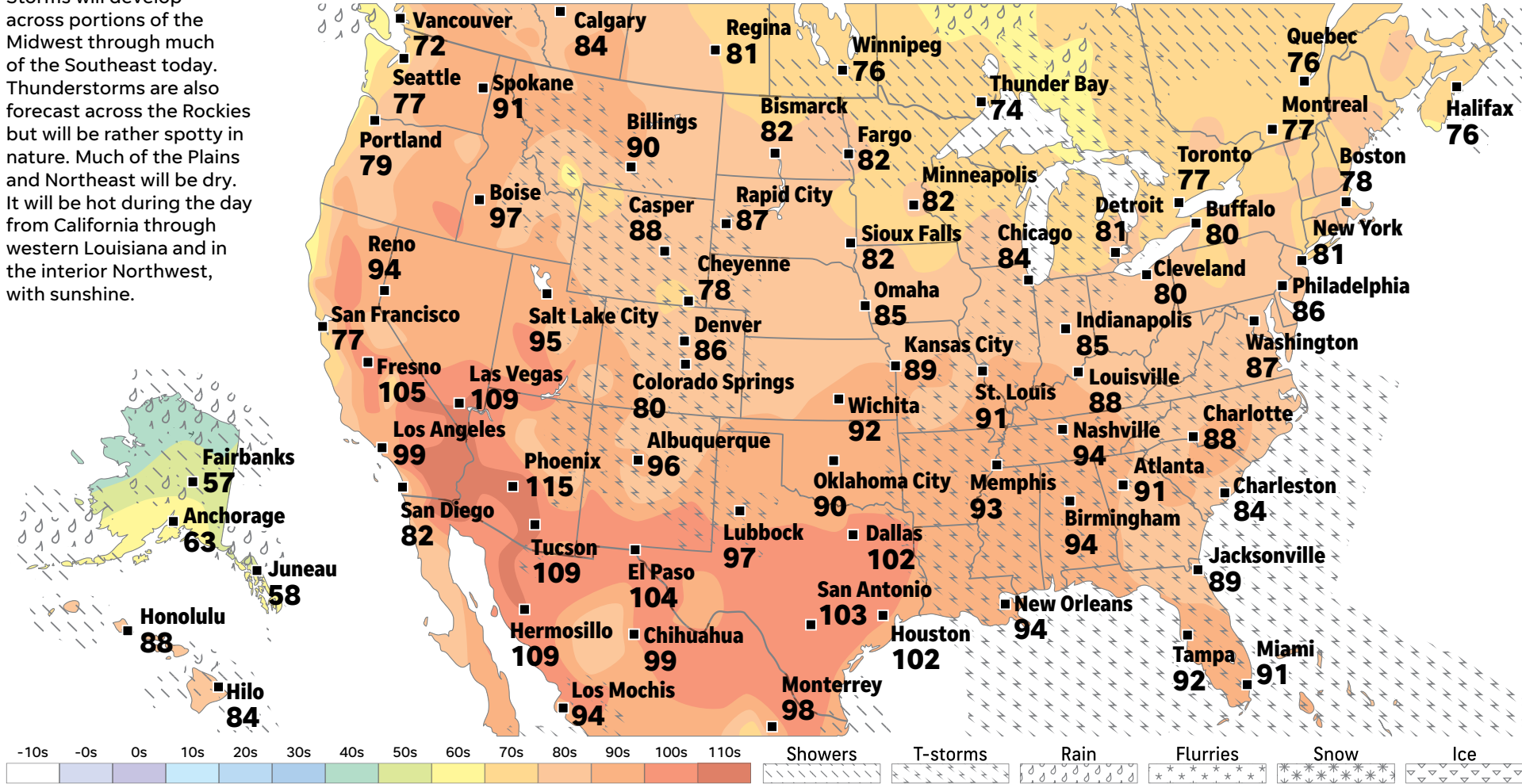
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NATIONAL SUMMARY

Storms will develop across portions of the Midwest through much of the Southeast today. Thunderstorms are also forecast across the Rockies but will be rather spotty in nature. Much of the Plains and Northeast will be dry. It will be hot during the day from California through western Louisiana and in the interior Northwest, with sunshine.

In the digital e-edition, you can click anywhere on the US map to get up-to-date forecasts, radar, MinuteCast® and more.
Shown are areas of precipitation and high temperatures for Wednesday.



TUESDAY EXTREMES

NATIONAL (for the 48 contiguous states)
High: 116 at Thermal, CA
Low: 38 at Leadville, CO
Precip: 2.35" at Valdosta, GA

INTERNATIONAL (excludes Antarctica)
High: 121 at Ahwaz, Iran
Low: 25 at Shologontsy, Russia
Precip: 4.52" at Minamidaitojima, Japan

TODAY IN HISTORY

On Aug. 26, 1864, a railroad train ran into a tornado 15 miles from Lawrenceburg, Ind. The storm lifted cars off the track, spun two passenger cars around twice and deposited them upside down in a ravine.

WEATHER TRIVIA™

Q: What is the common name for a seasonal wind?

NATIONAL CITIES WEDNESDAY

	High/low/W	Air Quality		High/low/W	Air Quality		High/low/W	Air Quality		High/low/W	Air Quality
Aberdeen, SD	81/51/s	58	● Evansville, IN	91/69/pc	75	Levittown, PA	85/66/s	55	Rochester, NY	80/63/pc	35
● Abilene, TX	103/75/pc	43	Fall River, MA	80/62/s	25	Lincoln, IL	87/61/t	75	Rockford, IL	84/60/c	75
Accomac, VA	84/70/s	48	Farmington, NM	96/64/t	61	Louisville, KY	88/69/pc	75	● Ruidoso, NM	87/58/t	63
● Adrian, MI	79/61/t	25	● Fayetteville, NC	89/71/t	51	● Lubbock, TX	97/72/t	75	Salem, OR	80/55/pc	75
Akron, OH	79/64/pc	75	Fond du Lac, WI	79/59/pc	75	Manitowoc, WI	79/60/pc	75	Salina, KS	88/65/pc	44
Alamogordo, NM	104/73/t	68	● Fort Myers, FL	94/75/t	25	Mansfield, OH	80/63/pc	50	Salinas, CA	81/60/s	39
Alexandria, VA	87/71/pc	53	Fort Smith, AR	99/73/t	55	● Marshall, NC	83/62/t	48	Salisbury, MD	86/69/s	67
Alliance, OH	79/62/pc	75	Framingham, MA	81/59/s	25	Marshfield, WI	76/56/pc	25	● San Angelo, TX	104/73/t	39
● Amarillo, TX	91/66/pc	75	Freeport, IL	82/58/c	75	Massillon, OH	79/63/pc	75	● Sarasota, FL	92/74/t	25
Ames, IA	83/58/s	25	● Fremont, OH	82/63/pc	45	McLean, VA	87/70/pc	53	● Savannah, GA	88/73/t	42
● Anderson, SC	89/70/t	47	Fort Collins, CO	84/57/t	75	● Melbourne, FL	91/74/t	25	Sheboygan, WI	80/61/pc	75
Appleton, WI	81/62/pc	75	● Gadsden, AL	92/70/t	64	● Memphis, TN	93/75/t	67	● Shelby, NC	86/67/t	53
● Asheville, NC	81/65/t	51	● Gainesville, FL	90/71/t	25	Middletown, NY	80/61/s	36	● Sherman, TX	99/74/t	40
Ashland, OH	79/63/pc	75	Galesburg, IL	83/60/c	75	Milford, MA	80/59/s	25	● Shreveport, LA	102/78/t	60
● Athens, GA	89/70/t	51	● Gastonia, NC	88/68/t	67	Milwaukee, WI	83/63/pc	75	Silver City, NM	98/67/t	49
● Augusta, GA	91/71/t	45	● Glen Rose, TX	106/76/t	37	● Monroe, MI	82/62/t	75	Sioux Falls, SD	82/56/s	50
Austin, TX	105/75/s	75	● Gonzales, LA	97/76/t	67	● Monroe, LA	100/76/t	58	Somerset, NJ	78/59/pc	50
Bartlesville, OK	93/64/pc	60	Great Falls, MT	91/59/t	49	● Montgomery, AL	94/72/t	45	Somerville, NJ	83/62/s	50
● Battle Creek, MI	79/63/t	25	Green Bay, WI	79/58/c	75	● Muncie, IN	83/65/pc	47	● South Bend, IN	81/64/t	75
● Bedford, IN	87/65/pc	49	● Greenville, SC	85/69/t	47	Murfreesboro, TN	92/69/t	51	● Spartanburg, SC	86/67/t	47
Binghamton, NY	76/62/pc	47	Hackensack, NJ	83/68/s	50	● Naples, FL	92/76/t	75	Springfield, IL	88/62/t	75
● Bluffton, SC	84/74/t	43	Hagerstown, MD	85/67/s	50	Nashville, TN	94/71/t	51	Springfield, MO	90/65/t	58
Bremerton, WA	77/54/pc	58	● Hattiesburg, MS	97/75/t	42	Neptune, NJ	79/70/s	50	● St. Augustine, FL	88/73/t	75
Brockton, MA	81/59/s	25	● Henderson, KY	90/68/pc	75	New Bedford, MA	80/61/s	25	St. Cloud, MN	80/54/pc	53
● Brownwood, TX	104/74/s	40	● Hendersonville, NC	81/64/t	51	● New Bern, NC	87/72/t	45	St. George, UT	106/77/s	25
Burlington, IA	84/63/pc	44	Herkimer, NY	79/59/pc	24	New Philadelphia, OH	79/62/pc	75	● Staunton, VA	84/62/t	45
● Burlington, NC	88/68/t	51	● Hillsdale, MI	78/61/t	25	Newark, OH	80/62/pc	58	Stevens Point, WI	79/57/pc	25
Burlington, VT	80/62/pc	35	● Holland, MI	79/64/t	75	Newton, NJ	80/61/s	50	Stockton, CA	100/65/pc	44
Cambridge, OH	81/62/pc	47	● Hornell, NY	81/59/pc	33	New York, NY	81/70/s	50	Stroudsburg, PA	81/63/s	50
Camdenton, MO	88/64/t	42	● Houma, LA	93/76/t	58	Norwich, CT	80/60/s	44	● Stuart, FL	89/77/t	75
Canandaigua, NY	81/63/pc	47	● Howell, MI	79/61/t	75	● Ocala, FL	92/73/t	75	● Sturgis, MI	78/61/t	25
Canton, OH	79/63/pc	75	Hutchinson, KS	90/64/pc	45	Oklahoma City, OK	90/72/pc	85	● Tallahassee, FL	89/72/t	75
● Carlsbad, NM	104/74/s	68	Hyannis, MA	77/65/s	25	● Opelousas, LA	98/76/t	55	● Thibodaux, LA	95/76/t	58
Chambersburg, PA	83/65/s	50	● Indianapolis, IN	85/66/pc	75	Oshkosh, WI	80/61/pc	75	Topeka, KS	89/61/pc	50
Cherry Hill, NJ	85/68/s	55	Iowa City, IA	85/63/pc	62	● Palm Beach, FL	88/81/t	25	● Tuscaloosa, AL	95/74/t	97
Cincinnati, OH	84/65/pc	75	Ithaca, NY	78/62/pc	47	Palm Springs, CA	113/89/s	90	Utica, NY	78/60/pc	28
Clarksville, TN	93/70/t	51	● Jackson, MS	98/75/t	51	● Panama City, FL	89/77/t	75	Ventura, CA	79/68/s	62
● Coldwater, MI	78/60/t	25	● Jackson, TN	90/70/t	53	Pekin, IL	86/62/t	75	Victorville, CA	106/71/s	80
Columbus, OH	83/65/pc	58	● Jacksonville, FL	89/72/t	75	● Pensacola, FL	90/77/t	75	Vineland, NJ	84/66/s	50
Corning, NY	80/58/pc	32	● Jacksonville, NC	86/73/t	45	Peoria, IL	85/63/t	75	Visalia, CA	103/67/s	115
Corpus Christi, TX	100/76/s	75	Kent, OH	79/62/pc	75	Petersburg, VA	89/68/s	50	Washington, DC	87/73/pc	53
● Daytona Beach, FL	90/73/t	25	Kewanee, IL	83/58/pc	75	Phoenix, AZ	115/91/pc	104	Watertown, SD	80/53/s	64
Deming, NM	104/73/t	56	Keyser, WV	85/61/s	50	● Port Huron, MI	80/63/t	47	Wausau, WI	78/57/c	25
● DeRidder, LA	99/77/t	58	● Kinston, NC	89/70/t	50	Portsmouth, NH	81/63/s	25	Waynesboro, PA	83/66/s	50
Des Moines, IA	84/63/pc	25	Knoxville, TN	89/69/t	51	Poughkeepsie, NY	81/63/s	36	White Plains, NY	81/66/s	41
● Detroit, MI	81/66/t	75	● Lafayette, IN	84/63/t	43	Providence, RI	80/64/s	44	● Wichita Falls, TX	99/73/c	70
Devils Lake, ND	78/51/c	78	● Lafayette, LA	97/78/t	55	● Pueblo, CO	87/58/t	75	Wilmington, DE	85/69/s	67
Dover, NH	81/59/s	25	● Lakeland, FL	94/73/t	25	Quincy, MA	80/62/s	25	● Wilmington, NC	85/72/t	45
El Paso, TX	104/76/s	75	● Lansing, MI	79/63/t	25	Redding, CA	98/63/s	38	Wisconsin Rapids, WI	78/55/pc	25
Elmira, NY	81/58/pc	33	Las Cruces, NM	102/71/t	49	Reno, NV	94/62/s	25	Wooster, OH	79/62/pc	75
Erie, PA	81/65/s	54	Lebanon, PA	83/64/s	59	Ravenna, OH	79/61/pc	75	Worcester, MA	77/62/s	25
Eugene, OR	81/56/pc	25	● Leesburg, FL	92/73/t	25	● Richmond, IN	82/63/pc	67	York, PA	83/67/s	59

Air Quality Index: 0-50, Good; 51-100, Moderate; 101-150, Unhealthy for sensitive groups; 151-200, Unhealthy; 201-300, Very unhealthy; 301-500, Hazardous

INTERNATIONAL CITIES

	Wednesday High/low/W	Thursday High/low/W		Wednesday High/low/W	Thursday High/low/W		Wednesday High/low/W	Thursday High/low/W		Wednesday High/low/W	Thursday High/low/W
Acapulco	92/79/pc	91/78/t	Cape Town	77/53/c	76/52/c	La Paz	62/31/s	65/33/s	San Jose	84/71/r	85/72/t
Addis Ababa	71/55/r	77/55/sh	Caracas	91/77/r	91/77/r	Lagos	84/76/r	84/77/r	● San Salvador	90/69/r	92/69/t
Algiers	99/75/pc	96/73/s	Casablanca	85/61/s	83/67/pc	Lima	77/69/s	76/68/s	● Santiago	57/46/sh	62/43/r
Amman	97/74/s	96/75/s	● Colombo	86/79/r	87/79/r	Lisbon	74/63/sh	73/61/pc	● Sao Paulo	72/61/c	82/66/t
● Amsterdam	77/64/pc	81/64/c	Copenhagen	71/56/pc	71/61/pc	● London	80/65/sh	76/59/sh	Sarajevo	88/58/t	95/65/s
Ankara	92/65/s	92/63/s	Damascus	102/66/s	102/67/s	Madrid	85/63/pc	77/54/sh	Shanghai	93/82/s	92/81/sh
Asuncion	91/72/s	96/77/s	Dublin	69/58/sh	66/58/sh	Manila	92/80/r	88/78/t	Singapore	90/81/t	90/80/t
Athens	96/78/s	97/77/s	Geneva	84/61/pc	84/65/t	Mexico City	76/56/r	77/58/c	Stockholm	71/44/pc	70/48/pc
Auckland	63/51/pc	65/53/pc	Guatemala City	82/62/t	81/62/t	Milan	88/71/t	90/72/t	Sydney	65/58/sh	65/49/pc
Baghdad	119/93/pc	116/88/s	● Hanoi	91/79/r	89/80/r	● Mombasa	85/71/r	86/70/r	Taipei	88/78/sh	93/82/r
● Bangkok	93/81/r	93/81/r	Harare	81/49/s	77/46/pc	● Montevideo	63/54/pc	59/48/sh	Tegucigalpa	86/68/t	87/68/t
Beijing	80/71/sh	86/68/r	● Havana	94/73/r	93/73/r	Montreal	77/62/pc	81/63/t	Tehran	99/80/pc	100/81/pc
Beirut	89/78/s	89/78/s	Helsinki	66/58/pc	66/57/pc	Moscow	64/50/sh	67/51/c	Tokyo	94/80/pc	86/78/t
Belgrade	87/64/s	92/68/s	● Hong Kong	89/82/t	89/83/sh	New Delhi	81/56/pc	79/56/pc	Toronto	77/66/pc	79/58/t
Berlin	76/57/s	81/62/s	● Jakarta	92/76/sh	92/76/sh	New Dubai	91/80/t	95/82/t	Tunis	112/81/s	116/83/s
Bogota	67/50/r	68/49/r	Jerusalem	91/71/s	91/71/s	Panama City	90/76/t	90/76/t	Vancouver	72/60/pc	69/56/sh
Brussels	78/62/pc	82/63/t	Johannesburg	76/47/pc	69/45/pc	● Paris	84/65/pc	81/62/t	Vienna	81/60/pc	86/66/s
Bucharest	82/66/pc	82/63/sh	Kabul	90/65/pc	91/66/pc	Port-au-Prince	101/74/pc	98/74/pc	Warsaw	73/53/s	76/54/s
Budapest	85/60/pc	87/62/pc	Khartoum	107/87/pc	105/85/pc	Rio de Janeiro	74/70/c	77/68/pc	Yerevan	90/64/s	85/61/t
Buenos Aires	62/56/pc	62/52/sh	Kyiv	75/55/c	72/56/pc	Riyadh	113/85/s	113/84/s	Zagreb	86/61/s	92/65/c
Cairo	101/78/pc	100/78/pc	Kingston	94/81/pc	94/80/pc	Rome	91/72/s	92/73/pc	Zurich	82/57/pc	86/62/pc

● Denotes possible travel delays Wednesday

Weather(W): s-sunny, pc-partly cloudy, c-cloudy, sh-showers, t-thunderstorms, r-rain, sf-snow flurries, sn-snow, i-ice.

MAIL-IN VOTING

Judge chides USPS over rule but won’t block it

Nate Raymond
REUTERS

BOSTON — A federal judge on Aug. 25 declined for now to block a final rule that the U.S. Postal Service adopted at the direction of President Donald Trump that would tighten requirements for mail-in voting, even as she concluded the agency had violated a court order by issuing it.

Boston-based U.S. District Judge Indira Talwani ruled a day after the U.S. Supreme Court lifted one of two court orders she had issued that had prevented USPS from implementing an executive order Trump signed targeting mail-in ballots.

Despite those rulings, USPS continues to be blocked from fulfilling Trump’s directive, and various challenges to the executive order are still playing out in federal courts, leaving the

ultimate fate of the measure uncertain. USPS did not respond to a request for comment.

The legal battles come less than three months before the midterm elections, in which control of Congress is at stake. Tens of millions of Americans rely on mail-in voting, and the rule’s fate could determine whether they face new requirements to cast ballots this fall.

Trump signed his executive order in March after years of calling for tighter rules on voting by mail and pushing the false claim that his 2020 election defeat was the result of widespread voter fraud. Under the U.S. Constitution, states are assigned the role of administering federal elections.

Talwani had issued rulings in two different cases blocking implementation of Trump’s order, first in a case by 23 states mostly led by Democrats — the case the Supreme Court addressed —

and then later in a lawsuit by voting rights groups including the League of Women Voters.

The Supreme Court, which has a 6-3 conservative majority, on Aug. 24 put one of those decisions on hold, saying a challenge by Democratic-led states had been premature as courts “review final rules, not proposed rules — and certainly not antecedent internal directives to propose a rule.”

But the injunction the voting rights groups obtained remained in place even after the Supreme Court ruled, and they had urged Talwani to conclude USPS flouted it when it released a final version of the rule on Aug. 21 that implemented Trump’s order.

That rule would require states to provide USPS with lists of voters who received mailed ballots and provide unique barcodes applied to outbound and return ballot mail envelopes.

Talwani, an appointee of Democratic President Barack Obama, on Aug. 25 agreed, saying USPS had “feigned compliance” with her ruling and ignored her explicit directive to not initiate or complete rulemaking in order to fulfill Trump’s executive order. But she said that given that USPS acknowledges it cannot implement its rule while her injunction remains in place, she would not order it blocked at this time.

States including California as well as arms of the Democratic Party have separately announced plans to continue challenging Trump’s executive order.

“The president has not been given power he never had — and Americans should not be discouraged from using a secure and widely trusted way to cast their ballots because of misleading headlines,” Celina Stewart, the head of the League of Women Voters, said in a statement.

Instagram head testifies at trial

Denies encouraging suppression of risks

Greg Bensinger, Diana Novak Jones and Jonathan Stempel
REUTERS

OAKLAND, CA — The top executive at Instagram denied encouraging employees or knowing of a company policy to keep negative information away from the public, testifying at a trial on Aug. 25 over whether Meta Platforms designed Instagram and Facebook to addict children without proper regard for their safety.

Adam Mosseri, the head of Instagram since 2018, is a central witness in the lawsuit by 29 states, in what experts call the biggest legal test yet of social media’s effects on young users.

Four of the states — California, Colorado, Kentucky and New Jersey — have accused Meta of designing the platforms to hook young users, fueling anxiety, depression and even suicide, while misleading consumers about their safety.

All 29 states say Meta violated federal law by improperly collecting and using personal data of children under 13 while they used its platforms.

The states have indicated they could seek nearly \$200 billion in civil penalties.

On the trial’s fourth day, Mosseri rejected a suggestion by Jason Slothoubler, a lawyer for Colorado, that he knew of an alleged Meta policy for lawyers to review internal presentations to scrub information from them, or shield him from problems.

Mosseri said it was important to the public that any information from Insta-



Adam Mosseri, the head of Instagram, leaves the courthouse in Oakland, California, on Aug. 25.
MANUEL ORBEGOZO/REUTERS

gram about children’s safety be high-quality, and backed by experts.

“I am not trying to encourage my team to hide anything,” Mosseri said. “I want to understand how things work. I can’t think of any time that I’ve encouraged people to bring less information to me.”

Mosseri also said Instagram took greater care with sensitive research following the 2021 leak of the so-called Facebook Files by Frances Haugen, a whistleblower who said Meta knew its products were unsafe for children but did nothing in order to pursue higher profit.

Meta restricted access to sensitive research about teenagers to a single team, Mosseri said. “We no longer gave access to people who didn’t work on those projects.”

Meta has rejected accusations it sought to addict children in pursuit of profit, and said its research showed no clear link between adolescents’ social media use and a lack of well-being.

The trial in the Oakland, California, federal court is expected to continue

through much of September.

Jurors are expected to issue an advisory verdict. U.S. District Judge Yvonne Gonzalez Rogers will decide whether Meta is liable and, if so, determine any civil penalties and changes to Facebook and Instagram.

Prior to Mosseri’s testimony, Instagram’s director of product design, Francesco Fogu, testified about a presentation on teenagers’ safety that his team prepared in 2023 for Instagram leadership.

Under questioning from Slothoubler, Fogu acknowledged the removal of data from a slide showing that teenage Instagram users saw 1.5 times more bullying, suicide, hate, nudity and violent content than adult users. He also said Instagram knew that fewer people would use its “take a break” feature by not making it the default setting.

In February, Mosseri testified in a Los Angeles trial where a jury ordered Meta and Alphabet’s Google to pay \$6 million to a 20-year-old woman who said she became addicted to Instagram and YouTube as a child. Jurors found Meta and Google negligent in designing their platforms.

Mosseri disputed suggestions that Instagram did not care about children’s safety, and defended its design choices against accusations by company insiders that its features were harmful. He said Instagram’s products and policies evolve, and “we try to focus on the most important issues.”

Earlier in August, a New Mexico judge ordered Meta to pay \$567 million to address teenagers’ mental health after that state’s attorney general called its platforms a public nuisance. Tennessee is also suing Meta, raising similar claims about Instagram, in a case on trial in Nashville.

TODAY IN HISTORY

- Today is Aug. 26. On this date in:
- 1629:** English Puritan stockholders of the Massachusetts Bay Company said they would immigrate to New England if the company transferred the colony’s government there. The company agreed and appointed John Winthrop governor.
 - 1791:** The steamboat was patented — twice: The United States granted rival inventors John Fitch and James Rumsey patents for different designs. Fitch built steam-powered paddle wheel boats with scheduled trips for the public, but they were expensive and did not catch on.
 - 1843:** Charles Thurber of Connecticut was awarded a patent for the first U.S. design of a typewriter that successfully typed. He envisioned it as useful for people who were blind, “nervous” or messy writers. However, the machine was slow and was never manufactured commercially.
 - 1883:** Mount Krakatoa, an island volcano in what is now Indonesia, entered its catastrophic eruption phase. The major eruption came the next day and was heard as far away as Australia. The resulting tsunamis killed an estimated 36,000 people, and the dust affected global weather for several years afterward.
 - 1918:** Mathematician Katherine Coleman Goble Johnson was born in West Virginia. Her calculations were critical to NASA’s crewed space travel. The Black woman and her colleagues were overlooked until the publication of “Hidden Figures.”
 - 1920:** U.S. Secretary of State Bainbridge Colby certified the 19th Amendment, giving women the right to vote, making it part of the U.S. Constitution. In 1973, Congress designated Aug. 26 as Women’s Equality Day.
 - 1957:** Soviet leader Nikita Khrushchev announced that his country had successfully tested an intercontinental ballistic missile. He gave no details, saying only that it could be fired “into any part of the world.” Americans were alarmed, though some doubted the test’s success.
 - 1959:** The British Motor Corp. announced the Morris Mini-Minor. Soon iconic, the Mini was a major advance in design: The compact car seated four passengers, was inexpensive and had good fuel economy.
 - 1968:** The Democratic National Convention began in Chicago — and with it, massive protests against the Vietnam War. Chicago Mayor Richard Daley called on 5,000 state National Guard members and 6,500 federal troops, according to Time, and the convention was the most violent in U.S. history.
 - 1978:** Cardinal Albino Luciani, Patriarch of Venice, was elected Pope John Paul I. Called the “smiling Pope,” he died of a heart attack 33 days later.
 - 1986:** Jerry Smith, a retired NFL tight end who had played 13 seasons for Washington, announced that he had AIDS. “I want people to know what I’ve been through and how terrible this disease is,” Smith said. “Maybe something positive will come out of this.” He died seven weeks later.
 - 2016:** As a protest, San Francisco 49ers quarterback Colin Kaepernick remained seated on the bench during the national anthem. “I am not going to stand up to show pride in a flag for a country that oppresses Black people and people of color,” he told NFL Media.

FINANCIAL MARKETS

Wall Street ends higher as tech rebounds

Nvidia results to offer read on AI sentiment

Saeed Azhar, Purvi Agarwal and Niket Nishant
REUTERS

NEW YORK — Wall Street’s main indexes closed higher on Aug. 25, as technology stocks recovered from a sell-off ahead of AI heavyweight Nvidia’s results, while investors found some relief in drops in oil prices and bond yields.

The gains could ease investor concerns sparked by a recent bond market rout that lifted yields and pressured equities. They could also help set the tone for September, a historically weaker month for stocks.

Longer-dated Treasury yields fell on Aug. 25 as oil prices dropped to a one-week low and traders continued to weigh the implications of Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent’s decision to expand Treasury buybacks.

“There’s a lot of push and pull – in the bond market, geopolitics, oil,” said Joe Quinlan, head of market strategy for Merrill and Bank of America Private Bank. “But we’re pretty constructive on the outlook [for the] next 12, 18 months on the U.S. economy; therefore, we are constructive on the markets as well.”

Nvidia’s results on Aug. 26 will be the next test for the earnings-driven rally. Any signs of slowing growth could reig-

Oil prices

Brent crude futures settled down \$3.59, or 3.9%, at \$88.58 a barrel on Aug. 25. West Texas Intermediate crude futures fell \$2.65, or 3.1%, to settle at \$82.36.

nite concerns about stretched valuations and how long the AI boom can sustain them.

“This is the classic problem of being the epicenter of the build-out – when you are the trade, execution stops being a catalyst and becomes a prerequisite,” said Mark Malek, chief investment officer at Siebert Financial.

Markets have grown wary of cyclical spending and the methods hyperscalers are using to fund their AI build-outs.

The Dow Jones Industrial Average rose 160.24 points, or 0.30%, to 53,577.40; the S&P 500 gained 24.38 points, or 0.32%, to 7,677.24; and the Nasdaq Composite gained 171.11 points, or 0.66%, to 26,151.30.

Most megacaps closed higher. Nvidia rose 2.2% and Meta climbed almost 2%. Chipmaker Micron gained 2.5%, while the broader chips index ended 1.4% higher after a 2.7% fall on Aug. 24. Advanced Micro Devices rose 4.9% after Raymond James upgraded the stock.

Shares of biotechnology firm Moderna surged 14% after Barclays hiked its target price. The target price increase on Aug. 24 came days after Moderna and

Merck reported late-stage trial results for their jointly developed skin cancer vaccine.

Dick’s Sporting Goods plunged 30.7% after the retailer cut its annual forecasts. Sportswear company Nike dipped.

Target shares fell 3.8% after the retailer apologized for and pulled a Halloween costume criticized for evoking blackface, renewing concerns about brand missteps just as its financial turnaround effort had begun to gain traction.

The Personal Consumption Expenditures report on Aug. 26 could provide greater clarity on price pressures after an in-line consumer inflation reading this month tempered bets on an imminent interest-rate hike by the U.S. Federal Reserve. On Aug. 25, a survey showed U.S. consumer confidence fell in August to its lowest in seven months.

Still, money market participants are pricing in one 25-basis-point rate increase by the end of the year, according to LSEG data.

Against this backdrop, investors will watch Fed Chair Kevin Warsh’s Jackson Hole, Wyoming, speech on Aug. 28 for clues on the central bank’s approach to monetary policy.

Volume on U.S. exchanges was 14.32 billion shares, compared with the 16.4 billion average for the full session over the last 20 trading days.

NEWS IN BRIEF

Judge blocks OH law on proof of citizenship for voter registration

A U.S. judge on Aug. 25 blocked an Ohio law requiring residents to present documentary proof of citizenship when registering to vote at the state’s motor vehicles offices, in the latest setback for allies of President Donald Trump pushing to tighten voter registration rules.

The decision by Cleveland-based U.S. District Judge Solomon Oliver Jr. marked a defeat for Ohio’s Republican government ahead of the Nov. 3 mid-term elections.

Ohio Gov. Mike DeWine last year signed a new law requiring people to present documents such as a birth certificate, a passport or a naturalization certificate when registering to vote while applying for a driver’s license or another type of state identification document.

Advocacy groups including the Ohio Alliance for Retired Americans sued to challenge the law, arguing that it imposed an unnecessary obstacle to registering to vote in violation of the National Voter Registration Act.

In issuing a preliminary injunction on Aug. 25 siding with the advocacy groups, Oliver wrote that having voters attest in writing that they are U.S. citizens was enough to allow Ohio officials to assess their eligibility to vote.

Reports: CIA director travels to Russia for meetings with officials

WASHINGTON — CIA Director John Ratcliffe traveled to Moscow Aug. 25 for meetings with Russian officials, U.S. media outlets reported, citing unnamed sources.

The trip would be the first known visit to the Russian capital by a U.S. spy chief since Ratcliffe’s predecessor, William Burns, held talks with President Vladimir Putin in November 2021. About three months after that meeting, Putin launched Moscow’s invasion of Ukraine.

CBS News and Axios reported the visit by Ratcliffe, President Donald Trump’s CIA chief, who served as director of national intelligence in Trump’s first term. The outlets did not say whom he was meeting or what the talks are expected to cover.

The CIA declined to comment. Kremlin spokesman Dmitry Peskov neither confirmed nor denied the report, telling Reuters that Putin did not plan to have a meeting with Ratcliffe.

U.S. starts returning personnel to Middle East diplomatic missions

WASHINGTON — President Donald Trump’s administration is starting to send personnel back to some diplomatic missions in the Middle East that were evacuated or downsized amid tensions with Iran, two people familiar with the matter told Reuters.

The posts in Lebanon, Israel, Saudi Arabia and Iraq are among those where staff will return, the sources said. Family members will also be allowed to return to the U.S. post in Riyadh, they added.

The move suggests Washington sees a lower risk of the conflict with Iran escalating in the near term, though some embassies will initially operate below full capacity.

The return of some staff is expected to start as early as this week, one of the sources said.

The United States pulled out staff from embassies across the Middle East after joint U.S.-Israeli strikes on Iran began on Feb. 28.

Nigeria’s president orders rescue operation after mass kidnapping

LAGOS, Nigeria — Nigerian President Bola Tinubu ordered the military and other security agencies on Aug. 25 to launch an immediate rescue operation after scores of people were kidnapped by gunmen in north-central Niger State last week.

An armed group posted a video on Facebook and WhatsApp showing what residents said were about 600 women, children and older people abducted during an attack on a mosque in the state.

Reuters could not independently verify the figure, but if confirmed it would rank among Nigeria’s largest and most audacious mass kidnappings in recent years.

The incident highlights Nigeria’s inability to protect swaths of the country where an array of armed groups operate. Any effort to rescue the hostages would be complicated by the gunmen’s knowledge of the remote border areas and ability to hide in the thick bush.

An official from Borgu district, where the attack happened, said 30 people had been killed during the attack and were buried on Aug. 23.

Reuters

Ousted defense minister: Ukraine needs changes to avoid losing war

Max Hunder
REUTERS

KYIV — Ukraine appears to be slowly losing the war against Russia, ousted Defense Minister Mykhailo Fedorov told Reuters, warning that Kyiv has a window of several months to make key decisions needed to turn the tide in its favor.

Fedorov, a young reformer whose dismissal in July sparked weeks of protests, said Ukraine lacked any overall vision for how to win the four-year-long conflict, and was hobbled by its failure to innovate.

Ingrained corruption and patronage networks, as well as a lack of political independence in government institutions, were also holding the country back, he said in an interview.

“I think that there’s now a turning point which will determine our future trajectory, but it looks as though we’re gradually, slowly losing,” Fedorov said in a marked departure from Kyiv’s official rhetoric.

Ukraine still had “every chance” to win but urgently needed a plan to end the war, he added.

Ukraine’s presidential office said in response to Fedorov’s comments that he had been positive about the conduct of the war when he was at the ministry and the only thing that had changed was his personal status.

Lack of interceptors

Russia is hammering Ukrainian factories and warehouses with dozens of ballistic missiles a month, which Ukraine is mostly unable to take down as interceptors run low. Although Russia is gaining less ground than last year, it is still slowly crawling forward in the Donbas, while Ukraine’s sparse front-line infantry dugouts are manned mostly by unmotivated conscripts.

Ukraine, in turn, has ramped up its own drone and missile attacks deep into Russia, hitting some key military factories, causing serious damage to oil refineries and creating nationwide fuel shortages.

A poll conducted at the end of July found 82% of Ukrainians believed Ukraine would win, although most expected fighting to carry on into 2027 or later.

Fedorov, 35, was fired six months after his appointment, having initiated reforms around procurement and mo-



Former Ukrainian Defense Minister Mykhailo Fedorov said it was too early to say if he would run for the presidency. ANATOLII STEPANOV/REUTERS

bilization that put him on a collision course with the military establishment and political rivals.

Last week, he rocked Ukrainian politics by becoming the first major political figure to demand wartime elections, decrying a “systemic” crisis of governance.

In an interview on Aug. 24, he emphasized the importance of developing autonomous drones guided by artificial intelligence, cheap interceptor missiles to stop Russia’s air attacks and Ukraine’s own ballistic missile program to turn the tide of the war.

Ukrainian manufacturers are already working on those technologies, but Fedorov said the country needed a joined-up strategy to maximize their effect once deployed.

He laid out a vision for a front line covered by electronic sensors to detect enemies, with drones on land and in the air to minimize human presence.

“Technologies exist already which could completely stop the Russians, but our absence of vision ... means we do not apply them,” he said.

Fedorov criticized the wasted potential and inefficiency of the Ukrainian state, which he said was operating at “5% effectiveness.”

Budget deficit blame game

Fedorov says he was a driving force behind a drone campaign this year targeting Russia’s fuel and military logistics in the occupied part of southern Ukraine, causing problems for Moscow’s forces on the front line.

He said there was still a window of opportunity of a few months to press ahead with that operation, seeking to isolate Russian-occupied Crimea, before Russia works out how to respond to Ukraine’s tactics.



Mourners carry the coffins of members of the Iraqi Popular Mobilization Forces, who were killed by air strikes that the PMF said were carried out by U.S. and Saudi forces, in Baghdad on July 29. Iran wields considerable military, political and economic influence in Iraq. THAIER AL-SUDANI/REUTERS

on both Washington and Tehran.

“Countries such as China or Turkey have larger economies and more room to absorb pressure. Iraq has fewer alternatives and significantly less financial resilience,” Quilliam said.

“Its vulnerability comes less from the scale of its trade with Iran and more from its dependence on continued access to the U.S.-led financial architecture.”

What are Iraq’s trade ties with Tehran?

Iraq’s trade with Iran topped \$10 billion in 2025, according to official figures, driven mainly by Iranian exports of food and consumer goods to the Iraqi market.

Trade has fallen in 2026 after the Iran war began, raising security risks, disrupting border crossings and increasing transport costs.

Iran has long viewed its neighbor and ally Iraq as an economic “lung” and wields considerable military, political and economic influence there through the powerful Shiite militias and political parties it backs. It has also sourced hard currency from Iraq through exports and has avoided U.S. sanctions via its neighbor’s banking system.

Energy is central to the relationship: Iraq pays Iran \$4 billion to \$5 billion a year for natural gas used to generate

This strike campaign was a significant factor in shifting narratives about Ukraine’s prospects.

Fedorov previously said the campaign’s success was aided by his decision to front-load spending, which had been earmarked for the second half of 2026.

President Volodymyr Zelenskyy — Fedorov’s former political patron turned rival — said over the weekend that bringing spending forward had left a \$27 billion hole in the ministry’s budget, for which donor-dependent Ukraine does not have a solution.

Fedorov said he had no idea where Zelenskyy got this figure, arguing his ministry devised a spending plan that relied on savings from new procurement tenders and international support.

Fedorov alleged that when he arrived at the defense ministry, he found department heads appointed at the behest of Ukrainian defense companies to lobby for their interests.

“By the end of the year, the budget deficit under our planning was around 5 billion dollars, and we knew where we would get it,” he said. “Perhaps the plan changed and new projects emerged that require such a budget.”

Election call

Fedorov’s call for elections was met with dismay from many Ukrainians and polls have consistently shown low enthusiasm for wartime elections.

Zelenskyy condemned Fedorov’s election call, arguing it could destroy Ukraine as it fights off Russia.

Ukraine has, since Russia’s February 2022 invasion, been under martial law which bans elections for security reasons.

The president said Fedorov may be being pushed by outside forces to call for elections. Fedorov staunchly denied this.

While there are enormous logistical challenges to holding wartime elections, Fedorov said that Ukraine would find innovative solutions. However, he said it was too early to say if he would run for the presidency.

In the meantime, Fedorov plans to split his time between his push to restore Ukraine’s elections and ventures focused on innovative military technologies, including an investment fund for which he plans to raise capital during an upcoming trip to the United States.

electricity, Iraqi energy officials say, and officials warn new U.S. measures could jeopardize those payments.

Will any new measures against Iraq be effective?

Iraq has long been an effective sanctions-evasion route for Iran, said Tom Keatinge, director at the Centre for Finance and Security at the Royal United Services Institute.

“As Iran’s connections with the international financial system are squeezed further, existing vulnerabilities will find themselves exploited to a greater extent. In that regard, Iraq, its banking system and its informal financial sector can expect to face mounting challenges,” he added.

He said, however, that an approach based on incentives rather than punitive measures could be more effective. For example, the United States could provide technical assistance for the Iraqi central bank and the broader Iraqi government in “a strategy based on carrots rather than sticks,” he added.

The United States is also wary of wider fallout for the financial system.

Asked why he stopped short of penalizing Iran directly or naming targeted countries, Bessent said: “Why would I want to blow up the global financial system?”

Parton

Continued from Page 1NN

often stood in as a symbol of the working-class American and regularly threw her name and money behind causes she believed in.

In response to the COVID-19 pandemic, Parton donated \$1 million to vaccine research at Vanderbilt University in 2020, making her an early sponsor of Moderna’s vaccine development.

She conducted a literacy program for preschool children across the United States, as well as in Canada, the United Kingdom, Australia and Ireland, and provided scholarships to high school students in the Tennessee county where she was born.

The county erected a life-size statue of her in front of the courthouse in thanks, though she declined another proposed statue of her in Nashville in 2021, saying, “Given all that’s going on in the world, I don’t think putting me on a pedestal is appropriate at this time.”

It was this ability to stay true to her roots, combined with her drive to work hard and her nonpartisanship, that fueled her appeal among conservatives and liberals in a politically polarized America.

‘Mama had this haunting voice’

Dolly Rebecca Parton was born on Jan. 19, 1946, in Pittman Center, Tennessee, and grew up in a one-room cabin in nearby Locust Ridge. One of 12 children of tobacco farmer Robert Lee Parton, her difficult childhood gave credibility to her often personal songs trilled in a distinctive soprano.

Her mother, Avie Lee, would sing constantly — songs from England, Ireland and Wales that told a story. “Mama had this haunting voice, and Lord you would feel it,” Parton wrote in her 2020 book “Dolly Parton, Songteller,” coauthored with Robert K. Oermann.

Parton got her first real guitar when she was 8. Her mother would say, whenever she had guests: “I want you to hear this song this little thing has made up. It’s really good.” Parton loved the attention.

She was singing on a local radio station by age 11, and at age 13 was appearing on the Grand Ole Opry, a weekly country music concert in Nashville.

After graduating from high school, she moved to Nashville to pursue a music career and began a famous partnership with country music singer Porter Wagoner, which would include a yearslong stint on his TV show and 14 top 10 duets. She penned her hit song “I Will Always Love You” as a farewell to Wagoner when she decided to pursue a solo career.

On the first day Parton arrived in country music’s capital, she met Carl Dean, an asphalt paver. They would marry two years later, in 1966.

Throughout their long marriage, Dean shunned the spotlight and did not tour with her, though he would be a muse for many of her greatest hits, including “Jolene,” which was inspired by a red-haired bank teller’s crush on Dean.



People gather at the Country Music Hall of Fame in Nashville to sign a guest book in memory of Dolly Parton on Aug. 25. SETH HERALD/REUTERS



Host Dolly Parton has other stars join her during her hand-clapping country anthem to start the 22nd annual CMA Awards show at the Grand Ole Opry House in Nashville in 1988. CALLIE SHELL/NASHVILLE TENNESSEAN VIA REUTERS FILE

The Dolly image

Her own appearance was the object of intense interest. Initially embarrassed, she eventually found the humor in frequent questions about her extravagant dress sense and generous figure.

She dismissed rumors that her breasts were insured and laughed off periodic rumors that she was bedridden due to their weight, telling People magazine, “Well, they are heavy, but they haven’t crippled me yet.”

Parton patterned her signature look on a woman she would see walking around her Tennessee hometown in tight skirts and high heels, with red nails, red lipstick and peroxided hair.

“I thought she was beautiful. But everybody said, ‘She’s trash!’” Parton wrote in her 2023 book “Behind the Seams: My Life in Rhinestones.” “I laughed and said, ‘Well, if that’s trash, that’s what I want to be when I grow up!’”

But as much as she embraced her signature look, she also viewed it as distinct from herself.

“I look one way and am another,” she told Ladies’ Home Journal in 1982. “It makes for a good combination. I always think of ‘her,’ the Dolly image, like a ventriloquist does his dummy. I have fun with it. I think, what will I do with her

this year to surprise people? What’ll she wear? What’ll she say?”

She also expressed the wish that her appearance would serve to sell, rather than overshadow, her talent.

‘I want to paint a picture’

Her music gained a following not only among the public but also with fellow singers who widely covered her songs — perhaps most famously Whitney Houston’s rendition of “I Will Always Love You.”

Some of Parton’s most beloved covers and duets were with her goddaughter, American pop star Miley Cyrus, and Cyrus’ father, country music star Billy

“At the end of the day, I hope that I will be remembered as a good songwriter. The songs are my legacy.”

Dolly Parton
Writing in 2020 book “Dolly Parton, Songteller”

Ray Cyrus. “Jolene” was covered by artists as varied as Beyoncé and The White Stripes.

While Parton was a force on stage and an accomplished vocalist, what set her apart from her peers was her talent with words. Parton wrote every one of her hit songs. All told, she penned an estimated 3,000 throughout her life, though she recorded only about 450 of them.

“I love to write poetic songs and sing flowery words,” she wrote in “Dolly Parton, Songteller.” “I like to make you see something visually, so I want to paint a picture. And I love to come up with clever lines, not just like a songwriter, but like a poet.”

Parton made her movie debut in 1980’s “9 to 5,” starring alongside Jane Fonda and Lily Tomlin, with the title tune earning Parton an Oscar nomination for songwriting. She got another Oscar songwriting nomination in 2006 for “Travelin’ Thru,” written for the film “Transamerica.”

Her other movie acting roles included “The Best Little Whorehouse in Texas,” “Steel Magnolias,” “Rhinestone” and “Straight Talk.”

Twenty-five of her songs reached No. 1 on the Billboard Country charts, and she was a member of the Songwriters Hall of Fame, receiving its highest honor, the Johnny Mercer Award, in 2007. She was inducted into the Rock and Roll Hall of Fame in 2022.

Parton received her first Grammy award in 1978 for her song “Here You Come Again.” In 1988, she won the People’s Choice Award for favorite all-around female entertainer.

But despite all her accolades and achievements, Parton found the greatest meaning in her art.

“I feel like I’m closest to God when I write,” she wrote in “Dolly Parton, Songteller.” “A great line will just come to me, and I’ll go, ‘Hey, thank You, Lord. I know I didn’t think of that.’”

“At the end of the day, I hope that I will be remembered as a good songwriter. The songs are my legacy.”

Survey

Continued from Page 1NN

making affordability a central issue on the campaign trail.

James Talarico, a Texas Democrat running for a U.S. Senate seat, has appeared in television ads carrying bags of groceries as evidence Texans are “drowning” in higher prices. The message could help Talarico’s chances, and his race is widely seen as leaning Republican or a toss-up in a deep-red state that normally would be a safe bet for Republicans.

But Republicans nationwide still have advantages on other issues like immigration and crime.

Hoffman said Republican candidates in the midterms need to highlight to voters that their party has addressed affordability by delivering tax cuts, while warning that the Democratic Party is growing more extreme as democratic socialists gain influence.

Democrats have called for raising the federal minimum wage, and those aligned with democratic socialists propose making the federal Medicare health insurance program available for all Americans instead of just the elderly and disabled.

For Republicans, losing control of either chamber could complicate Trump’s agenda in the last two years of his term.

While fighting in the Iran war has cooled, Tehran maintains a de facto blockade on oil shipments passing through the Strait of Hormuz, keeping global oil prices high and punishing U.S. household finances. Trump said last

week no peace talks were scheduled.

Gas, food worries

Christopher Nicholas, a Republican strategist in Pennsylvania, said Trump has not done enough to address voters’ concerns about the cost of living, leaving Republicans exposed on an issue that could shape the midterms, and which also weighed on Democratic former President Joe Biden.

“This is an easy layup for the party out of power, which are the Democrats,” Nicholas said.

“Keeping prescription drug prices lower is a good start, but that seems to be getting lost within the overall health care area, in which prices seem to be galloping ahead of inflation every year,” Nicholas said. “Voters feel gas and food prices, which are intertwined, every week when they go to the grocery store and gas station.”

The president’s own approval ratings are at the lowest levels of either this presidential term or his last. Currently only half of Republicans approve of his handling of the cost of living, far fewer than the 8 in 10 who give his presidency a thumbs up overall.

A Reuters/Ipsos poll earlier in August showed voters were picking Democrats over Republicans as better stewards of the economy for the first time in about a decade. The latest Reuters/Ipsos poll showed Democrats with a 2-point edge on the economy.

The latest survey gathered responses nationwide from 1,215 U.S. adults, including 951 registered voters. The poll, which was conducted online, had a margin of error of 3 percentage points.

WEDNESDAY, AUGUST 26, 2026

NEWS SENTINEL

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